

The 40-to of Vipassanā

Seeing Life in Many Special Ways

(First edition)



Sayadaw U Janakābhivamsa

Dhammagonyee Pa-Auk Tawya (Hlegu), Yangon

*“dukkhameva hi, na koci dukkhito.
kārako na, kiriyāva vijjati.
atthi nibbuti, na nibbuto pumā.
maggamatthi, gamako na vijjatī”ti.*

*For there is suffering, but none who suffers;
Doing exists although there is no doer.
Extinction is, but no extinguished person;
Although there is a path, there is no goer.*

Visuddhi.2.144 (Vism.2.16.indriyasaccaniddeso.magganiddesakathā)



Buddhasāsanam ciraṃ tiṭṭhatu

Dhammagonyee Pa-Auk Tawya (Hlegu), Yangon



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Biography of Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa



Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa was born in 1976 in Magway, Myanmar. He was ordained as a novice monk (sāmaṇera) at a monastery in Magway on 16 June 1991 and received higher ordination as a bhikkhu on 20 June 1995 at Atulakari Sinmin Monastery, Phaya Gyi Taik in Mandalay, where he pursued Buddhist Pāli studies.

In 2002, Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa passed the “Sāsanadhaja Dhammācariya” examination conducted by the Department of Religious Affairs under the Ministry of Religious Affairs, Government of the Union of Myanmar. He was awarded the prestigious title of “Sāsanadhaja Dhammācariya” on 18 July 2002. In the same year, he also passed the Pariyatti Sāsanahita Dhammācariya examination held by the Pariyatti Sāsanahita Association of Mandalay, earning the title of “Bhaddanta Janakābhivaṃsa Pariyatti Sāsanahita Dhammācariya” (Abhivaṃsa degree) on 17 July 2002.

The Pariyatti Sāsanahita Dhammācariya examination is widely recognized as the highest academic achievement

in Pāḷi language and Buddhist studies. The "Abhivaṃsa" degree is equivalent to a Ph.D. in Buddhist Pāḷi studies. Notably, among the many candidates who sit for this rigorous examination annually in Myanmar, only an average of three successfully pass and receive the title of "Abhivaṃsa."

In 2002, Sayadaw began his role as an official teacher of the Pāḷi language at Phaya Gyi Taik in Mandalay. From 2007 to 2008, he served as a member of the State Main Committee of Buddhist Education and was appointed as a questioner for the Dhammācariya examination by the Ministry of Religious Affairs, Government of the Union of Myanmar.

In 2005, Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa joined Pa-Auk Tawya Forest Monastery (Main) to learn and practice Samatha and Vipassanā meditation under the guidance of the Most Venerable Pa-Auk Tawya Sayadaw (Sayadawgyi). He deepened his training during the six-month Intensive Meditation Retreat in 2010 and the four-month Intensive Meditation Retreat in 2013, both led by Sayadawgyi. He also spent the 2015 vassa (Buddhist Rains Retreat) in Maymyo, where Sayadawgyi was conducting an intensive retreat for advanced meditators.

Since 2014, Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa has served as the Resident Teacher of the Pa-Auk Meditation Centre in Singapore. Additionally, he is the abbot and meditation

teacher at Dhammagonyee Pa-Auk Tawya in Hlegu Township, Yangon.

Sayadaw is fluent in both Myanmar and English. Over the years, he has delivered Dhamma talks and led meditation retreats across Myanmar and internationally, including in Singapore, Malaysia, Indonesia, Vietnam, the United States, Taiwan, Thailand, South Korea, and Nepal.





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Preface

Vipassanā is a vital practice for realizing *Nibbāna*, emphasizing the contemplation of *anicca* (impermanence), *dukkha* (suffering), and *anatta* (non-self) in all conditioned phenomena. Through this contemplation, practitioners develop Right View to navigate the complexities of life and progress toward liberation.

The Dhamma Talk “40-to” (40 Ways of Contemplation) by Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa offers a comprehensive exploration of these three characteristics through forty methods of contemplation. These methods are primarily drawn from the *Visuddhimagga* and Pa-Auk Tawya’s meditation manual, supported by references from the Suttas. This teaching is valuable not only for dedicated *Vipassanā* practitioners but also for anyone seeking to align their lives with the Dhamma, as it cultivates the Right Knowledge essential for overcoming defilements and realizing *Nibbāna*.

Typically, this teaching is aimed at advanced *Vipassanā* practitioners who can discern the arising and perishing of ultimate mentality and materiality. Without this ability, it is challenging to fully appreciate the characteristics of *anicca*, *dukkha* and *anatta*. However, in this book, Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa has made a commendable effort to explain these forty profound contemplations in a relatively accessible manner, interspersed with anecdotes and practical examples. Even practitioners who have not yet achieved the necessary breakthrough (i.e., the ability to see the arising and perishing of ultimate mentality and materiality) can still benefit from



this teaching. It helps cultivate dispassion toward life, an essential step for realizing *Nibbāna*.

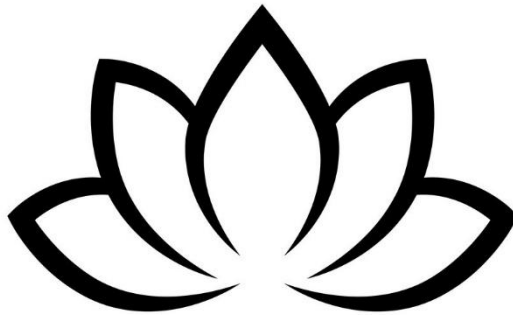
Sayadaw begins with a brief introduction to the practice of *Vipassanā*, explaining its stages, definitions, and importance in perceiving the faults and dangers of existence. He then elaborates on the objects of *Vipassanā* contemplation, particularly *nāmarūpa* (mentality-materiality) and the five aggregates. With this foundational understanding established, Sayadaw explains the forty ways of *Vipassanā* contemplation: ten synonyms of *anicca* (impermanence), twenty-five of *dukkha* (suffering), and five of *anatta* (non-self). The teaching concludes with a summary of the *Vipassanā* practice.

Engaging with this material enables readers to gain a deeper understanding of the true nature of body and mind, fostering a more realistic and Dhamma-aligned self-view.

Sayadaw U Janakābhivamsa originally presented this teaching in three Dhamma Talks at Taiwandīpa Theravāda Buddhist College, Taiwan, in April 2018. He later delivered the same series of talks in Indonesia (August 2019) and at Pa-Auk Meditation Centre, Singapore (September 2019) under the title, “The Path to Liberation – Seeing Life in Many Special Ways.” The original transcript was largely based on the talks in Taiwan, with supplementary inputs from the other two presentations. Sayadaw subsequently offered suggestions for revisions, including additional insights on the forty contemplations, verses and quotations from the Pāḷi Tipiṭaka, and further explanations on topics such as emptiness (*suññā*) and self (*atta*).

In June 2025, during a meditation retreat in Nepal, Sayadaw explained the 40-to contemplations again. On this occasion, Sayadaw also touched on some additional related contemplations found in the subsequent insight meditation stages. These additional contemplations are included as an appendix to this book.

This book is being published in two language editions – an English edition for a wider audience and a Vietnamese edition, translated from the English edition, for Vietnamese readers. Through these publications, we sincerely hope to support Sayadaw U Janakābhivamsa’s tireless efforts to propagate the True Dhamma for the benefit of a wider audience.





Acknowledgment

We extend our heartfelt gratitude to Sayadaw U Janakābhivaṃsa for his endless compassion, guidance, and dedication in teaching us the True Teachings of the Buddha.

We would like to acknowledge:

- Brother JJ (Singapore) for transcribing the talks.
- Malaysian Bhante for compiling and editing the transcript.
- Vietnamese Sayalay for initiating this project and translating the English edition into Vietnamese. Without her tireless efforts, this publication would not have been possible.
- Mr. Danny Chng and the other editors for refining the translation.

We welcome any feedback or suggestions for improvement regarding this book. Please feel free to reach out to the editorial team at dhammagonyee@gmail.com (cc jjthong77@gmail.com).

May the True Dhamma endure for a long time.
May all beings develop respect for the Dhamma.
May the noble aspirations of all beings be fulfilled.
May all beings be free from suffering.



Abbreviations for Source Reference

Abhi	Abhidhamma Piṭaka
Dī	Dīgha Nikāya
Ma	Majjhima Nikāya
Sam	Samyutta Nikāya
Añ	Aṅguttara Nikāya
Khu	Khuddaka Nikāya
Paṭisaṃ	Paṭisambhidāmagga
Visuddhi	Visuddhimagga
Ṭṭha	Aṭṭhakathā
mṬikā	Mūlaṭikā
anuṬikā	Anuṭikā

Examples of Source Reference

Abhi.Ṭṭha.1.175	Abhidhammapiṭaka-aṭṭhakathā Volume 1 page 175
Sam.1.61	Samyutta Nikāya Volume 1 Page 61
Visuddhi.1.171	Visuddhimagga Volume 1 page 171
Khu.Ṭṭha.25.26	Khuddaka Nikāya-aṭṭhakathā Volume 25 page 26
Paṭisaṃ.412	Paṭisambhidāmagga page 412
Khu.1.53 Dhammapade	Khuddaka Nikāya Volume 1 (Dhammapada) page 53
Visuddhi.Ṭikā.2.457	Visuddhimagga Mahāṭikā Volume 2 page 457



The 40-to of Vipassanā - Seeing Life in Many Special Ways¹

Introduction about Vipassanā

Today, I will try to talk about *Vipassanā*.

The *Vipassanā* practice consists of four parts:

1. Discerning materiality
2. Discerning mentality
3. Discerning cause and effect
4. Contemplating *anicca* (impermanence), *dukkha* (suffering), and *anatta* (non-self) in the arising and perishing of materiality, mentality, and their causes.

The 40-to's (40 ways of contemplation)

Among these four parts, I will focus on the last one – contemplating *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anatta*. Many words can be used to explain the meaning of these terms; *anicca*,

¹ This talk is edited based on a series of three talks given by Sayadaw Janakābhivaṃsa during a meditation retreat held at Taiwandīpa Theravāda Buddhist College in Taiwan. For the original recordings, please refer to the following links:

5 Apr 2018: [<https://youtu.be/LyWzbzSZ8mw>]

6 Apr 2018: [<https://youtu.be/EoDnxFtYc>]

7 Apr 2018: [<https://youtu.be/6-xdgn1sOYI>]



dukkha, and *anatta*. Each of these terms has many synonyms. In total, there are 40 such terms that are generally known as the “40-to’s”.

Some examples of these Pāḷi explanatory terms, or synonyms, are *aniccato*, *palokato*, *calato*, etc. They all end in “-to”. (For example, *aniccato* means to discern “as *anicca*”.) Therefore, among meditators, they are generally referred to as the “40-to’s”. These “40-to’s” are 40 explanatory terms for *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anatta* respectively. They serve as synonyms of the three characteristics, explaining the different aspects of the three terms.

Definition of *Vipassanā*

First of all, I will explain what the term *Vipassanā* means.

*Aniccādivasena vividhehi ākārehi dhamme
passatīti vipassanā*²

Vipassanā is a combination of two words: *vi* + *passanā*. The definition of *vi* is *vividha*. *Vividha* means “many special ways”. Not just one way, but many ways. Not just in the ordinary way, but in special ways. *Passanā* means “seeing” or “observing”. However, it is not seeing with the physical eyes, but seeing with the mind, or seeing with wisdom. So, *vipassanā* means **mentally seeing or observing an object in many special ways**. This is the meaning of *vipassanā*.

² Abhi.Ṭṭha.1.175 (Dhammasaṅgaṇī-aṭṭhakathā page 175)

Now we are going to talk about the “40-to’s”, the 40 ways of *vipassanā*. It is to see this body in many special ways—not just to see in one way or two ways, but in many ways; and not to see in a normal way as people would usually see this body, but to see the body in special ways, such as seeing it as *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anatta*.

When we learn about all these ways, it is like cultivating a negative view of life. It is a negative view because we are focusing on life as suffering, as impermanent, as non-self, etc. We aim to develop disenchantment towards life. Without thinking of our life as suffering, we cannot go beyond life—we cannot reach the state that transcends life. Hence, the Buddha said, “Without reaching the end of life/existence/world, one cannot reach the end of suffering.”³ So if we want to put an end to suffering, we need to reach the end of life. This is called *Nibbāna*.

So, where should we look to find *Nibbāna*? The Buddha advised us to look within this body—within this six-foot-long

³ Sam.1.61 (SN 2.26 Rohitassa Sutta):

Na ca appatvā lokantaṃ, dukkhā atthi pamocanaṃ.

Without reaching the end of the world, one cannot be free from suffering.

Añ.1.357 (AN 4.45 Rohitassa Sutta):

“*yattha kho, āvuso, na jāyati na jīyati na miyyati na cavati na upapajjati, nāhaṃ taṃ gamanena lokassa antaṃ ñāteyyaṃ daṭṭheyyaṃ patteyyaṃ’ti vadāmi. na cāhaṃ, āvuso, appatvā lokassa antaṃ dukkhassa antakiriyaṃ vadāmi. api cāhaṃ, āvuso, imasmiṃyeva byāmamatte kaḷevare sasaññimhi samanake lokañca paññāpemi lokasamudayañca lokanirodhañca lokanirodhagāminiñca paṭipadan’ti.*

“I say, friend, that by traveling, one cannot know, see, or reach that end of the world where one is not born, does not grow old and die, does not pass away and get reborn. Yet I say that without having reached the end of the world, there is no making an end of suffering. It is in this fathom-long body endowed with perception and mind that I proclaim (1) the world, (2) the origin of the world, (3) the cessation of the world, and (4) the way leading to the cessation of the world.”



body. Within this body, we can find all Four Noble Truths: The Noble Truth of Suffering, the Noble Truth of the Origin of Suffering, the Noble Truth of the Cessation of Suffering, and the Noble Truth of the Path leading to the Cessation of Suffering.

However, we should understand that it is only figurative speech to say that *Nibbāna* is found within this body. In reality, *Nibbāna* is not inside the body. *Nibbāna* is external to the body. In the *Dhammasaṅgaṇī*, there is a classification of all phenomena into internal phenomena and external phenomena (*ajjhataṭṭa dhammā* and *bahiddhā dhammā* in Pāli). Here, *Nibbāna* is grouped as *bahiddhā dhammā*—external to the body.

However, even though *Nibbāna* is not in the body, we need to take up this body as an object of contemplation. We contemplate the body as suffering, as impermanent, as non-self, to experience *Nibbāna* directly. Because of this reason, despite *Nibbāna* being external to this body, the Buddha advised his disciples to seek *Nibbāna* within this body. Metaphorically speaking, we can say that *Nibbāna* can be found within this body.

Therefore, if we want to find *Nibbāna*, if we want to realize *Nibbāna*, we need to reflect on life/existence with a negative view, such as *anicca*, *dukkha*, or *anatta*. As long as we are happy in life, we cannot go beyond life. If we want to be rich, we should develop a negative view regarding being poor. If we want to have a good education, we should harbor negative views about being uneducated. In the same way, if we want to go beyond life, we should develop negative views about life. Therefore, *Vipassanā* is mentally seeing, or

mentally observing, our body in many different ways to understand the suffering in life.

In some *suttas*, for example in the *Paṭhamasaññā Sutta*⁴, the Buddha encourages his disciples to develop and cultivate the perception of unattractiveness/foulness (*asubhasaññā*), the perception of death (*maraṇasaññā*), the perception of the repulsiveness of food (*āhāre paṭikūlasaññā*), the perception of non-delight in the entire world (*sabbaloke anabhiratasaññā*), the perception of impermanence (*aniccasaññā*), the perception of suffering in the impermanent (*anicce dukkhasaññā*), and the perception of non-self in what is suffering (*dukkhe anattasaññā*).

Are you happy now living where you are? The Buddha said *sabbaloke anabhiratasaññā*, the perception of non-delight in the entire world. We should develop such a perception. In any place in this world, we should cultivate this perception of non-delight. Although beings in the *Brahmā* realms or the *Deva* realms experience very little suffering, they still need to

⁴ Añ.2.433 (AN 7.48 Paṭhamasaññā Sutta):

...*asubhasaññā, maraṇasaññā, āhāre paṭikūlasaññā, sabbaloke anabhiratasaññā, aniccasaññā, anicce dukkhasaññā, dukkhe anattasaññā. imā kho, bhikkhave, satta saññā bhāvitā bahulikatā mahapphalā honti mahānisamsā amatogadhā amatapariyosānā*”ti.

...The perception of unattractiveness, the perception of death, the perception of the repulsiveness of food, the perception of non-delight in the entire world, the perception of impermanence, the perception of suffering in the impermanent, and the perception of non-self in what is suffering. These seven perceptions, when developed and cultivated, are of great fruit and benefit, culminating in the deathless, having the deathless as their consummation.”



maintain their goodness. Once they fail to maintain their goodness, they will lose their seemingly desirable situation.

All of us have been in those realms before. We have been in the *Deva* realms. We have been in the *Brahmā* realms. Now that we are reborn in the human realm and are living in Taiwan, our situation is still good, but we need to maintain this with goodness.

In the sixth *Abhidhamma* book, the *Yamaka*⁵, there is a question of whether there is anyone who will never attain *Nibbāna* (one for whom the Path-Truth will not arise). The answer is that there are worldlings (ordinary persons who are unenlightened beings) who will not attain *Nibbāna*. There are some doubts and discussions relating to this. As it concerns the future with no limit on the time frame, some wondered if it is possible for there to be anyone who will not attain *Nibbāna* even in the distant future. They held the opinion

⁵ Abhi.6.1.220 (Saccayamakapāḷi page 220):

48...(ka) yassa dukkhasaccaṃ uppajjissati tassa maggasaccaṃ uppajjissatīti?

aggamaggasamaṅgīnaṃ arahantānaṃ ye ca **puthujjanā maggaṃ na paṭilabhissanti** tesam dukkhasaccaṃ uppajjissati, no ca tesam maggasaccaṃ uppajjissati. yassa cittassa anantarā aggamaggaṃ paṭilabhissanti ye caññe maggaṃ paṭilabhissanti tesam dukkhasaccaṃ uppajjissati maggasaccaṃ uppajjissati.

48...For whom the Truth of Suffering will arise, will the Truth of the Path arise for that person?

For those possessing the highest Path [i.e. Arahatta Path], for Arahants, **and for those common worldlings who will not attain the Path**, for them the Truth of Suffering will arise; but the Truth of the Path will not arise for them. For those who will attain the highest Path immediately after their present consciousness, and for those others who will attain the Path, for them both the Truth of Suffering and the Truth of the Path will arise.

that everyone should be able to attain *Nibbāna* at some point in time in the future. However, some teachers provided an answer to this predicament.

According to them, there may be some ordinary persons who will not attain *Nibbāna*. These are referred to as “*vaṭṭajjhāsaya*”⁶ – persons who desire or wish for the cycle of rebirths, those who delight in the cycle of rebirths. As long as they maintain this disposition of desire or delight, they will be trapped in the cycle of rebirths. For them, there will be no attainments of *Nibbāna*.

In addition, among the definitions of one who is incapable of attainments (*abhabba*)⁷, there is a term “*acchandika*” –

⁶ Abhi.Ṭṭha.3.47 (Puggalapaññatti-aṭṭhakathā page 47):

Ekacco hi sotāpanno vaṭṭajjhāsaya hoti vaṭṭābhirato, punappunam vaṭṭasmimyeva carati sandissati.

Certain stream-enterer who is a delighter of the round of rebirth, will only appear and roam in the round of rebirth again and again.

Author’s note: Due to the disposition of delight in the round of rebirth, even the stream-enterer will be reborn again until this disposition is purified; let alone the ordinary being. The ordinary beings will not be able to escape from the round of rebirth so long as this disposition remained.

⁷ Abhi.2.355 (ñāṇavibhaṅgapāḷi page 355):

826. katame te sattā abhabbā? ye te sattā kammāvaraṇena samannāgatā kilesāvaraṇena samannāgatā vipākāvaraṇena samannāgatā assaddhā acchandikā duppaññā abhabbā niyāmaṃ okkamituṃ kusalesu dhammesu sammattaṃ, ime te sattā abhabbā.

826. Who are those beings who are not fit/incapable? Those beings who are furnished with the obstruction of (bad) action, furnished with the obstruction of corruption, furnished with the obstruction of (bad) resultant, have no confidence, **have no wish (to do good)**, have no wisdom (accompanying rebirth consciousness), are not fit to enter into the immutable rightness of good states (i.e., path consciousness). These are those beings who are not fit/incapable.



someone who has no desire to perform wholesome and has no aspiration for the Path, Fruition and Nibbāna.⁸ For one who does not see the faults and dangers of the cycle of rebirths, there is neither dispassion towards the five aggregates nor a sense of urgency to seek escape from the endless cycles of saṃsāra. As long as he does not arouse the desire for the realization of *Nibbāna*, there will be no attainment of Path and Fruition for him.

You may notice that some people are very happy in life. It is quite certain that as long as they enjoy the happiness in life, they will not aspire for *Nibbāna*; their mind will not incline towards *Nibbāna*.

Therefore, we need to practice *vipassanā*—thinking of the faults and dangers in life and reflecting on the suffering of life. By having “negative” views, we will achieve “positive” results. This “negative” view is the view of reality. It is the truth. This truth is the view of reality held by the Noble Ones, and it is also the view of reality that can lead to the

⁸ Abhi.Ṭṭha.2.443 (Vibhaṅga-aṭṭhakathā page 443):

acchandikāti kattukamyatākusalacchandarahitā.

Abhi.mṬṭikā.213 (Vibhaṅga-mūlaṭṭikā page 213):

nibbutichandarāhitattā acchandikaṭṭhānaṃ pavitṭhā.

Visuddhi.1.171 (Visuddhimagga Vol 1 page 171):

acchandikāti apaccanīkaṭṭhānaṃ chandavirahitā.

Visuddhi.ṭṭikā.1.200 (Mahāṭṭikā Vol 1 page 200):

acchandikāti “kattukamyatāchandarāhitā”ti sammohavinodaniyaṃ vuttaṃ, tampi nibbānādhigamatthameva kattukamyatāchandaṃ sandhāya vuttanti daṭṭhabbaṃ.

Khu.Ṭṭha.25.26 (Cūḷaniddesa-aṭṭhakathā page 26):

acchandiketi maggaphalatthaṃ rucivirahite.

attainment of Noble-hood. Hence, it is called the Noble Truth of Suffering (*Dukkha-Ariyasacca*).

***Nāma-rūpa* (mentality-materiality)**

Before starting on the “40-to’s”, I will first explain *nāma-rūpa* (mentality and materiality). To discern this body, we should analyze and divide it into two components - *rūpa* and *nāma*.

Rūpa refers to materiality; it refers to our physical body. The definition of the term *rūpa* is “changing due to causes”⁹. What are the causes? *Kamma*, *citta* (consciousness or mind), *utu* (temperature or weather), and *āhāra* (nutriment or food). Based on these four causes, our physical body, or materiality, constantly changes. For example, before and after eating, our bodies are not the same. Similarly, if the weather is hot or cold, this body may change. Additionally, if our mind changes—for instance, between being angry or happy—our physical body may change accordingly. Sometimes the changes may not be due to the above present

⁹ Visuddhi.2.159 (Visuddhimagga Vol 2 page 159):

Ruppatīti rūpaṃ

It is molested/changed, thus materiality (*Rūpa*).

Abhi.Ṭṭha.2.3 (Vibhaṅga-aṭṭhakathā page 3):

Ruppatīti *kuppati ghaṭṭiyati pīliyati bhijjatīti attho. Evaṃ iminā ettakena ṭhānena ruppanaṭṭhena rūpaṃ vuttaṃ.*

It is molested": [it is disturbed;] it is well-beaten; it is oppressed; it is broken is the meaning. Thus, materiality is hereby said to this extent in the sense of being molested.



causes but rather to the *kamma* we have performed in the past. This *kamma* can also cause changes in our bodies.

By seeing this nature of change, we can note, we can contemplate, “This body is materiality, materiality; it is not me, not mine, not my soul”.

If you contemplate in this way, it is a part of *vipassanā*. While it is not the systematic practice of *vipassanā*, it helps to develop a brief understanding of our body and to cultivate a wholesome mind by practicing *vipassanā*.

There are many details about materiality (*rūpa*), but I will not elaborate here. As it is very detailed, you may be bored. Therefore, we will move on to another part of our body, which is the mental body.

Sometimes we refer to the mental body as mentality. In Pāḷi, it is called *nāma*. What is the meaning of *nāma*? *Nāma* is similar to “name”. *Nāma* means inclining towards the object¹⁰. Our mind is called *nāma* because it is always inclining towards an object.

For example, when you are focusing on the breath, your mind is inclining towards the breath. Now that you are listening to the *Dhamma*, your mind is inclining towards the sound. If you are missing your home, your mind is inclining towards your

¹⁰ Abhi.Ṭha.2.128 (Vibhaṅga-aṭṭhakathā page 128):

Namatīti nāmaṃ. Ruppātīti rūpaṃ.

It bends" (*namati*), hence it is "mentality" (*nāma*); "it is molested" (*ruppati*), hence it is "materiality" (*rūpa*).

home. This inclination towards an object is the common characteristic of mentality. Whenever mentality arises, it is always inclining towards an object.

As such, the common characteristic of any mentality is that it inclines towards an object. For instance, the mind may incline towards visible objects when we see something. The mind may incline towards sound objects when we hear something. Because of this, it is just the nature of mentality to incline towards an object. Therefore, even though we see visible objects, hear sound objects, etc., there is no person or soul that is seeing or hearing. It is simply the nature of *nāma* to incline towards an object.

By understanding this nature of inclination, we can contemplate, “This is mentality, mentality; it is not me, not mine, not my soul.” If we contemplate in this way, it becomes part of *vipassanā* practice.

This way of contemplation is a way of practicing *Vipassanā*. It is the Right Thought; or we may say it is proper attention which can lead to *Nibbāna*—the freedom from materiality and mentality which are inherently suffering.



The Five Aggregates

Another way to analyze the body is by considering it through the lens of the five aggregates. We can divide our body into five components, or five aggregates. The first aggregate is *rūpakkhandha*, the materiality aggregate, which is the same as *rūpa* (materiality) explained earlier.

When analyzing by way of the five aggregates, we divide *nāma* (mentality) into four parts: The first component is feeling (*vedanā*). We always have feelings. Sometimes we feel happy, sometimes sad, and at other times neutral—neither happy nor sad. All these feelings are categorized as the feeling aggregate, *vedanākkhandha*.

Another component of mentality is perception (*saññā*). Perception refers to recognizing or labeling the object. It is the act of marking or identifying the object. This is the function of perception, and it may be correct or incorrect, beneficial or not. Regardless, we mark the object according to our perception. For example, while focusing on the breath, we should have the perception that the object is the breath. We perceive and mark the object as “breath”. Some perceptions, such as the perception of foulness (*asubha*), can be very beneficial. All these are perceptions. We perceive everything, and we are constantly labeling and marking objects. This factor is called *saññākkhandha*, the perception aggregate.

There are beneficial perceptions, and there are adverse perceptions. If you are practicing *ānāpānassati* meditation,

maintaining the perception of the breath is beneficial. Such perception will support mindfulness and meditation.

This factor of perception is a very important basis for the type of feeling that arises. Based on our perception, we may feel differently. Perceptions can vary from person to person. For instance, when it comes to chili, one person might perceive it as delicious and enjoyable, while another might dislike it. How about you? When you eat chili, what kind of perception do you have? The chili remains the same object, but perception differs from person to person.

All the remaining mental factors, apart from feeling (*vedanā*) and perception (*saññā*), fall under *saṅkhārakkhandha*, the formation aggregate. In total, there are 52 mental factors. Out of these, the mental factor of *vedanā* (feeling) is *vedanākkhandha* (feeling aggregate), and *saññā* (perception) mental factor is *saññākkhandha* (perception aggregate). Apart from *vedanā* and *saññā*, the remaining 50 mental factors are called *saṅkhārakkhandha*, the formation aggregate.

Saṅkhāra refers to the mental activities that construct or form objects. For example, while listening to a *Dhamma* talk, you may have certain feelings: happy, sad, or neutral. You may have perceptions about whether what Bhante is saying is good, average or just so-so. Such markings are perceptions. All the other mental factors are constructing the overall experience with the object, such as trying to listen, managing the mind to listen, etc. All those mental



factors are called *saṅkhārakkhandha*, the formation aggregate.

The final aggregate is *viññāṇakkhandha* (consciousness aggregate), which refers to the awareness of an object. In Pāli, this is called *viññāṇa*. Consciousness is the mentality which is aware of and cognizes the object. It is always grasping¹¹ or trying to grasp the object.

For additional information about the five aggregates, we can refer to the Khajjanīya Sutta¹² where the Buddha defines the five aggregates as follows:

ruppatīti kho, bhikkhave, tasmā ‘rūpan’ti vuccati. kena ruppati? sītenapi ruppati, uñhenapi ruppati, jighacchāyapi ruppati, pipāsāyapi ruppati, ḍaṃsamakasavātātāpasarīsapasamphassenapi ruppati.

“It is deformed,” bhikkhus, therefore it is called materiality. Deformed by what? Deformed by cold, deformed by heat, deformed by hunger, deformed by thirst, deformed by contact with flies, mosquitoes, wind, sub, and serpents.

vedayatīti kho, bhikkhave, tasmā ‘vedanā’ti vuccati. kiñca vedayati? sukhampi vedayati, dukkhampi vedayati, adukkhamasukhampi vedayati.

¹¹ *Upaladdhi*. Please refer to footnote 16 on page 19.

¹² Sam.2.71-72 (SN 22.79). [English translation by Bhikkhu Bodhi]

“It feels,” bhikkhus, therefore it is called feeling. And what does it feel? It feels pleasure, it feels pain, it feels neither-pain-nor-pleasure.

sañjānātīti kho, bhikkhave, tasmā ‘saññā’ti vuccati. kiñca sañjānāti? nīlampi sañjānāti, pītakampi sañjānāti, lohītakampi sañjānāti, odātampi sañjānāti.

“It perceives,” bhikkhus, therefore it is called perception. And what does it perceive? It perceives brown/blue, it perceives yellow, it perceives red, it perceives white.

saṅkhatam-abhisāṅkharontīti kho, bhikkhave, tasmā ‘saṅkhārā’ti vuccati. kiñca saṅkhatam-abhisāṅkharonti? rūpaṃ rūpattāya saṅkhatam-abhisāṅkharonti, vedanaṃ vedanattāya saṅkhatam-abhisāṅkharonti, saññāṃ saññattāya saṅkhatam-abhisāṅkharonti, saṅkhāre saṅkhārattāya saṅkhatam-abhisāṅkharonti, viññāṇaṃ viññāṇattāya saṅkhatam-abhisāṅkharonti.

“They construct the conditioned,” bhikkhus, therefore they are called volitional formations. And what is the conditioned that they construct? They construct conditioned materiality as materiality; they construct conditioned feeling as feeling; they construct conditioned perception as perception; they construct conditioned volitional formations as volitional formations; they construct conditioned consciousness as consciousness.



vijānātīti kho, bhikkhave, tasmā ‘viññāṇan’ti vuccati. kiñca vijānāti? ambulampi vijānāti, tittakampi vijānāti, kaṭukampi vijānāti, madhurampi vijānāti, khārikampi vijānāti, akhārikampi vijānāti, loṇikampi vijānāti, aloṇikampi vijānāti.

“It cognizes,” bhikkhus, therefore it is called consciousness. And what does it cognize? It cognizes sour, it cognizes bitter, it cognizes pungent, it cognizes sweet, it cognizes sharp, it cognizes mild, it cognizes salty, it cognizes bland.

Regarding perception (*saññā*), it is a combination of the prefix *saṃ* and the root *ñā*, meaning to know the object through marking it. The commentary of the Khajjanīya Sutta explains that by perceiving the color of brown flowers or brown clothing and using that as a preliminary sign, the meditator can attain access or absorption concentration.

Regarding volitional formations (*saṅkhārā*), they create or construct the five aggregates, which are conditioned (*saṅkhata*) because they are produced by a combination of conditions. The commentary illustrates this with the simile of one who cooks porridge for the sake of having porridge and to bake a cake in order to get a cake. In the same way, the volitional formations, which consists of a collection of mental factors headed by volition (*cetanā*), construct, build up, amass, and produce materiality (*rūpa*) for its nature of being materiality (*rūpattāya*). In other words, whenever materiality is produced, it arises with the intrinsic nature of materiality – for example, the intrinsic nature of being subject to change,

etc. (*ruppanādisabhava*). We can understand in a similar way for the production of the other mental aggregates – feeling, perception, volitional formations, consciousness.¹³

Regarding consciousness (*viññāṇa*), it is a combination of the prefix *vi* and the noun derived from the root *ñā*. The prefix *vi* here conveys the idea of “distinct” or “differentiated”. Consciousness cognizes differences among objects. Thus, in

¹³ The commentary (Saṃ.Ṭṭha.2.269) summarises as follows: *ayaṃ panettha saṅkhepo — attanā saha jāyamānaṃ rūpaṃ sampayutte ca vedanādayo dhamme abhisāṅkharoti nibbattetīti*. This is the explanation in brief – [volitional formations (*saṅkhārā*)] construct/produce materiality arising with themselves as well as associated mental aggregates such as feeling, etc.

To elaborate further, in the case of *rūpa*, it refers to co-nascence materiality (*sahajāta rūpa*), which specifically means mind-born materiality (*cittaja rūpa*). The *saṅkhārakkhandha* produces *cittaja rūpa* which arises together with itself. According to Paṭṭhāna, *rūpa* is also supported by mentalities by way of post-nascence condition (*pacchājātapaccaya*).

Furthermore, according to the sub-commentary (Saṃ.Ṭikā.2.237): *ayaṃ evaṃ ruppanādisabhāve dhammasamūhe yathāsakaṃ paccayehi abhisāṅkhariyamāne cetanāpadhāno dhammasamūho pavattanatthaṃ visesapaccayo hutvā te abhisāṅkharoti niropeti nibbattetīti*. The group of [*saṅkhārā*] dhammas, with volition (*cetanā*) as the predominant factor and the distinct cause (*visesapaccaya*), constructs, brings about, produces the group of dhammas [*rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saññā*, etc.], each with its intrinsic nature such as being deformed (*ruppana*) [for *rūpa*], by creating their respective causes and conditions.

Thus, in addition to being a *sahajāta*-kamma condition, *cetanā*, acting as *nānakkaṇṇika*-kamma (asynchronous kamma), is also a cause that produces *kammaja rūpa* in the future.

To summarise, among the *rūpa* of four causes, *cittaja rūpa* is supported directly by *saṅkhārakkhandha* through the *sahajāta* group of conditions; *rūpa* of all four causes is supported through the *pacchājāta* group of conditions; and *kammaja rūpa* is supported by *nānakkaṇṇika*-kamma condition.

Regardless, whenever *rūpa* is produced by various conditions, it arises with the intrinsic nature of *rūpa*. Hence, it is said “*rūpaṃ rūpattāya saṅkhatam-abhisāṅkharonti*.” The rest of the aggregates can be understood accordingly.



the sutta here, consciousness is explained as knowing the differences among various tastes.

The commentary further explains that perception (*saññā*) is analyzed by way of the eye door in this sutta because it is evident in grasping the appearance (*ākāra*) and shape (*sañthāna*) of an object. Consciousness, however, is analyzed through the tongue door due to its ability to grasp particular distinctions in an object without reliance on appearance and shape.¹⁴

The same commentary also explains the differences among perception (*saññā*), consciousness (*viññāṇa*), and wisdom (*paññā*). All these terms are derived from the root *ṽñā* (to know, to cognize) with different prefixes, and they express cognitive functions of increasing depth, discriminative

¹⁴ Saṃ.Ṭṭha.2.270: *yasmā pana ārammaṇassa ākāra-sañthāna-gahaṇavasena saññā pākaṭā hoti, tasmā sā cakkhudvāre vibhattā. yasmā vināpi ākārasañthānā ārammaṇassa paccatta-bheda-gahaṇavasena viññāṇaṃ pākaṭaṃ hoti, tasmā taṃ jivhādvāre vibhattaṃ.*

The sub-commentary explains that appearance (*ākāra*) refers to colors such as brown, yellow, etc., and shape (*sañthāna*) refers to forms such as round, quadrangle, etc. The marking of color and shape is an obvious function of perception.

In the case of *viññāṇa*, its mode of knowing operates by taking the specific/particular distinctions in the object (*paccatta-bheda-gahaṇavasena*). The sub-commentary explains this to mean taking the differences or distinctions among this and that objects (*tassa tassa ārammaṇassa pabheda-gahaṇavasena*). The use of “this and that objects” implies all objects—not just the tongue door objects as mentioned here—but also appearance, shape and all other objects.

acumen, and power of comprehension.¹⁵ Perception (*saññā*) merely marks the object by way of its differences in color such as brown and so on. Still, it cannot grasp the characteristics of impermanence (*anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*) and non-self (*anatta*). Consciousness (*viññāṇa*) not only knows the object by way of its differences in color etc., it is able to grasp¹⁶ the characteristics of impermanence, etc.;

¹⁵ The sub-commentary (Saṃ.Ṭikā.2.237) elaborates: *Tathā hi sañjānanapadaṃ paccabhiññāṇa-nimittaṃ ākāragahaṇamattaṃ bodheti, vijānanapadaṃ tato viṣiṭṭhavisayagahaṇaṃ. Pajānanapadaṃ pana tatopi viṣiṭṭhataṃ pakārato avabodhaṃ bodheti.*

For perception (*saññā* = *sañjānana*), the mode of knowing is to take or mark the appearance as a sign to be known again at a later time. The word *paccabhiññāṇa* (= *paṭi* + *abhiññāṇa*) means knowing again subsequently. [The prefix *saṃ* implies marking the object.]

For consciousness (*viññāṇa* = *vijānana*), the mode of knowing is to take the object differently (*viṣiṭṭha*) from that of mere perception. [The prefix *vi* denotes *viṣiṭṭha* (distinction).]

In the case of wisdom (*paññā* = *pajānana*), it is to know with full knowledge (*avabodha*) in modes or manners (*pakārato*) that go beyond differences (*viṣiṭṭha*) in object. [The prefix *pa* signifies *pakāra* (modes or manners).] *Paññā* is also described as *asammoha*, meaning non-delusion or clear comprehension.

¹⁶ The commentary uses the word *paṭivedha* here, which generally means penetration. However, the sub-commentary explains that *paṭivedha* in this context only means *upaladdhi* and not *paṭivijjhana*. This distinction implies merely gaining or apprehending the object, rather than truly penetrating it. In this sense, consciousness (*viññāṇa*) is capable of knowing or grasping the three characteristics of impermanence, suffering and non-self (*anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*), but it is not able to penetrate them. The latter—true penetration—is the domain of wisdom (*paññā*).

The sub-commentary further elaborates that a skillful *Vipassanā* practitioner may be able to know *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* even with consciousness dissociated with knowledge (*ñāṇavippayuttacitta*). This means that even consciousness without wisdom can still take these characteristics as its object due to the practitioner's proficiency in practice. This is analogous to someone



however, it is not possible to reach the attainments of Path (*magga*), Fruition (*phala*) and Nibbāna through practice. Wisdom (*paññā*) knows the object by way of its differences in color etc., penetrates the characteristics of impermanence and so forth, and through cultivation is able to culminate in the attainments of Path, Fruition, and Nibbāna.

There is a simile to further illustrate these differences:¹⁷

Suppose there were three people, a child without discretion, a villager, and a goldsmith/treasurer, who saw a heap of coins lying on the table.

The child without discretion knows merely that the coins are figured and ornamented, long, square, or round; he does not know that they are reckoned as valuable for human use and enjoyment.

And the villager knows that they are figured and ornamented, etc., and that they are reckoned as valuable for human use and enjoyment; but he does not know such distinction as, “This one is genuine, this one is fake, this is half-value.”

who chants daily and is able to recite correctly, even without paying much attention to what is being recited.

However, it is only consciousness associated with knowledge (*ñāṇasampayuttacitta*), supported by the presence of *paññā*, that can truly penetrate the three characteristics. Such penetration can eventually lead to the attainment of *magga*, *phala*, and Nibbāna.

¹⁷ Saṃ.Ṭṭha.2.270-271; also Visuddhi.2.66-67. [English translation by Bhikkhu Ñāṇamoli]

The goldsmith/treasurer knows all these kinds, and he does so by looking at the coin, by listening to the sound of it when struck, and by smelling its smell, tasting its taste, and weighing it in his hand, and he knows that it was made in a certain village or town or city or on a certain mountain or by a certain master.

Perception (*saññā*) is like the child without discretion, consciousness (*viññāṇa*) the villager, and wisdom (*paññā*) the goldsmith/treasurer.

Understanding the five aggregates helps us realize that there is no being but just an assemblage of aggregates.

Yathā hi aṅgasambhārā, hoti saddo ratho iti;

Evaṃ khandhesu santesu, hoti sattoti sammuti.

Dukkhameva hi sambhoti, dukkhaṃ tiṭṭhati veti ca;

Nāññatra dukkhā sambhoti, nāññam dukkhā nirujjhatī”¹⁸

“Just as, with an assemblage of parts,

the word ‘chariot’ is used;

So, when the aggregates exist,

there is the convention ‘a being.’

“It’s only suffering that comes to be,

suffering that stands and falls away;

Nothing but suffering comes to be,

nothing but suffering ceases.”

¹⁸ Saṃ.1.137 (SN 5.10 Vajirā Sutta) [English translation by Bhikkhu Bodhi]



So, there are only these 5 aggregates in our body. Instead of perceiving the body as men or women, as me or others, if you think of it simply as the five aggregates, it is also a form of *vipassanā* practice. We should develop this way of thinking. We should cultivate such a perception. It is truly beneficial. With the help of this perception, we can train ourselves to avoid mental suffering even when the body experiences physical pain, as the Buddha admonished the layman Nakulapita:¹⁹

āturo hāyaṃ, gahapati, kāyo aṇḍabhūto pariyonaddho. yo hi, gahapati, imaṃ kāyaṃ pariharanto muhuttampi ārogyaṃ paṭijāneyya, kimaññatra bālyā? tasmātiha te, gahapati, evaṃ sikkhitabbaṃ — ‘āturakāyassa me sato cittaṃ anāturaṃ bhavissatī’ti. evañhi te, gahapati, sikkhitabbaṃ.

“So it is, householder, so it is! This body of yours is afflicted, weighed down, encumbered. If anyone carrying around this body were to claim to be healthy even for a moment, what is that due to other than foolishness? Therefore, householder, you should train yourself thus: ‘Even though I am afflicted in body, my mind will be unafflicted.’ Thus, should you train yourself.”

Furthermore, such contemplation of the five aggregates will lead to *Nibbāna*, which is the freedom from the five aggregates, and therefore the freedom from suffering.

¹⁹ Sam.3.1 (SN 22.1 Nakulapitu Sutta) [English translation by Bhikkhu Bodhi].

The 40-to's (40 contemplation) In Detail

*Rūpaṃ **aniccam** palokaṃ, calaṃ pabhaṅgu addhuvam
viparināmāsārakaṃ vibhavaṃ maccu saṅkhataṃ.*

***Dukkha**ṇca rogāghaṃ gaṇḍaṃ, sallābādham
upaddavaṃ Bhayītyūpasaggātānaṃ, aleṇāsaraṇaṃ
vadaṃ aghamūlaṃ ādīnaṃ sāsavaṃ mārāmīsaṃ.*

*Jātijjaraṃ byadhisokaṃ, paridevamupāyāsaṃ saṃkilesa-
sabhāvakaṃ.*

***Anattā** ca paraṃ rittaṃ, tucchaṃ suññanti tālīsaṃ
vedanādaya khandhāpi, tatheva pañcakāpivā.²⁰*

Materiality is **impermanent**, disintegrating, fickle, perishable, not constant, subject to change, having no core, due to be annihilated, subject to death, formed.

And is **painful**, a disease, a calamity, a boil, a dart, an affliction, a disaster, a terror, a plague, a menace, without protection, without shelter, not a refuge, murderous, the root of calamity, a danger, subject to cankers, Māra's bait; subject to birth, aging, illness, sorrow, lamentation and despair; and is subject to defilements.

And (it is) **non-self**, alien, lacking, vain, and void – these forty aspects apply also to the feeling aggregate, etc., and likewise, to the group of five (aggregates as a whole).

²⁰ Pa-Auk Tawya Meditation Manual.

Anicca

1. *Aniccato* (impermanent)

²¹*so hi ekekaṃ khandhaṃ anaccantikatāya, ādiantavantatāya ca aniccato*²²

You can contemplate your body, or *nāmarūpa*, or the five aggregates, as *anicca*, impermanent. Regarding impermanence, you can contemplate it in two ways.

anaccantikatāya (ending points)

Firstly, it is *anicca* (impermanent) because your body, or mentality and materiality, cannot avoid encountering ending points (*anaccantikatāya*). You need to see the nature of not being able to overcome these ending points. Everything that happens in your body has an ending point. You may feel happy now, but sooner or later, this feeling will come to an end, and you will feel sad instead. It cannot last forever. Similarly, your physical body may be healthy now, but sooner or later, this healthy state will end, and you will fall sick. In this way, our body cannot avoid encountering endpoints.

If you can see very deeply into your body, you can see it arising and perishing very rapidly. By observing this, you can

²¹ Visuddhi.2.247 (Visuddhimagga Vol 2 page 247): [Similar Pāḷi reference source for the Pāḷi definition of each -to]

²² [English translation by Bhikkhu Ñāṇamoli, taken from the Path of Purification for reference:]

He comprehends each aggregate as *impermanent* because of non-endlessness, and because of possession of a beginning and an end.

discern the ending points. Seeing this, you can reflect and contemplate, "anicca, anicca, impermanence, impermanence." This is the first way to understand *anicca*—by seeing the ending points.

ādiavantatāya (beginning and ending points)

Another way to understand *anicca* is by observing that there are both beginning points and ending points (*ādiavantatāya*). You need to see both the beginning and the ending points—the arising and ceasing of phenomena. Your life begins at the moment of conception, with the rebirth-linking consciousness; that is the beginning point. At some point in time, you will die; that is the ending point. Similarly, a feeling of happiness may arise within you; that is the beginning point. Later, this happiness may disappear and be replaced by sadness; that is the ending point.

These beginning and ending points are what you can easily observe in a general way, as they are experienced by everyone. However, if you can focus on mentality and materiality very deeply, in a very detailed manner, you will discern that your body is always arising and perishing in every moment. After it arises, it perishes; then it arises again and perishes again.

A helpful analogy is that of water in a river. The water in the river is always flowing, never remaining stable. When the water at a certain spot flows downstream, new water flows in to replace it. Because of this constant flow, it may appear to you that it is the same water at that spot. However, in



reality, it is always different water. In the same way, materiality and mentality in our bodies are constantly arising and perishing. After perishing, they arise again. There are always beginning points and ending points. By seeing both the beginning and ending points, you can reflect and contemplate, "*anicca, anicca, impermanence, impermanence.*"

This is Right View (*sammādiṭṭhi*). Such reflection is Right Thought (*sammāsaṅkappa*), the correct application of the mind. Making the effort to reflect in this way is Right Effort (*sammāvāyāma*). Being mindful of such reflection and remembering it is Right Mindfulness (*sammāsatī*). Keeping the mind on this reflection is Right Concentration (*sammāsamādhi*). When we are engaging in such reflections, we are abstaining from wrongdoings, and thus are endowed with Right Speech (*sammāvācā*), Right Action (*sammākammanta*) and Right Livelihood (*sammāājīva*). In this way, the Eightfold Noble Path is complete when we reflect properly on impermanence (*anicca*). In addition, paying attention in this way is also proper attention (*yoniso manasikāra*). This understanding applies similarly to any of the subsequent contemplations among the 40 -tos.

Furthermore, this kind of reflection leads to a knowledge called *Anulomika Khanti* - the ability to see the true nature of mentality and materiality as impermanent, etc. This knowledge conforms to and is conducive to the arising of Path Knowledge. The Path Knowledge can take *Nibbāna*, which is permanent, as its object. By contemplating *anicca*

(impermanence), it will lead you to *Nibbāna*, which is *nicca* (permanent and unchanging).

2. *Palokato* (disintegrating)

*byādhijarāmarañehi palujjanatāya palokato*²³

The second *-to* is *palokato*. *Palokato* means being destroyed, spoiled, or damaged. You should reflect on your body as having the nature of disintegration. We can understand the nature of our body in three ways.

byādhi (sickness)

Our body is always subject to the nature of being destroyed. When we are sick, this becomes very clear: the body becomes weak, we lose strength, and we are no longer healthy. This is the nature of destruction. So, firstly, we can understand this nature through the body's vulnerability to sickness.

Our body has the inherent tendency to become sick; it has the nature of sickness. For example, you cannot sit in one posture for a long time. After sitting for one, two, or three hours, you need to move or change your posture. You may even need to stand up. However, even in the standing posture, you cannot sustain it for too long. After some time, you feel discomfort and need to lie down. Lying down also cannot be maintained for an extended period, and

²³ ***palokato***: as *disintegrating* because of crumbling through sickness, ageing and death.



eventually, you may have to walk. This constant need to change bodily postures to avoid discomfort is a sign of the body's vulnerability to sickness. You may observe that for those who are sick, even standing is uncomfortable, sitting is uncomfortable, and lying down is uncomfortable. This inability to maintain a posture is a form of sickness. Even when we think we are normal and healthy, we cannot maintain any posture—whether sitting, standing, or lying down—for a long time. This shows that sickness is one of the natural states of the body.

jarā (aging)

Another way to understand the body's nature of being destroyed is through the process of aging. Day by day, our body becomes older and older. For example, beautiful skin may wrinkle and shrink; shiny black hair may turn grey or white; strong teeth may weaken or break. The process of aging takes away our youth. Over time, the body ages and becomes weaker and more fragile. As we grow older, we may also experience many diseases. This is the nature of a body that is subject to aging—it is constantly in a state of disintegration.

marāṇa (death)

Another nature of our body is death. At some point in the future, we will inevitably die. After death, our body will no longer be supported by the life faculty, and within two or three days, it will become repulsive. Since death is inevitable, our body is inherently of the nature to be destroyed. If we

can see deeply with a concentrated mind, we will see that in every moment, materiality and mentality, together with life-faculty, are constantly perishing or are of the nature of dying.

By reflecting on the nature of sickness, aging, and death, we can contemplate and recognize that our body is subject to this nature of destruction: “*paloka, paloka*, being destroyed, being destroyed”. By doing so, you will cultivate the Right Thought (*Sammā Saṅkappa*). This is a form of *vipassanā*, a type of knowledge that can lead to *Nibbāna*, which is not subject to the nature of being destroyed (*apalokadhamma*).

3. *Calato* (fickle)

*byādhijarāmarañehi ceva lābhālābhādīhi ca lokadhammehi pacalitatāya calato*²⁴

The next “-to” is *calato*. *Cala* means shaking, and *calato* refers to having the nature of shaking or being unstable. Our body and life inherently possess the nature of instability and shakiness.

What do you think about your body and your life? Are they stable?

Our bodies are shaky and unstable. Our lives, too, are shaky and unstable.

²⁴ ***Calato***: as *fickle* because of fickle insecurity due to sickness, ageing and death, and to the worldly states of gain, etc.



byādhi (sickness)

Because of sickness, aging, and death, our body is not stable. Although we try to maintain stability, attempting to keep the body from being shaken, it is ultimately in vain. We are constantly vulnerable to sickness. We are always afraid of falling sick. We undergo medical check-ups from time to time as a precaution. This is an indication of the body's instability. Because of sickness and diseases, today we may be healthy, but tomorrow we may not be—everything is uncertain. Our minds and bodies are inherently unstable, unsteady, and easily shaken.

jarā (aging)

Similarly, aging is another source of instability. Even though we wish to remain young forever, it is impossible. Today, we may still be young, but day by day, we are growing older and older. Our bodies are always moving forward on the path of aging, a gradual but inevitable decline. The process of aging shakes our lives, bringing instability and uncertainty.

maraṇa (death)

Death is another undeniable aspect of instability in life. We all want to live forever, avoiding death, but it is unavoidable. Today we are alive, but tomorrow is uncertain. We may make plans for the future, but none of them are guaranteed. Tomorrow or the next life—who knows which will come first?

Since childhood, we have worked hard to build a good life. We study diligently, work hard in our jobs, and try to earn as much money as we can. Despite all our efforts, our lives

remain unstable because of sickness, aging, and especially death. No matter how much we wish to avoid these realities, we must accept the inevitable. Because of sickness, aging, and death, our lives are very shaky and unstable. This body, made up of materiality and mentality, is inherently unstable. This is its true nature, and we need to reflect, “This body is shaking; it is not stable”. Such contemplation brings knowledge, which can lead to *Nibbāna*, which is unshakeable (*acala*).

Another reason the body is shaky and unstable is that it is subject to *lokadhamma*. *Loka* means “world”, and *dhamma* means “nature”—the nature of the world. It is usually translated as worldly conditions. There are eight kinds of worldly conditions:

Lābho alābho (gain and loss)

Sometimes in life, we experience gain, and other times, we face loss. When we gain something, we feel happy, but when we suffer losses, we feel sad. Because of encountering gain and loss in our lives, we may laugh sometimes, and angry at other times. Life fluctuates between the two extremes of happiness and disappointment, making it unstable and easily shaken.

Even during a meditation retreat, when you are able to develop concentration, you feel happy, and everything about the place seems good. But when you lose concentration, the same place can feel unpleasant or unsatisfactory. Therefore, it is unstable, and it is a kind of worldly *dhamma*.



yaso ayaso (having retinue or deserted)

Another is *yaso ayaso* – having many followers or being alone; or enjoying fame and enduring loneliness. Sometimes we enjoy fame and recognition, and at other times, we are alone or ignored. We may enjoy having many followers or admirers, but feel unhappy when we are deserted. This attachment to fame or fear of obscurity makes our mind unstable. Thus, life is not stable.

nindā pasamsā (blame or praise)

Another is *nindā pasamsā* – being praised or blamed by others. Sometimes people blame us, and sometimes they praise us. We may enjoy praise but feel hurt by blame. This fluctuation between blame and praise makes our life unstable. Because of such worldly *dharmas*, both our lives and minds are unstable.

sukha dukkha (happiness and suffering)

The final pair is *sukha dukkha* – happiness and suffering. Happiness and suffering shake our lives too. Sometimes we are happy, and sometimes we suffer. Whoever lives in this world will encounter these conditions. These fluctuations cause everyone to experience the ups and downs of life. Every form of life is unstable. Our minds are easily shaken because we are constantly influenced by these eight worldly *dharmas*.

The body is dependent on many conditions, and the mind fluctuates as it is subject to various influences. By understanding this, we need to reflect on our body and life,

and contemplate, “This life is not stable, it is shakeable”; “*cala, cala*”, or “shakeable, shakeable”, or “unstable, unstable”.

This way of reflecting is a form of *vipassanā*. If you contemplate in this way, you gain knowledge. When this knowledge matures, it will lead to *Nibbāna*, which is stable and unshakeable (*acala*)²⁵.

4. *Pabhaṅguto* (perishable)

*upakkamena ceva sarasena ca pabhaṅgupagamanasīlatāya pabhaṅguto*²⁶

The next contemplation is *pabhaṅguto*. *Pabhaṅgu* means “perishable”, “brittle”, or “fragile”. Thus, *pabhaṅguto* refers to having the nature of perishing, or breaking apart, in a disorderly manner.

Our body, or our life, inherently possesses such a nature – perishable, brittle, and fragile, breaking apart in a disorderly manner. It has the nature of perishing in disarray. It does not

²⁵ Paṭisaṃ.412:

*pañcakkhandhe calato passanto anulomikaṃ khantiṃ paṭilabhati.
pañcannaṃ khandhānaṃ nirodho acalaṃ nibbānanti passanto
sammattaniyāmaṃ okkamati.*

The same source of reference is applicable for all 40 contemplations and their outcomes.

²⁶ ***Pabhaṅguto***: as *perishable* because of having the nature of perishing both by violence and naturally.



perish in an orderly or controlled manner. There are three ways to understand this.

upakkamena (by effort)

One reason for this nature is effort (*upakkama*). This body may perish as a result of the efforts of others or even of our own efforts.

Sometimes, others may harm this body and cause it to perish. We may be taking good care of ourselves, but others may come up to us and pick a fight with us, attack us, or inflict injuries on this body. Other people or beings may kill or harm us, causing this body to break apart. There is a high possibility for this body to perish. For example, innocent people in a peaceful country may suddenly face attacks by aggressors from another nation, leading to death and destruction. Such perishing is caused by the efforts of others, resulting in disorderliness and the breaking apart of the body.

At other times, our body may perish due to our own efforts or actions. Some people may intentionally harm or even kill themselves. Committing suicide is an example of perishing due to one's deliberate effort. Sometimes, the body perishes due to one's own intentional efforts. But sometimes it may not be intentional. In spite of the efforts to care for our body, we may inadvertently make mistakes and harm the body. For instance, accidentally consuming unsuitable food or harmful substances, exposing ourselves to adverse weather

conditions, engaging in risky activities, or putting ourselves in dangerous situations. All these will lead to our harm due to our own efforts, and this body may perish.

So, the body may perish either due to the efforts of others or our own. When someone meets with accidents, it could either be due to his own recklessness or carelessness, or it could be entirely due to the fault of others. Whether due to the efforts of others or our own actions, this body has the inherent nature of perishing—it breaks apart easily.

We need to reflect on this and contemplate on the nature of perishing of the body. Such contemplation is Right View and Right Thought, which are beneficial for us. *Vipassanā* is this kind of reflection and contemplation. By reflecting in this way, we cultivate Right View which guides us to think in ways that are beneficial for our spiritual growth.

sarasena (by nature)

Another way to understand the nature of *pabhaṅgu*—perishable, brittle, fragile, disorderly—is through *sarasena*—its intrinsic nature (*sarasa*). Even in the absence of efforts by others or ourselves to harm this body, it still has the intrinsic nature of perishing, being brittle, or fragile. Although we may take great care of this body, eat only good and nutritious food, and seek good medical treatment, this body will still grow older and older day by day. It will inevitably fall sick and, finally, it will die. This body is inherently bound to perish. Nobody can escape this intrinsic



nature of brittleness and fragility. This body will perish according to its intrinsic nature.

By understanding this, we need to reflect and contemplate: "This body has the nature of *pabhaṅgu*, the nature of perishing, perishing, or the nature of breaking, brittleness, disorderliness." Such reflection develops Right View and Right Thought. This kind of contemplation can lead to *Nibbāna*, which is beyond the nature of perishing, brittleness, and disorderliness (*apabhaṅgu*).

5. *Addhuvato* (not constant)

*sabbāvatthanipātītāya, thirabhāvassa ca abhāvatāya
addhuvato*²⁷

The next contemplation is *addhuvato*—to contemplate the body as *addhuva*. *Addhuva* means “not constant”, “not sufficiently strong”, and “without stability”.

sabbāvatthanipātītāya (the nature of falling at all stages)

This body is inherently not stable and not firm, much like fruits on a tree that may fall at any stage of development before they ripen. Similarly, our body can perish at any age, not only in old age. No one can declare with certainty: “I am young, I am strong, surely I cannot die now.” Even if we are young or adults in the prime of life, we can still die at any moment. From the moment we are conceived in our

²⁷ **Addhuvato**: as *unenduring* because of collapsing on every occasion and because of lack of solidity;

mother's womb until the time we are frail and advanced in age, our life can end suddenly, at any stage along this journey. It is impossible to guarantee staying alive at any given time. Therefore, this body is *addhuva*, not eternal, not permanent, not stable, and not firm.

If we examine the different periods of our life, this lack of constancy becomes even clearer. The body is continuously changing and cannot maintain its youthfulness. It is not the same at different stages in life. It cannot remain unchanged, nor can it achieve permanence or stability. This impermanence is its true nature.

Because of this, we must contemplate this body, understand and accept its true nature: This body is not stable, not firm, and not constant.

thirabhāvassa abhāvatāya (the absence of firmness)

Another perspective on *addhuva* is that even before death, this body lacks essence or true firmness. It is as though there is no heartwood (the strong, dense center in some trees) in this body—it is weak and fragile. Consider how much care the body requires just to stay functional: we need to carefully manage our food intake and protect ourselves from the weather. We must avoid accidents and maintain hygiene. When we are weak, even minor external influences such as air pollution may affect us and cause harm to our body.

If our body were compared to a piece of luggage, it would require a “Fragile” sticker to emphasize its delicacy. In fact, the human body is more fragile than most things. Eggs may



be fragile, but the body is even more so. Mosquitoes and other small insects can harm our body, whereas they cannot bite something as fragile as eggs. Even tiny viruses, invisible to the naked eye, can make us seriously ill. We need to be very careful with our hygiene. It is very easy for our bodies to suffer pain and to get sick. In order to listen to this talk, you need cushions to sit on, because sitting directly on the floor is too uncomfortable. If the weather turns slightly cold, we need extra clothing to stay warm. This shows just how delicate and unstable the body truly is. Because of these vulnerabilities, it becomes clear that this body has no essence or heartwood. Even if we are alive now, our body is inherently not constant, not strong enough, and not firm.

By understanding this nature of *addhuva*, you should reflect deeply and contemplate, “This body is *addhuva*, it is not stable; it is not constant; it is fragile”. This reflection is a form of *Vipassanā* contemplation, which cultivates Right View and Right Thought. This proper attention can ultimately lead to *Nibbāna*, which is firm, stable, and constant (*dhuva*).

6. *Vipariṇāmadhammato* (subject to change)

*jarāya ceva maraṇena cāti dvedhā pariṇāmapakatitāya vipariṇāma-dhammato*²⁸

The next contemplation is *vipariṇāmadhammato*, which refers to the contemplation that this body is subject to change. It has the nature of constantly changing and lacks any permanent standing. This body is always undergoing transformation. But how does this change occur? Does it transform from old to young, or from young to old?

jarā (aging)

The first cause of this constant change is *jarā*, or aging. The aging process manifests as the body transitioning from youth to old age. In the Mahāpadāna Sutta, this is described through the story of Prince Vipassī:

Once, Prince Vipassī was being driven to the pleasure park, he saw an aged man, bent like a roof beam, broken, leaning on a stick, tottering, sick, his youth all vanished. At the sight, he said to the charioteer:

“Charioteer, what is the matter with this man? His hair is not like other men’s; his body is not like other men’s.”

“Prince, that is what is called an old man.

“But why is he called an old man?”

²⁸ ***Vipariṇāmadhammato***: as *subject to change* because of having the nature of change in two ways, that is, through aging and through death.



“He is called old, Prince, because he has not long to live.”

“But am I liable to become old, and not exempt from old age?”

“Both you and I, Prince, are liable to become old, and are not exempt from old age.”²⁹

This story emphasizes the inevitable truth that we are all subject to aging. We have not overcome the nature of aging. None of us is exempt from it. The process of aging continually changes our bodies. From the moment we are born as humans, day by day, we grow older and weaker, becoming more vulnerable to diseases and physical decline. This process introduces us to the constant transformation of the body, which is always moving in the direction of aging. By contemplating this truth, we can observe and note the nature of change: “*Vipariṇāma*, *vipariṇāma*, the nature of changing, the nature of changing.”

²⁹ Dī.2.18-19 (DN 14 Mahāpadāna Sutta - Jīṇṇapuriso): [English translation by Maurice Walshe]

“addasā kho, bhikkhave, vipassī kumāro uyyānabhūmiṃ niyyanto purisaṃ jīṇṇaṃ gopānasivaṅkaṃ bhoggaṃ daṇḍaparāyanaṃ pavedhamānaṃ gacchantaṃ āturaṃ gatayobbanāṃ. disvā sārathīṃ āmantesi — ‘ayaṃ pana, samma sārathī, puriso kiṃkato? kesāpissa na yathā aññesaṃ, kāyopissa na yathā aññesaṃ’ti. ‘eso kho, deva, jīṇṇo nāmā’ti. ‘kiṃ paneso, samma sārathī, jīṇṇo nāmā’ti? ‘eso kho, deva, jīṇṇo nāma. na dāni tena ciraṃ jīvitabbaṃ bhavissatī’ti. ‘kiṃ pana, samma sārathī, ahampi jarādhammo, jaraṃ anatīto’ti? ‘tvañca, deva, mayañcamha sabbe jarādhammā, jaraṃ anatītā’ti.

marana (death)

The second cause for this nature of change is *maraṇa*, or death. Each day, we draw closer and closer to death, steadily approaching the moment when we must face it. While we may wish to avoid this terminal encounter, it is unavoidable. Aging acts as a driving force, pushing us toward death. It is comparable to a cowherd driving cattle toward green pastures—just as the cowherd urges the cattle forward, aging propels us ever nearer to the inevitability of death. Because of this, our body has the nature of change due to death.

On a deeper level, if we look closely with a concentrated mind, we can directly observe that all materiality and mentality are subject to the three stages: *uppāda* (arising), *ṭhiti* (standing), and *bhaṅga* (perishing). The standing phase represents aging (*jarā*), while the perishing phase represents death (*marāṇa*). All material and mental phenomena are constantly aging and dying. They are perpetually changing due to these forces of aging and death.

By seeing this nature of aging and death, we can contemplate, “This body is changing, changing, *vipariṇāma*, *vipariṇāma*, by aging, by death.” This contemplation constitutes Right View and Right Thought, forming a part of *Vipassanā*. Such proper attention and reflection may eventually lead to *Nibbāna*, which is free from the nature of change (*avipariṇāmadhamma*), the ultimate unchanging state.



7. *Asārakato* (having no core)

*dubbalatāya, pheggu viya sukhabhañjanīyatāya ca asārakato*³⁰

The next contemplation is *asārakato*, which means “having no essence”. The Pāḷi term *Sāra* refers to the hardwood of a tree. So, *asārakato* means the absence of hardwood. Hardwood is valuable because it is strong, durable, and reliable. However, our body lacks these qualities. It is not strong like hardwood. There are two ways to understand why our body has this nature of lacking a firm essence, comparable to the absence of hardwood.

dubbalatāya (weak)

The first way to understand is *dubbalatāya*, which refers to the state of being weak. Our body is inherently weak and feeble. It lacks the strength necessary to endure harsh conditions on its own. Because of this inherent weakness, we need to construct houses, monasteries, or other shelters to protect this body from external elements. Without such protection, the body cannot survive. This weakness also means we cannot stay just anywhere or in any environment we desire; we must carefully select suitable and safe places to live.

³⁰ ***asārakato***: As *having no core* because of feebleness, and because of decaying soon like sapwood.

In addition, this weakness extends to the nourishment the body requires. We cannot just eat any kind of food. The food we consume must be clean, healthy, and suitable for this delicate body. Even with proper care, this body remains vulnerable to sickness, harm, and discomfort. All of this special care and protection reflects the body's feebleness and inability to stand on its own. Therefore, we can understand that this body is *asāraka*, without essence, lacking strength, and not comparable to the firmness of hardwood.

sukhabhañjanīya (easy to break)

The second way to understand *asārakato* is through the idea of *sukhabhañjanīya*, which means “easy to break”. This body is as fragile as softwood. Inside some trees, we can find both softwood and hardwood. While hardwood is strong, firm, resistant to breaking, and lasts very long, softwood is weak and easy to destroy. Similarly, our body is like softwood—fragile and easily broken.

For example, if we eat unsuitable or spoiled food, this body may become gravely ill or even perish. If we expose ourselves to unsuitable environments, such as extreme weather or unsafe surroundings, the body may not survive. Similarly, even the slightest injury or accident can cause severe damage to this fragile body. If struck or harmed in any way, the body's vulnerability becomes immediately apparent.

We must also make constant adjustments to protect the body from discomfort or harm. When traveling, for instance,



we may prefer to use air-conditioned vehicles to avoid heat or pollution. All of these precautions highlight how delicate and easily breakable this body is. Because of this fragility, the body is *asāraka*, without the essence or the strength of the hardwood.

When we develop deep concentration, we can see that all materiality and mentality in the body are in a state of constant arising and perishing. This impermanence underscores the body's lack of essence or firm core. It is inherently weak and not strong enough to resist decay or destruction.

By understanding this nature, we can contemplate, “This body is without essence, without a core, without hardwood, *asāraka*, *asāraka*, it is weak and not strong.” Such contemplation constitutes Right View and Right Thought, a form of *Vipassanā* contemplation. This proper attention and reflection may eventually lead to *Nibbāna*, which is firm, stable, and unchanging, like hardwood (*sāra*). Unlike the body, *Nibbāna* is not weak or easily destroyed like softwood.

8. *Vibhavato* (due to be annihilated)

*vigatabhavatāya, vibhavasambhūtatāya ca vibhavato*³¹

The next contemplation is *Vibhavato*, which means “due to be annihilated” or “having the nature of losing.” This body inherently possesses the nature of annihilation and loss.

vigatabhavatāya (lack of increase)

The first definition is *vigatabhavatāya*, which means the lack of increase. Here, *bhava* refers to increasing or becoming, and *vigata* denotes the absence of such qualities. As it exists, this body is characterized by arising and quickly perishing. Nothing about it endures for long. If we examine it deeply, we will find that there is no sustained growth, no lasting success, and no enduring increase—it always races towards loss.

For example, we often desire to hold onto happiness. We wish to preserve happiness somewhere within this body, hoping to stay happy forever. But this desire is futile because happiness cannot last for long; it inevitably fades away. Similarly, after consuming suitable food, the body may feel refreshed, stable, and comfortable for a short while. But this comfort is also temporary and will soon turn into discomfort.

This fleeting nature of comfort and happiness illustrates the body’s inherent tendency toward loss. It cannot maintain any state of well-being for long. Even when something good

³¹ ***Vibhavato***: as *due to be annihilated* because their becoming disappears, and because their non-becoming comes about.



happens to this body, it is quickly lost. Because of this nature, this body is always losing and never truly increasing. By contemplating this, we can understand that the body is subject to loss.

vibhava-sambhūtatāya (annihilation-view-craving-originated nature)

The second definition is *vibhavasambhūtatāya*. According to the sub-commentary of the Visuddhimagga, this has two meanings.³²

In the first sense, the term *vibhava* can refer to both a form of craving (*vibhavataṇhā*) and a type of wrong view (*vibhavadiṭṭhi*). The latter parts of these compound terms (*taṇhā* and *diṭṭhi*) are elided, leaving simply *vibhava*. Therefore, the definition *vibhavasambhūtatāya* actually refers to *vibhavataṇhāsambhūtatāya* and *vibhavadiṭṭhi-*

³² Visuddhi.Tikā.2.397: *vibhavataṇhā, vibhavadiṭṭhi ca vibhavo uttarapadalopena, tato **vibhavato**, pitusadisassa vā sabhāva hetuno **vibhavato** vināsato sambhūtatāya.*

In this second definition of *vibhavato*, one is to contemplate the five aggregates (*pañcakkhandhā*) as *vibhavasambhūtā*. Here, *vibhavasambhūtā* can be defined as *vibhavato sambhūtā vibhavasambhūtā* (the five aggregates arise because of *vibhava*).

Grammatically, we can understand that *vibhava* here is a *taddhita* (secondary derivative) noun formed by adding the *taddhita-paccaya* (secondary derivative suffix) “*ṇa*” to *vibhava* – *vibhava* + *ṇa* > *vibhava*, with *ṇa* carrying the meaning of *sambhūta*. Hence, *vibhava* is a *sambhūta-taddhita* (secondary derivative noun with the meaning of “arising from”).

Therefore, *vibhava* or *vibhavasambhūta* means “arising” or “happening because of *vibhava*”. There are two meanings for *vibhava* in this context: in the first meaning, *vibhava* refers to *vibhavataṇhā* and *vibhavadiṭṭhi*; in the second meaning, *vibhava* refers to *vinasa*.

sambhūtatāya—arising due to *vibhavataṇhā* and *vibhavadiṭṭhi*.

Vibhavataṇhā refers to the craving for non-existence or annihilation, while *vibhavadiṭṭhi* denotes the wrong view that there is no rebirth after death, that life ceases completely upon death, and that there is no continuity of existence. People with this view believe that everything ends at death and attach themselves to the idea of annihilation. *Vibhavataṇhā* is the attachment to such a wrong view (*vibhavadiṭṭhi*).

The body originates from such craving and wrong view, both of which are called *vibhava* (*The Wrong-view-Vibhava*). Because this body is created as a result of those causes called *vibhava*, it is also termed *vibhava*.

In the second meaning, *vibhava* means *vināsa*—destruction or perishing. Here, *vibhavasambhūtatāya* refers to *vināsasambhūtatāya*—arising dependent on the destruction of its appropriate causes. This is similar to the father being the proper cause for the son’s coming into being. However, unlike the notion of an eternal creator, the cause here itself possesses the nature of impermanence and is subject to destruction. Because the cause is subject to perishing, the effect that depends upon it is likewise subject to perishing after it has arisen—just as a son shares the same nature of eventual passing as his father.

The body, being a product of ignorance, craving, formations, and other causes, shares the same impermanent nature as its



origin, and thus the saying “Like father like son” applies here too. Causes such as ignorance, craving, and formations arise and perish quickly. Consequently, the results they produce—like this body—also arise and perish quickly. Thus, this body is characterized by loss and the absence of increase, as *vibhava* (the real *Vibhava*), as it inherits the nature of its originating causes.

By seeing this nature, we can contemplate, “This body has the nature of losing, *vibhava*, *vibhava*.” Such contemplation aligns with Right View and Right Thought, making it a form of *Vipassanā*. Through this proper reflection, one may eventually realize *Nibbāna*, which is free from the nature of losing (*avibhava*).

9. *Maraṇadhammato* (subject to death)

*jāti-jarā-byādhī-maraṇa-pakatitāya jāti-jarā-byādhī-maraṇa-dhammato*³³

The next contemplation is *maraṇadhammato*, which means that this body has the nature of death. This truth is direct and undeniable. The Mahāpadāna Sutta continues to describe this through the story of Prince Vipassī:

As Prince Vipassī was being driven to the pleasure park, he saw a large crowd collecting, clad in many colors, and

³³ *Jāti-jarā-byādhī-maraṇadhammato*: as subject to birth, to aging, to illness, and to death because of having birth, aging, illness and death as their nature. Here, only *maraṇadhammato* is applicable as a synonym for *anicca*. The other three are synonyms of *dukkha*.

carrying a bier. At the sight, he said to the charioteer:
“Why are those people doing that?”

“Prince, that is what they call a dead man.”

“Drive me over to where the dead man is.”

“Very good, Prince”, said the charioteer, and did so. And Prince Vipassī gazed at the corpse of the dead man. Then he said to the charioteer: “Why is he called a dead man?”

“Prince, he is called a dead man because now his parents and other relatives will not see him again, nor he them.”

“But am I subject to dying, not exempt from dying?”

“Both you and I, Prince, are subject to dying, not exempt from it.”³⁴

This narrative encapsulates an essential truth of life: all living beings, without exception, are subject to death. Death is the ultimate destination for all who are born.

In a deeper sense, death is not just the final cessation of life. In every single mind moment of our existence, materiality and mentality within our bodies are continuously perishing. Death occurs every single mind moment.

By seeing such nature, we need to contemplate, “This body is subject to death; it has the nature of death, *marañadhamma*, *marañadhamma*”. This form of reflection aligns with the Right View and is beneficial. It can eventually lead to

³⁴ Dī.2.22 (DN 14 Mahāpadāna Sutta - Kālaṅkatapuriso) [English Translation by Bhikkhu Bodhi]



Nibbāna, the deathless (*amata*) state, which transcends and is not subject to the nature of death.

10. *Sañkhatato* (formed)

*hetupaccayehi abhisāṅkhatatāya saṅkhatato*³⁵

The next contemplation is *Saṅkhatato*, which means “being conditioned” or “being created by causes”. This body is created by causes. Causes give rise to effects, and because the body is created by causes, it is referred to as *saṅkhata* (formed).

Even our materiality, our physical body, is conditioned by various causes. Some of these causes are direct, while others are supportive. For example, one primary cause is *kamma*, the *kamma* we have accumulated in the past. We observe that people differ in appearance: some are beautiful, others less so; some are strong, while others are weak; some are healthy, while others suffer from illnesses. These differences arise from the variations in accumulated *kamma*. Hence, *kamma* serves as a direct cause for the formation of the body.

In addition to *kamma* as a direct cause, there are supporting causes. For example, even if someone is healthy and strong, neglecting nutrition will lead to decline and eventually death. Thus, consuming appropriate food is a supporting factor for maintaining or sustaining the body. Similarly, if one does not stay in good weather, it can negatively impact health and

³⁵ ***Saṅkhatato***: as *formed* because of being formed by causes and conditions.

shorten life. Hence, exposure to favorable environmental conditions is another essential supporting condition for the body. Furthermore, the mind is another cause that influences the body. For example, when we are angry, the body becomes tense and uncomfortable. In some cases, anger can even trigger severe consequences, such as death, for individuals with heart conditions. This shows that the body is created and sustained by numerous causes.

This dependency on causes is not good. If the body were not conditioned by causes, it could conform to our desires, and that would be more ideal. However, since it is conditioned, the body does not function according to our wishes but rather depends on many causes. To maintain the body, we need to have accumulated good *kamma*, eat suitable food, reside in favorable weather conditions, and cultivate a wholesome state of mind. Because the body is so dependent on causes and conditions, it often fails to align with our desires. By understanding this reality, we need to contemplate, "This body is created by conditions, created by causes, *saṅkhata*, *saṅkhata*."

Similarly, the mind is also created by causes. It is dependent on its object, associated mental states, and other conditions. There are many supporting conditions. For example, here in a meditation retreat, we need to focus on a suitable object, such as the breath, to develop a calm and concentrated mind. If the object is unwholesome or distracting, the mind becomes agitated or unbalanced. This is why we practice



breathing meditation—to give the mind a good and appropriate object to focus on.

In addition, we have come to the forest to seek seclusion because the city is filled with many distracting objects. In such an environment, it is difficult for the mind to remain peaceful or to cultivate positive states.

While we are here in a secluded place, we also need to observe silence. Even if we wish to speak with others, we restrain ourselves to develop concentration. This shows that even speech influences the mind.

Our mind is also affected by what we eat. For instance, during breakfast, if we eat excessively until we are overly full, we will feel drowsy and unable to meditate afterward. Thus, even food has a direct impact on the mind.

Both the body and the mind are dependent on various conditions and created by multiple causes. If these conditions are unfavorable, undesirable outcomes arise. Recognizing this reality, we must understand and accept that life is inherently conditioned.

We need to contemplate, “This body is created by various conditions, it is created by multiple causes, *saṅkhata*, *saṅkhata*.” Such contemplation ultimately leads to *Nibbāna*, which is *asaṅkhata*—unconditioned, not subject to causes, and supremely peaceful.

Today, we have completed the first ten “-to” among the forty of them. These are synonyms for *anicca* (impermanence). I intend to help you understand the nature of *Vipassanā* and

the proper way to practice *Vipassanā* contemplation. This true understanding of life is deeply beneficial. If you practice such contemplation, it is very beneficial, reduces defilements, and can ultimately lead to *Nibbāna*.

So far, we have explored ten “-to” terms related to *anicca* (impermanence). We will continue to examine those terms related to *dukkha* (suffering).

Dukkha

1. *Dukkhatō* (painful)

*uppādavayapaṭipīlanatāya, dukkhavatthutāya ca dukkhato*³⁶

The first contemplation is *dukkhatō*, meaning “as suffering”. We should contemplate that this body is suffering. What do you think about your body—is it suffering? If you sit for a long time, you will understand. If you tell me, “This body is happy”, I will give a long talk, and you will have to accept that this body is suffering. It is easy to agree on the suffering nature of our body.

uppāda-vaya-paṭipīlanatāya (Oppressed by arising and perishing)

The body is suffering because it is oppressed by arising and perishing (*uppāda-vaya-paṭipīlanatāya*). It is always arising and perishing, and because of this, it is being oppressed. If we examine this body as mentality and materiality with a concentrated mind, we will see that it is constantly arising and perishing. This is true not only for our internal body but for everything external as well—whatever we see is arising and perishing very quickly. Therefore, everything is being oppressed by arising and perishing. Seeing this, we should

³⁶ ***dukkhatō***: as *painful* because of oppression by rise and fall, and because of being the basis for pain.

contemplate: “This body, as well as everything external to us, is suffering, *dukkha, dukkha*.”

Even ordinary people who have not yet developed the ability to discern the arising and perishing of materiality and mentality can still gain some understanding of how this process of arising and perishing gives rise to suffering. Sometimes we are very happy, and the body is healthy, but we cannot maintain this happiness for long. For example, while meditating, there may be a very good sitting where we feel happy and peaceful, but the quality of the next sitting is uncertain and may change. This can lead to dissatisfaction or disappointment. It is being oppressed by arising and perishing. After eating a good meal, your stomach feels full and you feel good, but after the food is digested, your stomach is empty again, and you feel hungry. In this way, whatever we experience in life is transient. We cannot maintain or hold on to it for long. After something arises, it will inevitably perish over time. Because of this, this body is very much a source of suffering.

dukkha-vatthutāya (base of suffering)

Another definition is that this body is the base of suffering (*dukkha-vatthutāya*). Therefore, it is suffering. Whoever possesses a body—made up of mentality and materiality—has a base for suffering to arise. There are three kinds of suffering in life:

- i. *Dukkha-dukkha* –double *dukkha*. The double *dukkha* in Pāḷi means that it is real *dukkha*, real suffering. This refers



to direct suffering, such as physical pain or unpleasant mental feelings. When the body is in pain or the mind is unhappy, we experience painful feelings (*dukkhavedanā*). As this is directly experienced as suffering, it is called *dukkhadukkha*.

ii. *Vipariṇāma-dukkha* – changing-suffering or suffering due to change. This is suffering that arises from the impermanence of pleasant experiences. For instance, we may be happy at this moment, our meditation is going well, our concentration is very good, and we are very peaceful. We wish to hold on to this happy and peaceful feeling. We worry that this desirable state may change and disappear later. We are uncertain about the quality of our next sitting. In this way, even though we are happy, the nature of change brings suffering. Similarly, someone who is wealthy may fear losing their wealth. Because this state of wealth has the intrinsic nature of change, it will not last forever. Even though we are healthy and our body feels good, we still need to worry about becoming ill. Because this state of good health will not last, and it may deteriorate later. In this way, we may be alright and happy at present. However, even while experiencing happy feelings (*sukhavedanā*), we fear its eventual loss – this is the suffering caused by the nature of change. This is what we call *vipariṇāma-dukkha* – suffering due to change.

iii. *Saṅkhāra-dukkha* – formations suffering or suffering due to formations. *Saṅkhāra* refers to that which is created or conditioned by causes. Everything in this world is created

by causes and dependent on conditions. When those causes or conditions change, the formations deteriorate or are destroyed. For example, our body is dependent on the weather, and if the weather changes, our body may experience pain. Similarly, our body depends on food, and if we eat the wrong food or take unsuitable medicine, the body suffers. Moreover, our body is dependent on the *kamma* we have accumulated in the past. If a certain bad *kamma* produces results, our body may change for the worse. Someone who was once very beautiful may become less so, and a healthy person may become sick. All of these are examples of formations suffering. Formations are created by causes, and because of this dependence on causes, all materiality and mentality are constantly arising and perishing. Apart from *dukkhadukkha* and *vipariṇāmadukkha*, all remaining situations are included under formations suffering (*saṅkhāra-dukkha*).

Thus, this body is the base for real suffering (*dukkha-dukkha*), the suffering due to change (*vipariṇāma-dukkha*), and the formations suffering (*saṅkhāra-dukkha*). Understanding this, we can contemplate, “This body is suffering, suffering, *dukkha, dukkha.*”

Another way to reflect on the body as the base of suffering (*dukkha-vatthutāya*) is by considering *saṃsāra dukkha*. *Saṃsāra dukkha* refers to the suffering related to existence—suffering inherent in the cycle of rebirths. Whoever has a body must face various forms of suffering.



In the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta³⁷, the Buddha’s first discourse, the Buddha explained suffering:

(1) *jātipi dukkha* – being born or rebirth is also suffering. People often wish others “Happy Birthday,” but is it “Happy Birthday” or “Suffering Birthday”? What is commonly said by everyone is different from what is taught by the Buddha. The Buddha says *jātipi dukkhā* – rebirth is also suffering, but people prefer to say “Happy birthday”. If you look backward and see the day when you were born, at the moment of delivery, you were crying, and your mother was also in great pain. So perhaps what the Buddha said is more accurate. Is there anyone who comes out of the mother’s womb laughing and greeting others by saying “hello”? The truth is like how we always chant, “*anekajāti-saṃsāraṃ, sandhāviṣsaṃ anibbisāṃ, gahakāraṃ gavesanto, dukkhā jāti punappunāṃ*” (Through countless births in *saṃsāra* I have wandered without finding. While seeking the housebuilder, to be born again and again is suffering.). *Dukkha jāti punappunnaṃ* - being born again and again is suffering. Therefore, I am a bit hesitant to say, “Happy Birthday”. It is like saying what is opposite to the Buddha’s teaching. So, being born is also suffering.

(2) *jarāpi dukkhā* – aging is also suffering. As we age, our body becomes less capable and less comfortable. When we were young, we could climb stairs with ease, even skipping to climb

³⁷ Saṃ.3.369 (SN 56.11)

two levels with each step of the foot. Later, we can only climb one level with each step. Eventually, when we become frail, we need to take two small steps for each level. Aging is indeed also suffering.

(3) *byādhīpi dukkho* – sickness is also suffering. (4) *marañampi dukkhaṃ* – death is also suffering. (5) *appiyehi sampayogo dukkho* – associating with someone or something we hate is also suffering. (6) *piyehi vippayogo dukkho* – separation from beloved ones or beloved things is also suffering in life. (7) *yampicchaṃ na labhati tampi dukkhaṃ* – not obtaining what one longs for is also suffering. (8) *saṃkhittena pañcupādānakkhandhā dukkha* – in brief, the five aggregates of clinging are suffering.

Thus, whoever has a body needs to face various forms of suffering. Human life is considered a good destination; we are much better off than animals or those in the other woeful states. Nonetheless, we still suffer because this body is the base of all suffering. Because of this body, we must seek food, find shelter, earn money, and endure countless hardships. We encounter suffering because of this body. Hence, this body is truly the base of suffering.

We need to contemplate, “This body is suffering, suffering, *dukkha, dukkha*.” Such contemplation leads to Nibbāna, which is the cessation of suffering, freedom from suffering, and the realization of true happiness (*sukha*).



2. *Rogato* (a disease)

*paccayayāpanīyatāya, rogamūlatāya ca **rogato***³⁸

The next contemplation is *rogato* (disease). We need to contemplate the body as a disease. This body is a disease.

paccaya-yāpanīyatāya (maintained by conditions)

Why is it a disease? Because it is maintained by conditions (*paccaya-yāpanīyatāya*). Materiality is sustained by four conditions: *kamma*, mind, temperature, and food. There are many conditions for mentality, such as attention, etc. Since the body is maintained by various causes and conditions, when those conditions change, the body also suffers. As a result, we become sick, sorrowful, and experience other forms of discomfort.

When we have a disease, the body requires special care to maintain a delicate balance of suitable conditions. For example, if we are sick, the food we eat must be appropriate for curing the illness. We need to take medicine and stay in the right kind of weather. The mind also needs to be in a good state. Some people with heart disease, for instance, must be careful not to get angry. This shows that the mind is one of the conditions that needs to be balanced. The mind must be good and remain peaceful, which is why we go to meditation retreats to cultivate good conditions for the mind.

³⁸ **Rogato**: as a disease because of having to be maintained by conditions, and because of being the root of disease.

This situation is like having a disease. Our body needs to be maintained carefully, with suitable causes and conditions. If we do not take care of it properly—such as by eating unsuitable food—we will suffer. In short, this body is like a disease.

I have heard some people say, “Everyone has cells with the potential to become cancerous in their body. The only difference is whether those cells multiply uncontrollably or remain under control.” As long as we have the right supporting conditions, those cells will not grow out of control and become cancerous. However, if something goes wrong, they will grow uncontrollably. This shows that this body inherently possesses a disease.

Roga-mūlatāya (the root of disease)

Another definition is that the body is the root of disease (*roga-mūlatāya*). Because it is the root cause of disease, this body is a disease.³⁹ Why do we experience illness? Because we have this body. Whoever has a body is subject to disease. This body welcomes many diseases. Since it is the root of disease, we call this body, “*Roga, roga, disease, disease.*”

³⁹ Añ.3.220 (AN 9.36 Jhāna Sutta):

*so yadeva tattha hoti rūpagataṃ vedanāgataṃ saññāgataṃ saṅkhāragataṃ viññāgataṃ, te dhamme aniccato dukkhato **rogato** gaṇḍato sallato aghato ābādhato parato palokato suññato anattato samanupassati.*

He considers whatever phenomena exist there pertaining to materiality, feeling, perception, volitional activities, and consciousness as impermanent, suffering, **an illness**, a boil, a dart, misery, affliction, alien, disintegrating, empty, and non-self.



Some people explain that the word “disease” means “dis + ease”, which implies “not at ease” or “not in a comfortable state”. When we have a disease, we are not at ease. Even when we sit for a long time, the body becomes uncomfortable; it is not easy to remain comfortable for an extended period, which shows that the body itself has become “dis-eased”.

We need to contemplate, “This body is a disease, *roga, roga*.” By contemplating in this way, it will lead to *Nibbāna*, which is free from all diseases (*ārogya*).

3. *Aghato* (a calamity/evil)

*vigaraṇṇīyatāya, avaḍḍhiāvahanatāya, aghavatthutāya ca aghato*⁴⁰

The next contemplation is *aghato*. *Agha* originally refers to unwholesomeness or evil. This body is like unwholesomeness. This body is evil.

vigaraṇṇīyatāya (blameworthy)

The first definition is that this body is blameworthy (*vigaraṇṇīyatāya*). Noble beings such as the Buddhas and the Buddha’s disciples would blame this body.⁴¹ They

⁴⁰ **Aghato**: as a calamity because of having to be condemned, because of bringing loss, and because of being the basis for calamity.

⁴¹ Añ.1.36 (AN 1.328 Tatiyavaggo):

recognize its flaws and see it as blamable, as it is comparable to evil and unwholesomeness.

avaḍḍhi-āvahanatāya (bringing loss)

Another definition is that this body brings disadvantages (*avaḍḍhi-āvahanatāya*). It can cause many losses and troubles. For example, the constant need to search for food to sustain this body may lead to difficulties. If we commit misconduct using this body, we will suffer undesirable consequences in the future. In this way, this body can be considered evil or unwholesome, as it leads to harm and loss.

agha-vatthutāya (the base of sin)

Another definition is that this body serves as the base of unwholesomeness or evil (*agha-vatthutāya*). Because we have this body, we sometimes commit evil actions. For instance, when a mosquito bites us, we may kill it. In doing so, evil unwholesomeness arises in our minds. Similarly, those who lack understanding of the Dhamma and find themselves without food or shelter may resort to stealing or even killing. These evils arise because of the body.

Many people commit unwholesome actions due to the demands of the body. Why do they commit unwholesome

“seyyathāpi, bhikkhave, appamattakopi gūtho duggandho hoti; evamevaṃ kho ahaṃ, bhikkhave, appamattakampi bhavaṃ na vaṇṇemi, antamaso accharāsaṅghātamattampi”.

“Bhikkhus, just as even a trifling amount of faeces is foul-smelling, so too I do not praise even a trifling amount of existence, even for a mere finger snap.”



kamma? Because of this body. It is the base of evil and unwholesomeness.

It is common for unwholesomeness to arise in our lives, whereas cultivating wholesomeness is much more difficult. Some people even justify evil actions, thinking they are necessary to sustain the body. They may not avoid stealing or killing, believing such acts are required for survival. Even when we strive to act wholesomely, we may inadvertently do unwholesome things—all because of this body. This body is truly the base of evil and unwholesomeness.

Therefore, we should contemplate, “This body is evil, this body is unwholesome, *agha*, *agha*.” By reflecting in this way, we can progress toward *Nibbāna*, which is completely free from all evil and unwholesomeness (*anagha*).

Therefore, the fully-enlightened Buddha describes himself in these words:⁴²

***“aghajātassa ve nandī, nandījātassa ve aghaṃ.
anandī anagho bhikkhu, evaṃ jānāhi āvuso”ti.***

⁴² Saṃ.1.53 (SN 2.18 Kakudha Sutta). [English translation by Bhikkhu Bodhi]

Delight is for one who is **miserable**,
Misery for one filled with delight.⁴³
As a bhikkhu undelighted, untroubled:
you should know (me) in this way, friend.

4. *Gaṇḍato* (a boil)

*dukkhatāsūlayogitāya, kilesāsucipaggharaṇatāya,
uppādajarābhaṅgehi uddhumātaparipakkapabhinnatāya ca
gaṇḍato*⁴⁴

The next contemplation is *gaṇḍato*. *Gaṇḍa* refers to a kind of wound, such as an unsightly boil or swelling on the body.

dukkhatā-sūla-yogitāya (pain associated)

The first definition is that the body is related to pain and suffering (*dukkhatā-sūla-yogitāya*). A swollen wound or a boil is often painful. Inside the wound, there is a painful feeling. Similarly, having this body means we inevitably experience pain. Sometimes, we feel sadness, sorrow, or worry—painful feelings arise within this body. In this way, this body is like a

⁴³ According to the commentary, *agha* here refers to *vaṭṭadukkha* (the suffering inherent in the cycle of rebirths). As it is said, “One who is suffering longs for happiness”. Hence, delight (*nandī*) arises in one who experiences suffering associated with the cycle of rebirths (*aghajātassa*). Conversely, for one who takes delight (*nandijātassa*), suffering (*dukkhaṃ/aghamaṃ*) arises when changes occur, and happiness fades away (*sukhavipariṇāmena*). The fully-enlightened Buddha has transcended both *saṃsāric*-suffering and delight.

⁴⁴ **gaṇḍato**: as a boil because of being consequent upon impalement by suffering, because of oozing with the filth of defilements, and because of being swollen by arising, ripened by aging, and burst by dissolution.



wound or a boil, connected with pain and suffering (*dukkhatā-sūla-yogitāya*).

kilesāsuci-paggharanatāya (oozing impurity of defilement)

Another definition is the oozing of impure defilements (*kilesāsuci-paggharaṇatāya*). A boil may ooze pus, which is white, smelly, and disgusting. In the same way, this body produces unwholesomeness and defilements. Sometimes anger arises, sometimes attachment, sometimes lust. These defilements flow out like pus from a boil—disgusting and foul.

Even in the mind of a meditator or a monk, defilements may surface from time to time. Anger or lust may arise, defiling the mind. Just as a boil produces unpleasant pus, this body produces defilements that are similarly unpleasant and impure. This is why the body is like a swollen wound or a boil.

uppāda-jarā-bhaṅgehi uddhumāta-paripakka-pabhinnatāya (swelling, ripening, and bursting of a boil like the arising, aging and perishing of the body)

Another definition relates to the three stages of a boil: swelling, ripening, and bursting (*uppāda-jarā-bhaṅgehi uddhumāta-paripakka-pabhinnatāya*). These stages parallel the arising, aging, and perishing of the body (the materiality and mentality).

The 1st stage of a boil is *uddhumāta*, the initial swelling or bloating of the boil, which corresponds to the arising or birth of the body; the 2nd stage is *paripakka*, the ripening of the

boil, with pus forming inside, like the aging process of the body. Finally, the 3rd stage is *pabhinna*, the bursting of the boil, where the skin ruptures and pus flows out, which is comparable to the perishing or death of the body.

In every moment, this body undergoes these three stages—arising, aging, and perishing—even though it may not always be evident. An advanced meditator can observe these momentary stages in detail, but even ordinary people can understand the stages of birth, subsequent aging, and eventual death. This body, therefore, resembles a swollen wound or a boil.

This is the description of the body in the Milindapañha:

*“Alla-camma-paṭicchanno, nava-dvāro mahāvaṇo;
Samantato paggharati, asuci-pūti-gandhiyo”ti.*

“Covered with clammy skin, an impure thing and foul,
Nine-apertured, it oozes, like a sore.”⁴⁵

Understanding this, we should contemplate, “This body is like a swollen wound or a boil, *gaṇḍa*, *gaṇḍa*.” Contemplating in this way will lead us to *Nibbāna*, which is completely free from such wounds or boils (*agaṇḍa*).

⁴⁵ Khu.11.78 Milindapañhe (Milindapañha page 78). [English Translation by Rhys Davids]



5. *Sallato* (a dart)

*pīlājanakatāya, antotudanatāya, dunnīharaṇīyatāya ca sallato*⁴⁶

The next contemplation is *sallato*. *Salla* means a thorn—a thorn that has pierced into the flesh of the body. We need to reflect on the body as a *salla*, a dart of a thorn.

pīlā-janakatāya (oppression)

The first definition is that it causes oppression to the body (*pīlā-janakatāya*). If a thorn pierces the body, it is very painful and creates oppression. Similarly, this body causes oppression through its constant arising and perishing. This body is therefore like a dart or thorn, bringing pain and discomfort.

Anto-tudanatāya (piercing inside)

Another definition relates to the piercing of the thorn deep into the body (*anto-tudanatāya*). When a thorn pierces through the skin and into our flesh, it causes pain not only on the surface of the skin but also deep within. Painful feeling is felt inside the body. Similarly, within the body—comprising materiality and mentality—there is pain and suffering felt deep inside, just like a thorn piercing the flesh.

For example, when diseases affect the internal organs such as the liver, intestines, or heart, painful feelings arise within

⁴⁶ ***Salato***: as *a dart* because of producing oppression, because of penetrating inside, and because of being hard to extract.

the body, not merely on the surface. Even the bones and bone marrow can suffer from diseases. It is because of such internal pains that blood or tissue samples are taken from within the body for proper diagnosis in the laboratory. This is comparable to having a thorn inside our body. Just as someone pierced by a thorn experiences pain within the flesh and not just at the surface, our body similarly harbors internal painful feelings, caused by the thorn-like nature of suffering.

dunnīharaṇīyatāya (hard to remove)

The third definition relates to the difficulty in removing a thorn (*dunnīharaṇīyatāya*). When a thorn pierces the skin and lodges deep inside the flesh, attempting to remove it often causes even more pain. It is very difficult to extract the thorn. Similarly, when we come to understand that this body is a source of suffering, we may wish to be free from it. We wish to remove this body—this thorn of materiality and mentality.

However, removing this thorn is not easy. To extract the thorn of materiality and mentality, we must meditate. The process of meditation, like removing a thorn, can sometimes feel painful and challenging, as if incurring even more suffering. It is very difficult to remove our body. Ultimately, only when we attain arahantship and enter into final *parinibbāna* can we completely extract this thorn of materiality and mentality, achieving the cessation of the body and all suffering. Is it easy to realize arahantship? Realizing arahantship is no easy task, which further underscores the



difficulty of removing this thorn of existence. Thus, the body is like a thorn, deeply embedded and hard to extract.

Understanding this, we should contemplate, “This body is like a thorn, *salla, salla*.” Such contemplation will lead to the realization of *Nibbāna*, which is free from all thorns (*visalla*).

6. *Ābādhato* (an affliction)

*aseribhāvajanakatāya, ābādhapadaṭṭhānatāya ca ābādhato*⁴⁷

The next contemplation is *ābādhato*. *Ābādha* means sickness. We should view the body as a sickness.

aseri-bhāva-janakatāya (non-independence)

Why is the body considered sick? One definition is that sickness gives rise to a state of non-independence (*aseri-bhāva-janakatāya*). When a person is sick, he is dependent on others for help. He cannot perform even simple tasks such as sitting up, standing, or lying down without assistance. He is reliant on others for support.

Similarly, this body is not independent of its causes and conditions. The body cannot sustain itself alone; it is dependent on various causes to exist. It requires good food, favorable weather, proper clothing, and many other

⁴⁷ ***ābādhato***: as *an affliction* because of restricting freedom, and because of being the foundation for affliction.

supportive conditions. Without these, the body cannot survive.

For example, we cannot endure the scorching heat of the sun or the pouring rain without seeking shelter in a building. In this way, we are like sick individuals—always in need of assistance. Just as a sick person depends on others' help, anyone with this body depends on the support of favorable conditions.

ābādha-padaṭṭhānatāya (cause of sickness)

Another definition is that the body is the proximate cause of sickness (*ābādha-padaṭṭhānatāya*). Since this body is the root cause of many illnesses, it is likened to a sickness itself.

Understanding this, we should contemplate, “This body is a disease, *ābādha*, *ābādha*”. Such contemplation will lead to the realization of *Nibbāna*, which is free from all sicknesses (*anābādha*).

7. *Upaddavato* (a disaster)

*aviditānaṃyeva vipulānaṃ anattānaṃ āvahanato,
sabbupaddava-vatthutāya ca **upaddavato***⁴⁸

The next contemplation is *upaddavato*. *Upaddava* refers to a kind of disaster, a form of suffering that oppresses this body very closely.

⁴⁸ **upaddavato**: as a disaster because of bringing unforeseen and plentiful adversity, and because of being the basis for all kinds of terror.



anattānam āvahanato (bringing disadvantages)

One definition of *upaddava* is that this body brings countless unknown disadvantages (*aviditānaṃyeva vipulānaṃ anattānaṃ āvahanato*). As long as we possess this body, we will face numerous disadvantages. This body will bring many unknown disadvantages.

For instance, when a baby is born, we often celebrate with a “happy birthday”, yet that birth is the start of welcoming countless disadvantages. How many? They are uncountable. Social problems, political problems, economic struggles, punishment by authorities, old age, sickness, death, and even falling into woeful states – all these stem from the possession of this body.

This body is an *upaddava*, a disaster that oppresses us not from afar but very closely. It creates pain and suffering, staying intimately connected to us.

sabbupaddava-vatthutāya (base for all disasters)

Another definition is that the body is the base for all dangers (*sabbupaddava-vatthutāya*), therefore it is *upaddava*. This body is inseparable from us, and all dangers that afflict us arise because of it. We cannot avoid encountering various forms of calamity due to the existence of this body. In this way, the body is the base of all disasters.

Understanding this, we should contemplate, “This body is a danger, *upaddava*, *upaddava*.” Such contemplation will lead us to the realization of *Nibbāna*, which is completely free from all dangers (*anupaddava*).

8. *Bhayato* (a terror)

*sabbabhayānaṃ ākaratāya, dukkhavūpasamasan̄khātassa paramassāsassa paṭipakkhabhūtatāya ca **bhayato***⁴⁹

The next contemplation is *bhayato* (terror). We need to reflect on this body, or mentality and materiality, or the five aggregates, as a source of fear and terror.

sabba-bhayānaṃ ākaratāya (producer of all terror)

One definition is that this body is the place of production of all fearful dangers (*sabba-bhayānaṃ ākaratāya*). This body serves as the place where all terrifying dangers are generated. It is the foundation upon which every kind of fearful danger arises.

If we possess a body, we are essentially inviting numerous types of fearful dangers. Even though we put immense effort into safeguarding our bodies—securing them from harm and keeping them away from peril—we still encounter countless dangers. The body, as such, is a source of fear and terror.

The commentary to the Āsīvisopama Sutta mentions that there are twenty-five great fears (*pañcavīsati mahābhayāni*) rooted in the four kinds of birth⁵⁰. In the Khuddaka-vatthu-

⁴⁹ **bhayato**: as a terror because of being the producer of all terror and because of being the opposite of the supreme comfort called the stilling of all suffering.

⁵⁰ Saṃ.Ṭṭha.3.62 (Commentary to SN 35.238 Āsīvisopama Sutta):
... nandīrāgo panesa aṇḍajādibhedā catasso yoniyo upaneti. tassa yoniupagamanamūlakāni **pañcavīsati mahābhayāni** dvattiṃsa kammakāraṇāni ca āgatāneva hontīti ...



vibhaṅga, we find various types of fears or dangers listed as follows:⁵¹

fear of birth, fear of aging, fear of illness, fear of death,
fear of kings, fear of thieves, fear of fire, fear of water,
fear of waves, fear of crocodiles, fear of whirlpools, fear

Moreover, this delight-and-lust leads to the four kinds of birth beginning with egg-born. The **twenty-five great fears** and thirty-two types of torture that are rooted in going to these births come accordingly.

⁵¹ Abhi.2.390-391,393 (Vibhaṅgapāḷi, Khuddakavatthuvibhaṅgo, catukkaniddeso & pañcakaniddeso):

Catukkaniddeso:

(13) cattāri bhayāni

tattha katamāni cattāri bhayāni? jātibhayaṃ, jarābhayaṃ, byādhibhayaṃ, maraṇabhayaṃ — imāni cattāri bhayāni. (also in Añ.1.436 - AN 4.119 Paṭhamabhaya Sutta)

(14) aparānipi cattāri bhayāni

tattha katamāni aparānipi cattāri bhayāni? rājabhayaṃ, corabhayaṃ, aggibhayaṃ, udakabhayaṃ — imāni cattāri bhayāni. (also in Añ.1.436 - AN 4.120 Dutiyabhaya Sutta)

tattha katamāni aparānipi cattāri bhayāni? ūmibhayaṃ, kumbhīlabhayaṃ, āvaṭṭabhayaṃ, susukābhayaṃ — imāni cattāri bhayāni. (also in Añ.1.438 - AN 4.122 Ūmibhaya Sutta)

tattha katamāni aparānipi cattāri bhayāni? attānuvādabhayaṃ, parānuvādabhayaṃ, daṇḍabhayaṃ, duggatibhayaṃ — imāni cattāri bhayāni. (also in Añ.1.436 - AN 4.121 Attānuvāda Sutta)

Pañcakaniddeso:

(12) pañca byasanā

tattha katame pañca byasanā? ñātibyasaṇaṃ, bhogabyasaṇaṃ, rogabyasaṇaṃ, silabyasaṇaṃ, diṭṭhibyasaṇaṃ — ime pañca byasanā. (also in Añ.2.129 - AN 5.130 Byasana Sutta)

(14) pañca bhayāni

tattha katamāni pañca bhayāni? ājīvakabhayaṃ, asilokabhayaṃ, parisasārajjabhayaṃ, maraṇabhayaṃ, duggatibhayaṃ — imāni pañca bhayāni. (also in Añ.3.174 - AN 9.5 Bala Sutta)

of fierce fish⁵², fear of self-reproach, fear of others' reproach, fear of punishment, fear of unfortunate destinations, disaster due to [loss of] relatives, disaster due to [loss of] wealth, disaster due to illness, disaster concerning virtuous behavior, disaster concerning wrong views, fear concerning livelihood, fear of disrepute, fear of timidity in assemblies, and ⁵³fear of famine.

Therefore, as long as we possess this body, we cannot avoid encountering various types of fears and dangers.⁵⁴

⁵² In Añ.1.438 - AN 4.122 Ūmibhava Sutta, the Buddha explains these four fears or dangers – waves (*ūmi*), crocodiles (*kumbhīla*), whirlpools (*āvatta*), and fierce fish (*susukā*) as designations of anger and irritation (*kodhūpāyāsa*), gluttony (*odarikatta*), the five objects of sensual pleasure (*pañca kāmagaṇā*), and women (*mātugāma*) respectively for the ordained ones.

⁵³ The last two fears listed under *pañcabhayāni* in the Khuddaka-vatthu-vibhaṅga—fear of death (*maraṇabhaya*) and fear of an unfortunate destination (*duggatibhaya*)—have already been mentioned earlier in the list of fears. These duplications are removed and replaced with the fear of famine (*dubbhikkhabhaya*), bringing the total to twenty-five great fears (*pañcavīsati mahābhayāni*).

⁵⁴ There is an alternative list of fears or dangers in the preliminary section of Paritta chants as follows:

... *rājato vā, corato vā, manussato vā, amanussato vā, aggito vā, udakato vā, pisācato vā, khāṇukato vā, kaṇṭakato vā, nakkhattato vā, janapadarogato vā, asaddhammato vā, asandiṭṭhito vā, asappuriso vā, caṇḍa-hatthi-assa-miga-goṇa-kukkura-ahi-vicchika-maṇisappa-dīpi-accha-taraccha-sūkara-mahiṃsa-yakkha-rakkhasādīhi, nānabhayato vā, nānārogato vā, nānāupaddavato vā, ārakkhaṃ gaṇhantu.*

(May you be protected) from the king, thieves, humans, non-humans, fire, water, demons, stumps, thorns, unlucky stars, epidemics, what is not the true dhamma, not right view, not a good person, and from fierce elephants, horses, antelopes, bulls, dogs, snakes, scorpions, poisonous



dukkha-vūpasama-saṅkhātassa paramassāsassa
paṭipakkha-bhūtatāya (opposite to Nibbāna)

Another definition is that the body stands in direct opposite to *Nibbāna*, which is the cessation of suffering and the ultimate comfort (*dukkha-vūpasama-saṅkhātassa paramassāsassa paṭipakkha-bhūtatāya*).

Nibbāna signifies the complete cessation of suffering. It is a state of freedom from suffering where there is neither arising nor perishing, no conditioning, and no dependence on causes. On the other hand, this body is the exact opposite of *Nibbāna*. It is constantly arising and perishing, entirely conditioned, and dependent on numerous causes for its existence. *Nibbāna* is free from all fearful dangers,⁵⁵ while

serpents, panthers, bears, hyenas, wild boars, buffaloes, *yakkhas*, *rakkhasas*, and so on, from the manifold fears, the manifold diseases, the manifold calamities, (from all of these troubles) may you receive protection.

Out of the list of fears listed above, *maṇisappa* (poisonous serpents) can be included under *ahi* (snakes), while *pisāca* (demon), *yakkha*, and *rakkhasa* can be included under *amanussa* (non-humans), therefore also giving a total of 25 fears.

⁵⁵ In the standard description of one who has become stream-enterer (*sotāpanna*), one of the epithets is *vesārajappatto* – attaining the state of fearlessness (or self-confidence). This is because he has seen *Nibbāna* which has no fear.

The standard description of a *sotāpanna*:

Dī.1.102-103 (DN 3 Ambaṭṭha Sutta) etc.:

... *diṭṭhadhammo pattadhammo viditadhammo pariyogāḷhadhammo*
*tiṇṇavicikiccho vigata-kathaṃkatho **vesārajappatto** aparappaccayo*
satthusāsane...

...one who had seen the *Dhamma*, attained the *Dhamma*, understood the *Dhamma*, fathomed the *Dhamma*, crossed over doubt, gotten rid of bewilderment, **attained self-confidence**, and become independent of others in the teaching of the Teacher...

the body is filled with them. The body is therefore not just a source of fear but the very opposite of the safety and liberation that Nibbāna represents.

Understanding this, we should contemplate, “This body is a terror, it is a source of fear, *bhaya*, *bhaya*.” Such contemplation will lead us to *Nibbāna*, which is completely free from fear and all dangers (*abhaya*).

9. *Ītito* (a plague)

*anekabyasanāvahanatāya ītito*⁵⁶

The next contemplation is *ītito*. The word *īti* refers to a terrifying danger, plague, or calamity. We need to reflect on the body as a source of terrifying danger.

aneka-byasanāvahanatāya (bringing various misfortunes)

The definition of *ītito* is that this body can bring countless damages, destructions, and misfortunes (*aneka-byasanāvahanatāya*). These misfortunes can arise in many different ways, affecting every part of the body—no place is safe from them. As long as we have this body, we are susceptible to numerous calamities. Because of this, the body is a terrifying danger and a constant source of suffering.

Reflecting on the body in this way constitutes Right View, Right Thought, and Right Effort. This form of reflection aligns

⁵⁶ *ītito*: as a plague because of bringing various kinds of ruin.



with the Noble Eightfold Path, leading toward *Nibbāna*, where there is no *īti*—no terrifying danger (*anītika*).

anulomika-khanti (the knowledge in conformity with the Path)

Such reflection develops the knowledge which conforms with *magga* (the Path) and is proper for the acceptance of *magga*. This knowledge called *anulomika-khanti* in Pāḷi, is the access to *magga* knowledge. *Anulomika khanti* means the acceptance which is proper for the arising of *maggañāṇa*, Path Knowledge.

There are three stages of *anulomika-khanti*: the tender stage, the middle stage, and the mature stage. From the initial reflection to the point where one can begin to see the arising and perishing of the body, this stage is referred to as the tender *anulomika-khanti*. This is the beginning point. After that, from seeing only the perishing of the body to developing *saṅkhārupekkhā-ñāṇa* (equanimity of formations, or indifference towards formation), which is a deeper insight knowledge, this is the middle *anulomika-khanti*, the middle stage. Beyond that, the development of this acceptance knowledge culminates in the insight knowledge called *anulomañāṇa*, conformity knowledge. This *anulomañāṇa* is the mature stage of *anulomika-khanti*.⁵⁷

⁵⁷ *Anulomika* means suitable for the arising of or in conformity with *magga*. *Khanti* means the acceptance of something, or being delighted with something.

We frequently make the aspiration, “*nibbānassa paccaya hotu*” – may this merit be the supporting condition for *nibbāna*. That means making a wish or an aspiration to realize *Nibbāna*. It is to arouse the desire for the realization of *Nibbāna*. For such a strong aspiration for *Nibbāna* to arise, we need to reflect deeply on life and the body in the various ways discussed here. By reflecting on the body in these ways, we strengthen our resolve to attain *Nibbāna*. Such reflection fosters a profound desire to reach the ultimate liberation from all suffering and danger.

10. *Upasaggato* (a menace)

*anekehi anatthehi anubaddhatāya, dosūpasatṭhatāya, upasaggo viya anadhivāsanārahatāya ca upasaggato*⁵⁸

The next contemplation is *upasaggato*, which refers to a menace, a threat, or oppression tied to the body. The body is closely associated with various forms of torturous adversity, making it a constant source of suffering and oppression.

anekehi anatthehi anubaddhatāya (disadvantages-bound)

One definition of *upasaggato* is that this body is bound up with numerous disadvantages (*anekehi anatthehi anubaddhatāya*). Internally, the body is fraught with dangers. Every part of it is vulnerable to disease—no organ, tissue, or

⁵⁸ *upasaggato*: as a *menace* because of being bound up with many kinds of adversity, because of being menaced by ills, and because of unfitnes, as a menace, to be entertained.



system is entirely safe. Therefore, the body is very close to danger; it is *upasagga*. Externally, even when the body appears healthy, countless dangers remain. For example, the loss of loved ones, wealth, knowledge, or status can bring external misfortune, all closely tied to the existence of the body. Therefore, this body, bound up with endless internal and external dangers, is a constant menace.

dosūpasatthatāya (adhere to faults)

Another definition of *upasaggato* is that the body adheres to faults (*dosūpasatthatāya*). These faults include lust, anger, delusion, and all the defilements represented by the fourteen unwholesome mental factors.

We attach to faults in two ways. The first way is through faulty objects. For example, there are things we should not see, but we still desire to see them. Similarly, there are sounds we should not hear, smells we should not smell, food we should not eat, tangible objects we should not touch, and mental objects we should not think about, but we engage with these objects anyway. These faulty and unwholesome objects enter and manifest in our minds from time to time. Even meditators seeking to focus on wholesome meditation objects such as the breath often find their minds wandering to unwholesome distractions. Certain objects are not suitable for meditators, but without proper attention, these inappropriate objects would still arise in the mind. Indeed, this body is adhering to faults through taking faulty objects.

The second way the body adheres to faults is through association with faults. The mind is originally pure. For example, when we are in deep sleep, the mind that arises is a resultant mind called *bhavaṅga* (mental continuum). For humans, it is a result of *kusala* (wholesome) actions. That mind is pure as it is free from faults. However, the originally pure mind becomes defiled upon waking. The active mind associates with various faults and becomes tainted by anger, lust, attachment, and many other defilements. Because of faulty association, the mind becomes faulty, too.

In this way, the body adheres to faults, both through taking faulty objects and through association with unwholesome mental states. Therefore, we should reflect, “This body is *upasagga*, *upasagga*, torturous adversity which is bound up with the body.”

upasaggo viya anadhivāsanārahatāya (intolerable)

A third definition of *upasaggato* is that the body is unbearable or intolerable (*upasaggo viya anadhivāsanārahatāya*), like a disease that is produced by demons or evil *devas*. As it is produced by demons or evil *devas* who know how to cause harm and suffering in humans, such diseases are very difficult to bear or tolerate. For example, demons or evil *devas* may inflict terrifying visions or sensations, causing people to experience intense fear or anguish.



The body is similarly intolerable in its constant demands. Upon waking, we must stretch our hands and legs, wash our faces, brush our teeth, eat, take medicine, and rest—an endless cycle of tasks. These chores keep us perpetually busy. Because of this, when we are asked, “Are you free?” We should answer, “I am not free. I am constantly very busy”. If someone asked us to care for another person’s body in this way—performing these tasks daily—we might find it intolerable, even for our closest family members. However, because of attachment, we tolerate such burdens for our own bodies. Without this attachment, even caring for ourselves would feel unbearable.

In this way, the body can be seen as a menace, like a disease inflicted by demons or evil *devas*. It is bound up with countless disadvantages, adheres to faults, and is intolerable in its constant demands.

By reflecting on the body as *upasagga*, we develop acceptance knowledge (*anulomika khanti*), which conforms to the Path (*magga*). We should contemplate, “This body is *upasagga*, *upasagga*, a disease inflicted by demons and evil *devas*.” This contemplation eventually leads to the realization of *Nibbāna*, which is free from all menaces (*anupasagga*).

11. *Atāṇato* (no protection)

*atāyanatāya ceva, alabbhaneyyakhematāya ca atāṇato*⁵⁹

The next contemplation is *atāṇato*, meaning that the body offers no protection. This body, despite our efforts to maintain and care for it, is entirely unprotected and unable to provide safety from danger.

atāyanatāya (unprotectable)

One definition of *atāṇato* is that the body is unprotectable (*atāyanatāya*). Everything that arises in the body inevitably perishes. Despite our desires and efforts, it is impossible to prevent the materiality and mentality in our bodies from decaying and perishing. Today, the body may be in good health, but maintaining that state indefinitely is impossible. Similarly, we might experience happiness and wish for it to last forever, but it too will fade.

As long as we possess this body or the five aggregates, we are subject to aging, illness, and death. No matter how much effort we invest, the body or the aggregates cannot be shielded from perishing once they have arisen. This inherent nature of impermanence makes the body fundamentally unprotected.

⁵⁹ *atāṇato*: as no protection because of not protecting, and because of affording no safety.



alabbhaneyya-khematāya (no security)

Another definition is that the body provides no security (*alabbhaneyyakhematāya*). Even though we might wish to obtain safety and security from the body, it cannot fulfill this desire. To seek protection, we often turn to others, offering something in exchange, such as money or service, and they may provide us with the safety we seek. However, no matter how much care and attention we give to the body—feeding it, cleaning it, and treating it when ill—it is incapable of offering us true protection.

For instance, we might plead with our bodies, saying, “Please don’t grow old. Stay youthful forever. Please don’t die.” Yet, such wishes are always met with disappointment. The body cannot protect us from aging, sickness, or death, nor from the myriad dangers that arise in life. Despite our endless care and nourishment, the body does not and cannot reciprocate by safeguarding us.

In this way, this body is not a source of protection. It cannot save us or provide us with lasting security.

By understanding this, we should contemplate, “This body has no protection, *atāṇa, atāṇa*.” Such contemplation leads to *Nibbāna*, which is the true and ultimate protection (*tāṇa*).

12. *Aleṇato* (no shelter)

*allīyituṃ anarahatāya, allīnānampi ca leṇakiccākāritāya aleṇato*⁶⁰

The next contemplation is *aleṇato*, meaning the body offers no true shelter or refuge. While “*leṇa*” refers to a place of hiding or shelter, “*aleṇa*” signifies the absence of such a sanctuary. When we encounter danger or fear, we may instinctively seek a place to hide or find safety. However, this body does not serve that purpose.

allīyituṃ anarahatāya (not worthy of a shelter)

One definition of *aleṇato* is that the body is not worthy of being a shelter (*allīyituṃ anarahatāya*). When we try to depend on this body as a refuge from danger, it ultimately fails us. Despite our efforts to use the body as a place of safety and security, it cannot fulfill this role. The body is incapable of shielding us from harm or protecting us from danger. For this reason, the body is considered *aleṇa*—it is not a place to hide.

leṇa-kiccākāritāya (not functioning as a shelter)

Another definition of *aleṇato* is that the body does not perform the function of providing protection (*allīnānampi ca leṇa-kiccākāritāya*). In times of danger, we might seek shelter in a specific place or under someone’s protection, and they

⁶⁰ ***aleṇato***: as no shelter because of unfitness to give shelter, and because of not performing the function of a shelter for the unsheltered.



may effectively shield us from harm. In contrast, when we rely on this body to keep us safe, it fails us completely.

Throughout our lives, we devote significant effort to caring for the body and preparing for the future. From a young age, we pursue education to secure happiness and sustain life. As adults, we work hard to earn money to maintain the body and provide for its needs. Despite all these efforts, the body cannot reciprocate or fulfill its function as a protector. It does not regard our education, wealth, or hard work—it merely follows its natural course of aging, sickness, and eventual death.

The body is indifferent to our efforts; it cannot protect us from the dangers inherent in life. As a result, noble persons understand that the body is not as valuable as it seems. They prioritize the protection of the *Dhamma* over the protection of the body. They protect themselves from transgressing the *Dhamma*. For instance, noble persons follow this principle when forced to make a choice: between property and limbs (hands and legs), they relinquish property to save their limbs; between their limbs and their lives, they relinquish their limbs to preserve their lives. However, between the *Dhamma* (such as morality) and their lives, they relinquish their lives to uphold the Dhamma. They will never transgress the *Dhamma*. Noble persons prize the *Dhamma* above the body because they understand that the body is not a reliable refuge from danger.

By understanding this, we should contemplate, “This body is *aleṇa*, *aleṇa*, not the place to hide from danger.” This contemplation leads to the realization of *Nibbāna*, the supreme and ultimate shelter (*leṇa*) from all dangers.

13. *Asaraṇato* (no refuge)

*nissitānaṃ bhayasārakattābhāvena asaraṇato*⁶¹

The next contemplation is *asaraṇato*, meaning that this body is no refuge. The word “*saraṇa*” is commonly understood as “refuge”, as in the familiar chant, “*Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*” (I go to the Buddha as a refuge). Here, “*asaraṇa*” signifies the absence of such a refuge, emphasizing that this body cannot serve as a refuge or a reliable source of protection for us.

nissitānaṃ bhaya-sārakattābhāvena (absence of ability to dispel dangers)

The definition of *asaraṇato* emphasizes that this body cannot provide safety or dispel dangers (*nissitānaṃ bhaya-sārakattābhāvena*). When we seek a refuge, we expect it to save us and protect us from harm.

A refuge is something we turn to for safety, something that can save us from harm and dispel danger. However, this body fails to meet those criteria. Despite all the care and

⁶¹ ***asaraṇato***: as *no refuge* because of failure to disperse fear in those who depend on them.



attention, we devote to it—feeding it, treating it with medicine, grooming it, and even providing it with luxuries—it cannot shield us from the dangers inherent in life. Aging, sickness, and death are inevitable, no matter how much effort we expend. Even the wealthiest individuals, with access to the finest resources, and the most powerful people, with all the privileges of their status, are not immune to the vulnerabilities of the body. This truth highlights the futility of depending on the body as a refuge.

In contrast, the Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Saṅgha are true refuges because they provide a path to protection from life’s ultimate dangers. When we chant “*Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*”, we approach the Buddha as a refuge. We acknowledge our reliance on the Buddha as a refuge. The Buddha can protect our lives. Thus, we can take the Buddha as a refuge.

The Buddha protects us through his teachings, which guide us to avoid evil actions and cultivate wholesomeness. By refraining from harmful deeds and actively pursuing virtuous qualities, we create a life of safety and peace. However, it is not enough to simply seek refuge in the Buddha; we must also follow his teachings and practice the Dhamma ourselves. The Buddha can only show us the way, but we must practice accordingly.

If we take refuge in the Buddha, the Buddha’s teachings, and the *Saṅgha*, our lives can truly be protected.

This body, in contrast, offers no such protection. It cannot save us from birth, aging, sickness, or death. No matter how much we try to preserve and care for it, the body will ultimately fail us. Understanding this truth, we come to see the body as *asaraṇa*, a source that cannot serve as refuge.

By understanding this, we should contemplate, “This body is no refuge, *asaraṇa*, *asaraṇa*”. This contemplation leads to the realization of *Nibbāna*, the ultimate refuge (*saraṇa*) that offers true liberation and protection from all dangers.

14. ***Vadhakato* (murderous)**

*mitta-mukha-sapatto viya vissāsa-ghātītāya vadhakato*⁶²

The next contemplation is *vadhakato*, which translates to “murderous”. *Vadhaka* refers to a murderer or killer. It may sound startling to describe the body as a murderer or killer. How could this be? Does the body truly kill you? Have you become your own enemy?

The definition explains that this body is *vissāsa-ghātaka*, a “betrayer of trust,” or a killer of someone who places trust in it. It is also described as *mitta-mukha-sapatta*⁶³, an “enemy with a friendly face.” This phrase refers to someone who appears to be a friend, gains your trust, and then betrays and

⁶² ***vadhakato***: as *murderous* because of breaking faith like an enemy posing as a friend.

⁶³ *Mitta* = friend; *mukha* = face; *sapatta* = enemy.



harms you. In movies, we often see such characters—individuals who pretend to be friends, build intimacy and confidence, and later commit treachery. Such betrayal feels cruel and deeply upsetting, even when it is fictional.

We cannot accept this because even though we associate with someone as a friend and place our confidence in him as a friend, later, he betrays our trust and kills us instead. Such kind of killers we call *mitta-mukha-sapatta* – the enemy with a friendly face.

Now consider your relationship with your body. You may view your body as your closest companion, your friend. You love it dearly and care for it with utmost devotion. Every morning, you wake up and attend to it—washing your face, brushing your teeth, using the toilet, eating, exercising, and dressing. Throughout your life, you serve and cherish this body, nurturing it as if it were your most trusted friend.

Yet, despite all your care and devotion, this body betrays you. It does not fulfill your wishes. You wish to remain young, but the body ages. You wish to stay healthy, but the body falls ill. You wish to avoid death, but the body inevitably dies. The very thing you treat as a friend and rely on turns into the cause of your suffering. This body, which you trust and care for, reveals itself to be a killer—a friendly murderer.

The body is also referred to as *khandha-māra*⁶⁴ – the aggregates (*khandha*) or our body as a killer. Why do we die? It is solely because we possess this body. Without it, there would be no death. Despite loving and caring for the body, it inevitably disappoints us, betrays our trust, and ultimately causes our demise.

Understanding this, we should contemplate, “This body is a friendly killer, a murderer, *vadhaka*, *vadhaka*.” Such contemplation helps us realize the suffering and treacherous nature of the body, guiding us to seek *Nibbāna*, which is free from such friendly but betraying killers (*avadhaka*).

15. *Aghamūlato* (the root of calamity)

*aghahetutāya aghamūlato*⁶⁵

The next contemplation is *agha-mūlato*, which means “the root of calamity” or “the root of evil”. Here, *agha* refers to evil, suffering, or calamity, and *mūla* means root. Together, *agha-mūla* signifies the root cause of all evil and suffering.

Whoever possesses this body is prone to engaging in evil deeds. Why? Because the body drives us to seek agreeable experiences and avoid disagreeable ones. When we encounter something unpleasant, we develop hatred toward

⁶⁴ This is one of five kinds of *māra* which will be elaborated on under 18. *Mārāmisato* later.

⁶⁵ ***aghamūlato***: as the root of calamity because of being the cause of calamity.



it, and when we desire something pleasant, we develop an attachment to it. In pursuing what we love or in trying to eliminate what we hate, we may resort to unwholesome actions.

For ordinary people, the body often becomes the cause of their immoral actions. They may lie, steal, hurt others, or commit other harmful deeds, all to fulfill the desires or demands of the body. These unwholesome actions, in turn, bring suffering to the doer. Therefore, the body is rightly called the root of all evil and suffering.

By recognizing this truth, we should contemplate, “This body is the root of evil, *aghamūla, aghamūla*”. Such contemplation helps to diminish attachment to the body and its desires, paving the way toward the ultimate peace of *Nibbāna*, which is free from the root of evil (*anaghamūla*).

16. *Ādīnavato* (a danger)

*pavattidukkhatāya, dukkhassa ca ādīnavatāya ādīnavato, atha vā ādīnaṃ vāti gacchati pavattatīti ādīnavo, kapaṇamanussassetam adhivacanaṃ, khandhāpi ca kapaṇāyevāti ādīnavasadisatāya ādīnavato.*⁶⁶

⁶⁶ **ādīnavato**: as *danger* because of the suffering in the process of becoming, and because of the danger in suffering or, alternatively, as *danger* (*ādīnava*) because of resemblance to misery (*ādīna*) since “danger” (*ādīnava*) means that it is towards misery (*ādīna*) that it moves (*vāti*), goes, advances, this being a term for a wretched man, and the aggregates are wretched too.

The next contemplation is *ādinavato*, which translates to "a danger" or "full of faults." The term *ādinava* can encompass many layers of meaning, from inherent flaws to the dangers associated with something. This body, in its very nature, is filled with faults and vulnerabilities, making it a source of danger.

pavatti-dukkhatāya (suffering in arising)

This body arises together with its inherent qualities of impermanence (*anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and non-self (*anatta*). These three universal characteristics are inseparable from the body. Because the body arises within this cycle of impermanence and suffering, its very existence is bound with faults. Every moment of its existence is accompanied by instability, discomfort, and the lack of true control, which makes it inherently defective.

kapaṇa-manussa (destitute person)

Another interpretation of *ādinava* compares the body to a wretched and destitute person (*kapaṇa-manussa*). Such a person is lonely, poor, and without protection. They have no refuge and no one to rely on for help. Similarly, despite all our efforts to preserve the body—feeding it, clothing it, providing shelter, and seeking comfort for it—it remains unsavable in the end. This body, or the five aggregates, is helpless and vulnerable, like a destitute person with no hope of escape from suffering. It is pitiable and unreliable. Hence, the body is *ādinava*, full of faults.



Understanding this, we should contemplate, “This body is full of faults, *ādīnava*, *ādīnava*.” By seeing the dangers and flaws inherent in the body, we become an *ādīnava-dassavī*, one who habitually perceives the faults in conditioned existence. This contemplation helps loosen attachment to the body and leads us toward Nibbāna, the ultimate state where there are no faults, no flaws—*anādīnava*.

17. *Sāsavato* (subject to cankers)

*āsava-padaṭṭhānatāya sāsavato*⁶⁷

The next contemplation is *sāsavato*, meaning "subject to cankers" or "cause of taints." The term *āsava* is commonly translated as "taints" and refers to a group of defilements that ferment and linger in the mental continuum, leading to suffering and delusion. This body, along with the five aggregates, becomes the cause of these taints in several ways.

ārammaṇa-paccayo (as an object condition)

One way this body acts as the cause of taints is by being the object (*ārammaṇa-paccayo*) that gives rise to them. Simply observing or contemplating our body can provoke taints to arise. When we see our own body, or even others' bodies, defilements such as greed, attachment, wrong views,

⁶⁷ ***sāsavato***: as *subject to cankers* because of being the proximate cause for cankers.

ignorance, or delusion may emerge. This happens because the body acts as an object condition that stimulates these unwholesome mental states. For example, when we admire the beauty of the body, attachment arises; when we observe its decay or imperfections, aversion or delusion may surface. Thus, the body, by its very existence, acts as fertile ground for the growth of defilements through object condition (*ārammaṇa paccayo*).

upanissaya-paccayo (as a strong dependence condition)

The body is also a cause of taints through *upanissaya-paccayo*, meaning strong dependence condition. This occurs when past habits, wholesome or unwholesome actions of the past, influence the mind and support the re-emergence of taints in the present. For example, new meditators who sit down to practice mindfulness of breathing often find that various mental objects—both wholesome and unwholesome—arise in their minds, seemingly unbidden. These may include greed, anger, or attachment to past experiences. Why do such thoughts emerge? It is because of their previous conditioning and habitual tendencies. They may have been heedless, allowing the mind to wander among various objects—good and bad—without any control. Even though this mind of the past has ceased, the objects may appear again from time to time. The mind, influenced by past actions, continuously brings up these mental states in the present. This is how past habits strongly condition and support the defilements that arise in the present. The diversity of past actions contributes



to the wide range of individual mental dispositions. This way of support is called *upanissaya-paccaya* – a strong dependence condition.

To free ourselves from the taints, we should contemplate, “This body, the mentality and materiality, is the cause of the taints, *sāsava, sāsava.*” This contemplation will lead to *Nibbāna*, which is free from the taints.

The mundane materiality and mentality can be taken as objects by the taints; hence, they are *sāsava*. But *supramundane* states (*Nibbāna, magga, phala*) cannot be taken as objects by the taints; they are *anāsava*. In addition, the taints (*āsava*), which are like the *akusala* mental states that have been fermenting in our mental continuity for a long time, are destroyed completely by the realization of final *Nibbāna*, a state known as *āsavakkhaya*, the destruction of taints.

18. *Mārāmisato* (Māra’s bait)

*maccumārakilesamārānaṃ āmisabhūtatāya mārāmisato*⁶⁸

The next contemplation is *mārāmisato*. *Mārāmisa* is a combination of two words: *māra* and *āmisa*. *Āmisa* usually

⁶⁸ ***mārāmisato***: as *Māra’s bait* because of being the bait [laid] by the *Māra* of death and the *Māra* of defilement.

means food or property,⁶⁹ but in this context, it is taken as food. Therefore, *mārāmisā* means “the food of *māra*”. This body, the aggregates, is the food of *māra*.

You may already be familiar with the Pāḷi word, *maraṇa*, which means death. *Māra* is closely related to *maraṇa*.⁷⁰ The literal meaning of *māra* is “one who causes death”, or in other words, a killer. *Māra* signifies what brings about death. There are five kinds of *māra*.

devaputta māra (deity-Māra)

The term *māra* originally refers to *devaputta māra* – a certain deva called *māra*. This *māra* deva actively tries to prevent others from practicing the Dhamma, especially the *Bodhisatta* who was on the path to awakening. For example, when the *Bodhisatta* wanted to renounce household life, *māra* attempted to stop him, saying, “Please do not renounce; return to the palace.” In this sense, *māra* is the one who obstructs spiritual practice. Why is he called a killer (*māra*)? Because if someone does not practice and penetrate the *Dhamma*, he will continue to die again and again in the cycle of rebirths (*saṃsāra*). Preventing *Dhamma* practice is like causing death repeatedly.

⁶⁹ For *bhikkhus*, *āmisā* means something to eat, or something to use or consume. For example, there are two types of dāna: *āmisadāna* (consumable things) and *dhammadāna* (*Dhamma*).

⁷⁰ *Mareti* (with short a) = to die; *maraṇa* = death; *māreti* (with long ā) = to cause to die.



kilesa-māra (defilement Māra)

The second kind of *māra* is defilements or *kilesa*. Defilements such as greed, hatred, and delusion are also called *Māra* because they "kill" beings by binding them to the cycle of birth and death. Whoever harbors defilements will face death repeatedly in the endless rounds of *saṃsāra*. Therefore, defilements are also metaphorically called *māra*, a killer.

khandha-māra (aggregates Māra)

The third type of *māra* is *khandhamāra*, the five aggregates themselves. These aggregates—materiality, feeling, perception, volitional formations, and consciousness—are also called *māra*, one who causes death, because they are inherently tied to death. Anyone who possesses this body, the five aggregates, is subject to death. Therefore, the aggregates are considered killers in this sense. In Pāḷi, it is called *khandha-māra*, the aggregates as a killer.

abhisāṅkhāra-māra (formation Māra)

The fourth kind of *māra* is *abhisāṅkhāra-māra*. *Abhisāṅkhāra* refers to the good or bad *kamma* which can produce new existences. Whoever has accumulated *kamma* will be reborn again in a new existence. If someone is reborn again into a new existence, surely, he has to die again at the end of that existence. Why do we need to face death? It is because of our *kamma*. When *kamma* generates a new life, death will inevitably follow. Therefore, the cause of future deaths is our

kamma. In this way, *kamma* is a killer. In the case of an *arahant*, he does not accumulate any more *kamma*. Whatever he does, there will be no *akusala* (unwholesome). He is still doing good deeds, but these are pure actions with no *kamma* accumulation. To become an accumulated *kamma*, mere action is not enough; it has to be accompanied by attachment or craving. If there is such a craving or attachment, the action becomes *kamma*. For the *arahant*, since he has no more attachment to any form of existence at all, his actions are merely actions, and he does not accumulate any new *kamma*. After passing away from his last existence, he will not be reborn again. If there is no rebirth, surely there will be no death.

In contrast, with *kamma*, there will be rebirth and therefore death again and again. Consequently, *kamma* is also called *māra*. *Kamma* is also a killer.

maccu-māra (death Māra)

The fifth kind of *māra* is *maccu-māra*. The killer is death itself. *Maccu* refers to the very nature of mortality. Because of this nature, all beings must die. Why do we have to die? It is because of this nature of mortality. When someone dies, people may say, “Humans are mortal”. Being mortal means not having gone beyond death; death is inevitable. This mortality of humans, this nature of death, is called *maccu*. This inevitability of death makes it a killer, which is why it is called *māra*. Because of this, we have *maccumāra*, death as the killer.



I will do a summary of the five kinds of *māra*. The five kinds of *māra* are *devaputta māra* (the killer which is a deva), *kilesa-māra* (the killer which is defilements), *khandha-māra* (the killer which is aggregates), *abhisaṅkhāra-māra* (the killer which is *kamma*), and *maccu-māra* (the killer which is death). These are the five kinds of *māra*.

Now, let us return to *mārāmisā*, the food of *māra*. According to the *Visuddhimagga*, *mārāmisā* includes two types of *māra*: *maccu-māra* and *kilesa-māra*.

maccu-mārāmisā (the bait of death Māra)

This body is the food of *maccu-māra*. If we possess this body, we are providing food for death. The body ensures that death will come.

kilesa-mārāmisā (the bait of defilement Māra)

Similarly, the body is the food of *kilesa-māra*. Based on this body, defilements arise—such as greed for the body, attachment to the body, or delusion about the body. If we possess this body, this set of aggregates, it is like providing food for the *kilesa*. Therefore, this body is the food for defilement, *kilesa-māra*.

Khandha-mārāmisā (the bait of aggregate Māra)

In the sub-commentary of *Visuddhimagga* (*mahāṭīkā*), the definition of *mārāmisā* is expanded to include the remaining three types of *māra*: *khandha-māra*, *abhisaṅkhāra-māra*, and *devaputta-māra*.

The body is also the food of *khandha-māra*. The current set of aggregates supports the arising of future aggregates. By engaging in actions, good or bad, this body produces kamma, which leads to another set of aggregates in future lives. Thus, the present aggregates are food for future aggregates.

Abhisāṅkhāra-mārāmisa (the bait of formation Māra)

The body is also the food of *abhisāṅkhāra-māra*. *Abhisāṅkhāra* means *kamma*. This body is the food of *kamma*. With this body, we have sense faculties like eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, and mind, which come into contact with various objects. We see visible objects, listen to sounds, and so on. We come into contact with both desirable and undesirable objects. We like desirable objects and try to grasp onto them, but we dislike undesirable objects and wish to repel them. In the process of removing undesirable objects or getting hold of desirable objects, those who understand cause and effect will try to do so properly and righteously. They will try to do good deeds (*kusala*). However, those who do not understand cause and effect may react in the wrong way and try to achieve their wish in an unwholesome manner. They will end up doing evil deeds (*akusala*). Hence, because we have this body, we may do good or bad actions, and we may produce good or bad *kamma*. In this context, this body is the food of *abhisāṅkhāra*, the food of *kamma*.

devaputta-mārāmisa (the bait of deity Māra)

Lastly, the body is the food for *devaputta māra*. That *māra deva* is always trying to stop others from practicing the



Dhamma. What is the reason? Normally, when someone passes away, the *māra deva* can see where that person has been reborn. He knows the places of rebirth of those who pass away. However, one who practices the *Dhamma* will eventually abandon all defilements and become an *arahant*. After passing away from that last existence, his aggregates cease completely without remainder, and there will be no more rebirth for him. At that time, he escapes from the knowledge of the *māra deva*.

As there is no further rebirth for an *arahant*, *māra deva* does not know where the *arahant* has gone after his death. The *arahant* has gone beyond *māra deva*'s domain of knowledge. *Māra deva* cannot trace the *arahant* anymore, which displeases him. Therefore, he always tries to stop others from practicing *Dhamma* in order to keep them within his domain of knowledge. Moreover, for ordinary beings who are still trapped in the cycle of *saṃsāra*, he overestimates himself by thinking: “*etaṃ mama*” – “This is mine”, “These are my people”. Because wherever they go, he can see. Even when they pass away, wherever they are reborn, he can see too. Therefore, for the people who are not *arahant*, their aggregates become the food for the *māra deva*, because it can produce his conceited thought that all these beings are under his control, “*etaṃ mama*” – “This is mine”. Hence, the body is the food of the *māra deva* too.

Understanding this, we should contemplate, “This body is the food of *māra*, *mārāmisā*, *mārāmisā*.” This is the Right Thought that leads to the realization of the final *Nibbāna*.

With the complete cessation of the aggregates, we will escape from *māra*'s domain of knowledge and will no longer be food for *māra* (*nirāmisā*).

19. *Jātidhammato* (subject to birth)

The next contemplation is *jātidhammato*, the nature of being subject to birth. *Jātidhamma* refers to the inherent nature of rebirth.

The Buddha defines birth in many suttas, such as in the following passage:

*Katamā ca, bhikkhave, jāti? Yā tesaṃ tesaṃ sattānaṃ tamhi tamhi sattanikāye jāti, sañjāti, okkanti, abhinibbatti khandhānaṃ pātubhāvo, āyatanānaṃ paṭilābho. Ayaṃ vuccati, bhikkhave, jāti.*⁷¹

And what, bhikkhus, is birth? The birth of the various beings into the various orders of beings, their being born, descent [into the womb], production, the manifestation of the aggregates, and the obtaining of the sense bases. This is called birth.

Birth is also a form of suffering. Yet in the world, we celebrate it with “Happy Birthday”. We should reflect more deeply to

⁷¹ Dī.2.243 (DN 22 Mahāsatipaṭṭhāna Sutta – Dukkhasaccaniddeso). [English translation by Bhikkhu Bodhi]



examine whether rebirth into a mother's womb is truly happy or otherwise.

How long do we stay in the mother's womb? More than nine months, often up to ten months. Imagine someone asking you to stay in a room for ten months. How would you feel? Even in this wide space, with fresh air, it would be uncomfortable. How much more so in the narrow, cramped confines of the mother's womb?

Inside the womb, you can neither stretch nor bend your limbs. Above you are the stomach and intestines, filled with digested food and feces. You are squeezed between the abdomen and spine in a tight, dark space. The smells are unbearable—like rotten fish or putrid cakes—not like a fragrant lotus flower but more like a worm in a cesspool at the village gate.

The air is also polluted. The winds within the body are foul and unpleasant. All the food consumed by the mother moves down past your head. Beneath you are body wastes waiting to be expelled. It is a place full of filth and repulsive odors.

When your mother drinks something hot or cold, you feel the effects. Many Chinese mothers like to drink hot water, so it may feel like being in a heated furnace. When she eats ice cream, you experience the chill of *sītanaraka*, the cold hell. Hot foods feel like burning coals, while spicy, sour, or salty foods cause piercing pain on your tender skin.

If the mother suddenly changes posture or slips accidentally, you are flung and shaken, suffering alone without help. It

feels like being a goat in the hands of a drunkard or a small snake in a snake charmer's grasp. There is no refuge, no friends or relatives to ease the suffering.

After enduring seven, eight, nine, or ten months in the womb, the winds of kamma turn you upside down. This can be terrifying, uncertain of where you will fall or land. Then comes the moment of childbirth. Upon emerging from the womb, all babies cry. Why is this? It must be an extremely painful and traumatic experience.

Imagine being squeezed out of the mother's body—it feels like a massive elephant being forced through the keyhole of an ancient door, or being pressed under an iron mountain. The baby's tender skin is easily hurt.

Immediately after emerging from the mother's womb, your hands and legs are grabbed, and your delicate body is washed and rubbed with cloth. It is excruciatingly painful, and so the baby cries.

Reflecting in this way, you can see the true nature of rebirth. It is not a source of happiness but a profound form of suffering. This is *jātidhammato*, the reality of being subject to birth.

20. *Jarādhammato* (subject to aging)

The next contemplation is *jarādhammato*, the nature of being subject to aging. This body is bound by the nature of aging. In many suttas, the Buddha defines aging as follows:



*Katamā ca, bhikkhave, jarā? yā tesam tesam
sattānam tamhi tamhi sattanikāye jarā, jīraṇatā,
khaṇḍiccam, pāliccam, valittacatā āyuno samhāni,
indriyānam paripāko. ayam vuccati, bhikkhave,
jarā.*⁷²

And what, bhikkhus, is aging? The aging of the various beings in the various orders of beings, their growing old, the brokenness of teeth, the greyness of hair, the wrinkling of skin, the dwindling away of the life span, the degeneration of the sense faculties. This is called aging.

This truth is plain to see, and I think there is no need for elaborate explanations. You can easily understand that this body has the nature of aging. Even the Buddha, the Fully Enlightened One, could not escape from growing old. For this reason, we need to contemplate aging to develop Right View and Right Thought.

The Buddha himself remarked on his own aging to Venerable Ānanda, saying:

*“aḥam kho paṇānanda, etarahi jiṇṇo vuddho
mahallako addhagato vayoanuppatto. āsītiko me
vayo vattati. seyyathāpi, ānanda, jajjarasakaṭaṃ
veṭhamissakena yāpeti, evameva kho, ānanda,
veṭhamissakena maññe tathāgatassa kāyo yāpeti.”*⁷³

⁷² Dī.2.244 (DN 22 Mahāsatipatṭhāna Sutta – Dukkhasaccaniddeso). [English translation by Bhikkhu Bodhi]

⁷³ Dī.2.85 (DN 16 Mahāparinibbāna Sutta). [English translation by Sister Vajira & Francis Story]

“Now I am frail, Ananda, old, aged, far gone in years. This is my eightieth year, and my life is spent. Even as an old cart, Ānanda, is held together with much difficulty, so the body of the Tathāgata is kept going only with supports.”

This teaching emphasizes the inevitability of aging and its effects on the body, even for the Buddha. He described the body as being like an old, worn-out cart that can only be held together with great effort.

A verse from the Saṃyutta Nikāya reminds us of this truth:

*“Jīranti ve rājarathā sucittā,
Atha sarīrampi jaraṃ upeti;
Satañca dhammo na jaraṃ upeti,
Santo have sabbhi pavedayanti” ti.*⁷⁴

“The beautiful chariots of kings wear out,
This body too undergoes decay.
But the Dhamma of the good does not decay:
So the good proclaim along with the good.”

The physical body is impermanent, destined to age and deteriorate. However, the Dhamma, the truth of the teachings, does not age or decay. Therefore, we should focus on the Dhamma, which transcends the nature of aging and brings peace and wisdom.

⁷⁴ Saṃ.1.71 (SN 3.3 Jarāmarāṇa Sutta). [English translation by Bhikkhu Bodhi]



21. *Byādhidhammato* (subject to illness)

*jāti-jarā-byādhi-maraṇa-pakatitāya jāti-jarā-byādhi-maraṇa-dhammato*⁷⁵

The next contemplation is *byādhidhammato*, the nature of being subject to illness. Our body has the nature of sickness, a truth that becomes evident in our daily experiences. When we sit for a long time, for example, the body begins to show signs of discomfort. This, too, is a form of sickness. The body is constantly vulnerable to various ailments, large and small, that remind us of its fragile nature.

In the *Girimānanda Sutta*⁷⁶, the Buddha provides a detailed reflection on this reality:

Having gone to the wilderness, to the foot of a tree, or to an empty dwelling, a bhikkhu reflects thus: 'This body has many pains, many drawbacks. In this body many kinds of disease arise, such as: eye-disease, disease of the inner ear, nose-disease, tongue-disease, body-disease, head-disease, disease of the external ear, mouth-disease, tooth-disease, lip-disease, cough, asthma, catarrh, fever, aging, stomach-ache, fainting, dysentery, gripes, cholera, leprosy, boils, ringworm, tuberculosis, epilepsy, skin-disease, itch, scab, psoriasis, scabies, jaundice, diabetes, hemorrhoids, fistulas, ulcers; diseases arising from bile, from phlegm, from the wind-property, from

⁷⁵ *jāti-jarā-byādhi-maraṇa-dhammato*: as subject to birth, to ageing, to illness, and to death because of having birth, ageing, illness and death as their nature;

⁷⁶ Añ.3.343 (AN 10.60 *Girimānanda Sutta*)

combinations of bodily humors, from changes in the weather, from uneven care of the body, from attacks, from the result of kamma; cold, heat, hunger, thirst, defecation, urination.' Thus, he dwells contemplating the drawbacks with regard to this body.

The Buddha's enumeration of diseases serves as a sobering reminder of the body's vulnerability. It encompasses ailments affecting all parts of the body and those caused by various factors—internal and external, environmental, and even karmic.

In light of this, we should contemplate, “This body has the nature to be reborn, to age and to fall sick, *jātidhamma*, *jarādhamma*, *byādhi-dhamma*.” Such reflections help us to see the body for what it truly is: impermanent and prone to suffering. Ultimately, this insight will lead us to the realization of *Nibbāna*, which is free from the nature of rebirth, aging, and sickness (*ajāta*, *ajarā*, *abyādhi*).

22. *Sokadhammato* (subject to sorrow)

The next contemplation is *soka-dhammato*, the nature of being subject to sorrow. This body is inherently bound to experience sorrow. Sorrow arises from separation from what we love, from meeting what we dislike, and from unfulfilled desires. Sorrow also arises in one touched by one form of misfortune or another, such as that regarding relatives, wealth, illness, morality, or views. The fragile and



impermanent nature of the body, as well as the attachments we form around it, ensures that sorrow will inevitably arise.

23. *Paridevadhammato* (subject to lamentation)

The next contemplation is *parideva-dhammato*, the nature of being subject to lamentation. *Parideva* refers to the loud expression of grief—crying and wailing with intense sadness. When sorrow becomes unbearable, it manifests as *parideva*, a deep and outwardly visible lamentation. This is often described as the uncontrollable outpouring of sorrow when faced with significant loss or overwhelming pain.

24. *Upāyāsadhammato* (subject to despair)

*soka-parideva-upāyāsa-hetutāya soka-parideva-upāyāsa-dhammato*⁷⁷

The next contemplation is *upāyāsa-dhammato*, the nature of being subject to despair. After prolonged sorrow and lamentation, when the mind and body are utterly exhausted, one reaches a state of *upāyāsa*, or despair. In this state, there is no more crying, no sound of wailing, and even the tears have dried. Yet, within, the heart is heavy with an inexpressible grief. This quiet, consuming anguish, where one feels helpless and defeated, is *upāyāsa*.

⁷⁷ ***soka-parideva-upāyāsa-dhammato***: as subject to sorrow, to lamentation and to despair because of being the cause of sorrow, lamentation and despair.

The Buddha described these as natural aspects of having a body: sorrow, lamentation, and despair are inevitable for all who take birth. Thus, we should reflect, “This body is subject to sorrow, lamentation, and despair—*sokadhamma*, *paridevadhamma*, *upāyāsadhamma*.” Such reflections deepen our understanding of the body's true nature and turn our minds toward liberation.

By contemplating these truths, we are inspired to seek and eventually realize Nibbāna, the state free from sorrow, lamentation, and despair—*asoka*, *aparideva*, *anupāyāsa*. Nibbāna is the ultimate peace, where the sufferings inherent in conditioned existence cease entirely.

25. *Samkilesikadhammato* (subject to defilements)

*taṇhā-diṭṭhi-duccarita-saṃkilesānaṃ visaya-dhammatāya saṃkilesika-dhammato*⁷⁸

The next contemplation is *saṃkilesika-dhammato*, the nature of being subject to defilements. Here, the term “*dhamma*” refers to the inherent nature, and “*saṃkilesa*” means defilements. *Samkilesa* is the same as *kilesa*, defilements. *-ika* means object. *Samkilesika* refers to being the object of defilement. So, *saṃkilesika-dhamma* means the nature of being the object of defilement. Therefore, *saṃkilesika-dhamma* signifies that the body becomes the object and cause of defilements. In the definition here, the defilements

⁷⁸ ***Samkilesika-dhammato***: as *subject to defilement* because of being the objective field of the defilements of craving, views and misconduct.



mentioned are craving (*taṇhā*), wrong view (*diṭṭhi*), and misconduct (*duccarita*).

This body, with its impermanent and unsatisfactory nature, is deeply tied to the arising of defilements. It becomes an object of craving when we cling to its appearance or seek comfort and pleasure through it. It becomes an object of wrong view when we mistakenly think, "This is me, this is mine." Such attachment to the body as a self leads to countless misperceptions about reality. Furthermore, driven by craving and wrong views, we may engage in misconduct—actions rooted in greed, hatred, or delusion—causing harm to ourselves and others.

This is the nature of the body: it is inherently bound to be an object for craving, wrong view, and misconduct. Therefore, it is called *saṃkilesika-dhamma*—the nature of the object of defilement. Reflecting on this truth, we develop insight into the body's true nature, allowing us to weaken our attachments and misconceptions.

We should regularly contemplate, "This body is of the nature to be the object of defilements, *saṃkilesikadhamma*, *saṃkilesikadhamma*". Such reflections guide us toward Nibbāna, the state that is free from defilements and the object of defilements—*asaṃkiliṭṭha*. It is only in Nibbāna that the defilements of craving, wrong view, and misconduct are completely extinguished, leaving the mind utterly pure and liberated.

Anatta

1. *Suññato* (voidness)

*sāmi-nivāsi-kāraka-vedakādhiṭṭhāyaka-virahitatāya
suññato. sayañca assāmika-bhāvāditāya anattato*⁷⁹

The first contemplation under the category of non-self is *suññato*. *Suñña* means nothing, like zero, and may be translated as emptiness or voidness. Our body is nothing special. It is just emptiness or voidness. However, we should not understand this to mean that our body is empty of everything. There is mentality and materiality (*nāma-rūpa*). There are five aggregates in the body. But what the body is empty of is the idea of a self, *atta*.

Some may hold the view that there is *atta* in the body. This is merely their view, which is incorrect. In reality, there is no *atta* in the body. The body is empty of a self, *atta*.

So, what is the definition of *suñña* here? It means empty of a self, *atta*. First, we need to know what self, *atta*, is. There are five definitions or five ideas of *atta* here.

⁷⁹ ***Suññato***: as *void* because devoid of the state of being an owner, abider, doer, experiencer, director; as *not-self* because of itself having no owner, etc.



sāmi-virahitatāya (without owner)

The first idea of *atta* is *sāmi*. *Sāmi* means the owner, the owner of this body, or the owner of the five aggregates. However, there is no owner of this body or the five aggregates. Because of the absence of an owner (*sāmi*), this body is *suñña*, emptiness.

If there were an owner of this body, he would be able to manage it so that it does not become old, sick, or die. However, nobody can do this. There is no owner of this body. Hence, this body has no owner; it is empty of an owner.

nivāsi-virahitatāya (without dweller)

The second idea of a self (*atta*) is *nivāsi* (dweller). *Nivāsi* refers to something that can stay in the body from life to life. Some people may think that when a person passes away, the body perishes, but there is something that can move from this body to the next body.

This is just an idea conceived by them, but this is not what happens in reality. Everything in our body perishes immediately after arising. There is nothing that lasts beyond the short moment, let alone from life to life. Therefore, there is no such kind of *atta* (self or soul) that can stay in the body without passing away. This notion is not in accordance with reality; it is merely some people's thinking.

kāraka-virahitatāya (without doer)

Another wrong idea about the self (*atta*) is *kāraka*. *Kāraka* means doer. Some people may think there is a doer in the body performing all the actions of the body. When they speak, see something, or hear something, they may believe there is a doer who performs all such functions.

However, this is only their illusory idea; it is not reality. In reality, actions arise due to the presence of conditions, not because of a doer. For instance, the function of seeing arises when four conditions are present: eye sensitivity, a visible object, light, and attention. When all four conditions are fulfilled, we can see. If any one of the conditions is absent, we cannot see.

Without the right conditions, no such thing as a doer can make us see. For example, if we switch off the light, even if we want to see, we cannot. If someone lacks eye sensitivity, such as a blind person, he cannot see, no matter how much he desires to. Therefore, there is no doer in our body. This body is empty of a doer, empty of a self—it is nothing special. It is *anatta* (non-self).

As expressed in the verse:

*“dukkhameva hi, na koci dukkhito.
kārako na, kiriyāva vijjati.
atthi nibbuti, na nibbuto pumā.*



*maggamatthi, gamako na vijjatī”ti.*⁸⁰

For there is suffering, but none who suffers;
Doing exists although there is no doer.
Extinction is, but no extinguished person;
Although there is a path, there is no goer.

vedaka-virahitatāya (without sufferer)

Another idea of self is *vedaka*. *Vedaka* means something that feels objects. Some people may think that feeling is the soul or self. However, feeling is just a mental factor called *vedanā*. It arises and passes away based on conditions. It is not the soul or self.

Sometimes we feel happy, sometimes sad, and sometimes neutral. If feeling were the soul or self, we would be able to control it and feel happy all the time as we desire. There is no need to come here to meditate to be happy. Yet, this is not the case. Feeling is also not self; it is empty of any such self. It is called *suñña*, emptiness, or *anatta*, non-self.

ādhittāyaka-virahitatāya (without manager)

Another idea of self is *ādhittāyaka*. *Ādhittāyaka* means a manager—something that manages this body, commanding it to see, hear, or move. Some people may think that there is such a manager within the body.

⁸⁰ Visuddhi.2.144 (Vism.2.16.indriyasaccaniddeso.magganiddesakathā).

[English translation by Bhikkhu Ñāṇamoli]

This, too, is merely their idea, not reality. No one can manage anything. There is no manager in our body. Everything that happens in our body is based on causes and effects, not on a manager.

For example, as you listen to a *Dhamma* talk, the hearing (ear-door) process arises. Certain conditions must be present for this hearing process to occur: sound, ear sensitivity, space, and attention. If any of these conditions is absent—such as blocking the ear canal with an earplug or being inattentive—hearing does not occur.

No manager can override the absence of conditions to make hearing possible. Therefore, there is no manager in this body. This body is empty of a manager; it is void of a manager; it is non-self.

The Buddha refers to this body as the world and proclaims that the world is empty or void:⁸¹

“suñño loko, suñño loko’ti, bhante, vuccati. kittāvatā nu kho, bhante, suñño lokoti vuccatī”ti?

“yasmā ca kho, ānanda, suññaṃ attena vā attaniyena vā tasmā suñño lokoti vuccati. kiñca, ānanda, suññaṃ attena vā attaniyena vā? cakkhu kho, ānanda, suññaṃ attena vā attaniyena vā. rūpā suññā attena vā attaniyena vā, cakkhuvīññāṇaṃ suññaṃ attena vā attaniyena vā, cakkhusamphasso suñño attena vā attaniyena vā ... pe ... yampidaṃ manosamphassapaccayā uppajjati vedayitaṃ sukhaṃ

⁸¹ Saṃ.2.280 (SN 35.85 Suññataloka Sutta)



*vā dukkhaṃ vā adukkhamasukhaṃ vā tampi suññaṃ
attena vā attaniyena vā. yasmā ca kho, ānanda,
suññaṃ attena vā attaniyena vā, tasmā suñño lokoti
vuccatī”ti.*

‘Empty is the world; empty is the world.’ In what way, venerable sir, is it said, ‘Empty is the world’?”

“It is, Ānanda, because it is empty of self and of what belongs to self that it is said, ‘Empty is the world.’ And what is empty of self and of what belongs to self? The eye, Ānanda, is empty of self and of what belongs to self. Forms are empty of self and of what belongs to self. Eye-consciousness is empty of self and of what belongs to self. Eye-contact is empty of self and of what belongs to self.... Whatever feeling arises with mind-contact as a condition— whether pleasant or painful or neither-painful-nor-pleasant— that too is empty of self and of what belongs to self. “It is, Ānanda, because it is empty of self and of what belongs to self that it is said, ‘Empty is the world.’”

In this way, we need to reflect that there is no owner, there is no one who can stay in our body without passing away, there is no doer, there is no something who feels or something who can feel the object without passing away, and there is no manager in this body. By thinking in this way, you should contemplate, “This body is emptiness, the emptiness of self, it is *suñña*.”

In the Visuddhimagga, voidness (*suññatā*) with reference to each of the Four Noble Truths is examined:⁸²

*dhuvasubhasukhattasuññaṃ,
purimadvayamattasuññaṃamatapadaṃ.
dhuvasukhāttavirahito,
maggoiti suññatā tesu.*

So void of lastingness, and beauty, pleasure, self,
is the first pair, and void of self the deathless state,
and void of lastingness, of pleasure and of self
is the path too; for such is voidness in these four.

The Four Noble Truths	<i>Dhuva</i> (lastingness)	<i>Subha</i> (beauty)	<i>Sukha</i> (pleasure)	<i>Atta</i> (self)
<i>Dukkha</i> (suffering)	X	X	X	X
<i>Samudaya</i> (origin)	X	X	X	X
<i>Nirodha</i> (cessation)	✓	✓	✓	X
<i>Magga</i> (path)	X	✓	X	X

The first two noble truths are mundane *nāmarūpa* and the object of *vipassanā*, so they are void of all these four attributes.

⁸² Visuddhi.2.144 (Vism.2.16.indriyasaccaniddeso.magganiddesakathā).
[English translation by Bhikkhu Ñāṇamoli]



The Truth of the Cessation of Suffering refers to Nibbāna, which is lasting, beautiful, and pleasurable. However, it is non-self. Hence, *nirodha sacca* is only void of *atta* (self).

The Truth of the Path Leading to the Cessation of Suffering consists of the supramundane Noble Eightfold Path. These are eight mental factors arising with the Path consciousness. They, too, are subject to arising and perishing and are, therefore, impermanent (*anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and non-self (*anatta*). Therefore, *maggā sacca* is void of lastingness, pleasure, and self. However, as its object is *Nibbāna*, which is supremely peaceful, it is considered *subha* (beautiful).

2. *Anattato* (non-self)

Anattato carries the same definitions as explained earlier for *suññato*. This body is non-self.

Ordinary people may say that the body is “me,” “self” or “soul”. However, this is their misguided view. There is no such reality in the body. Such a view is a wrong view and does not align with reality. Instead, we must contemplate that the body is void, *suññā*, and non-self, *anatta*.

When someone contemplates in this way, knowledge arises within him. That knowledge is Right View and also Right Thought. If you contemplate in this way, it can also be considered Right Effort, Right Mindfulness, and Right

Concentration. This type of contemplation can lead to *Nibbāna*.

In the earlier contemplations under the *anicca* group and *dukkha* group, when contemplation leads us to the realization of *Nibbāna*, the state of *Nibbāna* is often described with a term opposite to the one used in the contemplation. For example, in the case of *aniccato*, if we contemplate the five aggregates as *anicca* (impermanent), it leads to *Nibbāna*, which is *nicca* (permanent). Thus, the five aggregates are impermanent, and *Nibbāna* is the opposite: permanent.

Paramasuñña (Nibbāna) (ultimate emptiness)

In this context, the body is *suññā* (emptiness), but *Nibbāna* is not *asuñña*. Instead, *Nibbāna* is *paramasuñña*. *Parama* means “the most superior”, and *suñña* means “emptiness”. Therefore, the name of *Nibbāna* is *paramasuñña* – the most superior form of emptiness.

The Body, or the five aggregates, is empty of a self, making it void. *Nibbāna* is also void. Void of what? Void of all formations. Because of this, *Nibbāna* is not *asuñña*; *Nibbāna* is also *suñña*. However, it is *paramasuñña*—the most superior emptiness. Among all phenomena, *Nibbāna* is the most superior.

The Buddha declared, “*Nibbānaparamam sukhaṃ*”—*Nibbāna* is the most superior happiness. In this way, *Nibbāna* is the most superior, the highest. Another term for *Nibbāna*



is *anuttara*—nothing is higher or more superior than *Nibbāna*. It is unsurpassable. Thus, in this case, we cannot describe *Nibbāna* as *asuñña*. *Nibbāna* is *paramasuñña*.

Paramattha (Nibbāna) (ultimate phenomenon)

Similarly, when we contemplate *anatta* (non-self), it leads us to *Nibbāna*. However, we cannot say that *nibbāna* is *atta* (self), even though we often use an opposite term to describe *Nibbāna*. In this case, we cannot describe *Nibbāna* as *atta*. Instead, it is called *paramattha*.

Parama means “the most superior”, and *attha* can be translated as “phenomenon” or “meaning”. Here, *attha* refers to phenomena. Therefore, *paramattha* can be translated as “the most superior phenomenon”.

If we contemplate this body as “emptiness, emptiness, *suñña, suñña*”, it can lead to *Nibbāna*, which is *paramasuñña*, the most superior emptiness.

If we contemplate this body as “*anatta, anatta*, non-self, non-self”, it can lead to *Nibbāna*, which is *paramattha*, the most superior phenomenon or the most superior element.

The Buddha taught:

*Suññato lokam avekkhassu, mogharāja sadā sato.
attānudiṭṭhim ūhacca, evaṃ maccutaro siyā.
evaṃ lokam avekkhantaṃ, maccurājā na passati.*⁸³

⁸³ Khu.1.448 (Suttanipāta verse 1125)

View the world as empty –
Mogharaja! Always mindful,
To have removed any view about Self,
this way one is above and beyond death.
This is how one views the world,
so as not to be seen by Death's king.

Additional Information on Emptiness in the Practice

During meditation practice, some meditators may penetrate the body to the point where the body appears as a bright light. At that stage, they may no longer see their physical form, only the bright light. Some may mistakenly believe that this is the attainment of emptiness (*suññatā*), but it is not.

Here, I would like to share different aspects of emptiness that a meditator may encounter or experience during the course of meditation practice:

- (i) *ajaṭākāsa* (open space)/*paricchinākāsa* (delineated space) – for the development of the space *kasiṇa* (*ākāsakasiṇa*) up to the attainment of the fourth or fifth *rūpāvacara jhāna*.⁸⁴

⁸⁴ There are generally four types of *ākāsa* – *ajaṭākāsa*, *paricchinākāsa*, *kasiṇuggahātimākāsa*, and *rūpaparicchedākāsa*. Among these, the first type, *ajaṭākāsa* is just open space and is usually not involved in the practice. However, in the *Vibhaṅga-aṭṭhakathā* page 68 (Abhi.Ṭṭha.2.68), while commenting on *bāhirā ākāsadhātu*, it is stated, “*Iminā yasmim ākāse parikammaṃ karontassa catukkapañcakajjhānāni uppajjanti taṃ kathitaṃ.*”



- (ii) *kasiṇugghāṭimākāsa* (space after the removal of kasiṇa) – for the development of the first *arūpāvacara jhāna*.
- (iii) *rūpaparicchedākāsa* (space delineated by the boundaries of rūpa-kalāpas) – one of the unreal (*anipphanna*) *rūpa*, referred to as *ākāśadhātu* (space element). This is discerned during the stage of *rūpakammaṭṭhāna* (discernment of materiality).
- (iv) *akiñcaññāyatana* (the base of nothingness) – the object of the third *arūpāvacara jhāna*, which is *akiñcañña* (nothingness) or *abhava-paññatti* (the concept of absence) – in this case, it is the absence of the first *arūpāvacara jhāna* consciousness which takes boundless space as its object.
- (v) *nirodhasamāpatti* (the attainment of cessation) – this refers to the complete cessation of *citta* (consciousness), *cetasika* (mental factors), and *cittajarūpa* (mind-born materiality). In this attainment, there is no mind and no object. This

(The system of four or five jhānas arises for one who has done preliminary kasiṇa work based on a certain space, and that space is being referred to here). In the Mūḷaṭṭikā page 44 (Abhi.mṭikā.2.44), it is clarified that this space is not referring to *kasiṇugghāṭimākāsa*, but to *ajaṭākāsa*. The Anuṭṭikā page 53 (Abhi.anuṭṭikā.53) further explains that the *paricchedākāsa* used for kasiṇa preliminary works is based on *ajaṭākāsa*, which is obtained through delineation of open space, such as that seen through a wall fissure, etc. The meaning is that the delineated space (*paricchinnākāsa* or *paricchedākāsa*) used for kasiṇa preliminary works is derived from the delineation of open space (*ajaṭākāsa*). Hence, *ajaṭākāsa* here can also be considered as being involved in the practice for the development of space kasiṇa meditation.

state can only be achieved by a non-returner (*anāgāmi*) or an *arahant* who has developed both *samatha* and *vipassanā*. This state arises when the meditator becomes weary of the continuous arising and perishing of formations (*saṅkhāra*). They enter *nirodhasamāpatti* for up to seven days to experience *diṭṭha-dhamma-sukha-vihāra* (pleasant abiding in the present life).

- (vi) *anuppādanirodha* in *udayabbaya-vipassanā* – In addition, at the stage of *udayabbaya* (arising and perishing) in *vipassanā* practice, the meditator needs to discern that with the future cessation of *avijjā* (ignorance), *taṇhā* (craving), *upādāna* (clinging), *kamma* and *saṅkhāra* (formations) at the *arahanta* stage, there will also be the cessation of *viññāṇa* (consciousness), *nāma-rūpa* (mentality and materiality), etc. (*avijjānirodhā saṅkhāra-nirodho, saṅkhāranirodhā viññāṇa-nirodho*, etc.).

These are the various aspects of emptiness a meditator may encounter in the course of practice. But these are not the same as what we have just discussed earlier under *suññato* (as emptiness) – where emptiness here means empty of a self, *atta*.

These various aspects of emptiness are encountered at different stages of meditative practice. However, they are not the same as the earlier discussion of *suññato* as emptiness in the sense of being void of a self (*atta*). The specific emptiness we discussed earlier under *suññato* refers



to the realization that the body, mind, and all phenomena are empty of self or soul, aligning with the core teaching of non-self (*anattā*).

3. *Parato* (alien/stranger)

*avasatāya, avidheyyatāya ca parato*⁸⁵

The next contemplation is *parato*. The term *para* means “the other”, “another person”, or “not me”. Or we may say it as a stranger. Our body is like a stranger, an alien; it is someone else other than me. You need to contemplate this body as a stranger, as an alien, as someone else, as not me.

avasatāya (not in mastery)

The first definition is *avasatāya*—not in mastery. We cannot control the body according to our desires. Just like we cannot control other people to do as we wish. For example, I may want meditators to meditate the whole night, but they may not follow my desire; they may not practice the whole night. Why? Because they are apart from me. They are others; they are strangers to me.

In the same way, this body is also like that. It is not within our control; it is like a stranger. We want to be handsome or beautiful, we want to be happy always, we want to be healthy, we want to be young forever, and we do not want to die. But this body reacts like a stranger; it does not follow our

⁸⁵ *parato*: as *alien* because of inability to have mastery exercised over them, and because of intractability;

desire. The nature of the body is aging, sickness, and death, even though we do not want it to be so.

Therefore, we need to contemplate, “This body is a stranger, an alien; this body is someone else, this body is not me. *Para, para.*”

avidheyyatāya (intractable)

The second definition of parato is intractable (*avidheyyatāya*). This means that we cannot manage this body. We may try to order the body, “Please don’t grow old”, or “Please don’t die”. But we cannot command this body.

This body is like someone else, like a stranger. When we meet strangers, we may not be able to manage or instruct them to do as we want, because they are strangers; they are not us. In the same way, our body is like a stranger, beyond our ability to manage.

We may feed the body with good food, give it good medicine, or live in good weather. But despite all these efforts, we cannot stop the body from aging, becoming sick, or dying. Since we cannot manage it, this body is like a stranger; this body is someone else, it is not me. We need to contemplate that.

If we contemplate in this way, that knowledge may lead to *Nibbāna*, which is *aparapaccaya* (not-other-conditioned)⁸⁶,

⁸⁶ *paccaya* also means something that should be relied upon, something trustworthy. *Para* means others or another. Thus, *aparapaccaya* means that there is no reliance on any other thing that can be trusted. Only *Nibbāna* is



meaning it is not dependent on any other conditions. Our body depends on many conditions, but *Nibbāna* is independent of all conditions. *Nibbāna* is completely free from dependencies.

In the Saṃyutta Nikāya, Venerable Ānanda advises Venerable Vaṅḡisa to see formations as alien:

*“saṅkhāre parato passa, dukkhato mā ca attato.
nibbāpehi mahārāgaṃ, mā ḡayhittho
punappunaṃ.”⁸⁷*

“See formations as alien,
As suffering, not as self.
Extinguish the great fire of lust.
Don’t burn up again and again.”

In the Theragāthāpāḡi, Venerable Mahāmogallāna also declares himself seeing the five aggregates and formations as alien:

*1169 “sukhumaṃ te paṭivijjhanti,
vālaggaṃ usunā yathā.
ye paṅcakkhandhe passanti,
parato no ca attato.*

reliable and trustworthy for a noble person who has seen *Nibbāna* directly. Only this *Nibbāna Dhamma* is reliable, not anything else.

⁸⁷ Saṃ.1.189 (SN 8.4 Ānanda Sutta). [English translation by Bhikkhu Bodhi]

1170 “*ye ca passanti saṅkhāre,
parato no ca attato.
paccabyādhimsu nipuṇaṃ,
vālaggaṃ usunā yathā.*”⁸⁸

“Those who see the five aggregates
as other (alien), not as self,
penetrate a subtle thing,
like a hair-tip with an arrow.

Those who see formations
as other (alien), not as self,
pierce a fine thing,
like a hair-tip with an arrow.”

4. *Rittato* (lacking)

*yathā-parikappitehi dhuva-subha-sukhattabhāvehi rittatāya
rittato*⁸⁹

The next contemplation is *rittato*. *Ritta* has a meaning very similar to *suñña*—nothingness or emptiness. They are closely related. Another meaning of *ritta* is that it has no essence, no hardwood. In a tree, usually, only the hardwood is useful, while the other parts are not as useful. In the same way, our

⁸⁸ Khu.2.362 (Theragāthāpāli, 20. Saṭṭhinipāto, 1. Mahāmoggallānattheragāthā).
[English Translation by Bhikkhu Sujato]

⁸⁹ ***Rittato***: as *lacking* because of their lacking of the lastingness, beauty, pleasure, and self that are conceived about them.



body has nothing solid or truly useful. That is why it is called *ritta*.

dhuva-rittatāya (devoid of constancy)

It is *ritta* because of the emptiness of a doer. Those with wrong views think of a doer and believe that this body is constant (*dhuva*). However, there is no such stability in the body. The body is not constant (*adhuva*).

subha-rittatāya (devoid of beauty)

Some people who hold wrong views may think that this body is beautiful or handsome, but that is not correct. As you know, when we wake up, we need to wash our face and mouth. If you think that this body is beautiful, try keeping it unbathed for two or three days, and then you will see whether the body is truly beautiful.

Similarly, when you wear clean clothes, after one or two days, they become dirty and begin to smell. However, if you keep the clothing by itself without wearing it, there is no need to wash it. It only becomes soiled and dirty when it comes into contact with your body.

In the same way, the food that has not yet been eaten looks nice and presentable. But once you put the food into your mouth, nobody wants to see it anymore. It looks and smells like vomitus.

People with wrong views think of this body as *subha*—beautiful or handsome—but in reality, it is not so. This is just

their idea. Instead, the body is *asubha*—impure and repulsive.

sukha-rittatāya (devoid of happiness)

Another wrong idea about the body is that it is *sukha*—happiness. People think that the body is happy or a source of happiness. But this is not true. When we sit for a long time, pain starts to develop here and there. We need to move and change our posture. This is not happiness.

We must also be cautious about what we eat, the weather we expose our bodies to, and whatever we use or come into contact with. We need to take care of everything related to the body. In this way, this body is void of happiness; it is empty of true happiness.

attabhāva-rittatāya (devoid of self)

Another wrong idea is that the body has a self (*attabhāva*). We often say that this body is “me” or “mine”, but actually, it is neither. The body exists based on conditions and does not function according to our desires. It is empty of self (*attabhāva*). The body is non-self (*anatta*).

In summary, this body is empty of stability, empty of beauty, empty of happiness, and empty of soul or self. Therefore, we should contemplate that this body is *ritta, ritta*, emptiness, emptiness, no essence, no essence”.



*Pheṇapiṇḍūpamaṃ rūpaṃ, vedanā bubbuḷūpamā;
Marīcikūpamā saññā, saṅkhārā kadalūpamā;
Māyūpamañca viññāṇaṃ, desitādiccabandhunā.
yathā yathā nijjhāyati, yoniso upaparikkhati.
rittaṃ tuccakaṃ hoti, yo naṃ passati yoniso.*⁹⁰

Form is like a lump of foam,
Feeling like a water bubble;
Perception is like a mirage,
Volitions like a plantain trunk,
And consciousness is like an illusion,
So explained the Kinsman of the Sun.
However one may ponder it
And carefully investigate it,
It appears but hollow and void
When one views it carefully.

This contemplation will lead to *Nibbāna*, which is *aritta*—not empty. The body is *ritta*, empty of *subha* and *sukha*. But *Nibbāna* is not empty of *subha* or *sukha*. Therefore, *Nibbāna* is *aritta*.

⁹⁰ Sam.2.116 (SN 22.95 Pheṇapiṇḍūpama Sutta). [English translation by Bhikkhu Bodhi]

5. *Tucchato* (vain)

*rittatāyeva tucchato appakattā vā, appakampi hi loke tucchanti vuccati*⁹¹

appakattā (worthless)

The next contemplation is *tucchato*, reflected as *tuccha*. In English, *tuccha* may be translated as worthless—it is not worth anything. Why is it not worth it? The reasons are similar to what has already been explained under *rittato*: the body is devoid of constancy (*dhuva*), happiness (*sukha*), beauty (*subha*), and self (*attabhāva*). In this way, this body is worthless.

appakam (minimal)

Another definition of *tuccha* is that it is not entirely void of everything. There is something, but it is very little, very minuscule. In our body, there is something, but so little that it might as well be considered nothing. For example, if there is only a small amount of food left on a plate, someone might ask “Is there food?” You could reply, “Nothing”, because the remaining amount is so small that it is almost negligible. Similarly, *tuccha* means “like nothing”. It does not imply total emptiness but conveys a sense of very little, to the point of being inconsequential.

Why is there only so little in our body? The body consists of materiality and mentality, but these are constantly arising

⁹¹ ***Tucchato***: as *vain* because of their emptiness, or because of their triviality; for what is trivial is called “vain” in the world.



and perishing at an incredibly rapid rate. They arise, persist momentarily, and then perish.

If materiality and mentality are arising and perishing so quickly, how do we can perceive the body? This is due to the continuity of new phenomena arising after old ones perish. It is like water in a river: the water you see is not the same water as before. The previous water flows downstream while new water replaces it from upstream. Though it appears that the water is the same, it is constantly being replaced, but we are generally unaware of this.

Another simile given in the scriptures is the flame of an oil lamp. The flame exists due to the support of oil as fuel. However, the flame you see at one moment is not the same as the previous one. The earlier flame burns with the earlier oil, and as the oil is consumed, new oil feeds the new flame. Though it appears to be the same flame, it is, in fact, a continuous arising of new flames supported by new oil.

Similarly, in the body, materiality and mentality arise and perish so rapidly that we perceive continuity. For example, when you see my hand moving from right to left, it seems as though the same hand is moving across. However, in reality, no materiality can move from one point to another. Materiality simply arises and perishes at each adjacent point, giving the illusion of movement.

All phenomena within our body exist for an incredibly short duration—much less than a fraction of a second. They arise, perish, and arise again, repeating in this manner. This fleeting

existence means that the body cannot persist in any state for long.

If this body could last longer, it might be considered a source of happiness. For example, during a good meditation session, your mind feels calm and happy. You might wish to hold onto that experience and keep it somewhere in the body to preserve it for your next session. However, the problem is that such states are impermanent and cannot be retained. Sometimes, meditation is peaceful, but external sounds or disturbances can easily disrupt this peace, replacing happiness with agitation.

In this way, everything lasts for only a brief moment. This brevity makes it seem as though the body is nothing or empty. While it is not entirely "nothing," its existence is so fleeting and minimal that it may as well be considered *tuccha*—worthless or empty.

To truly understand what exists (and what does not) in this body, we need to discern materiality and mentality, their causes and effects, and their arising and perishing. This discernment is especially crucial for realizing *anatta*, or non-self.

We should contemplate, “This body is worthless, it is nothing, *tuccha, tuccha*.” Through such contemplation, we may realize *Nibbāna*. While the body is *tuccha*, *Nibbāna* is not. *Nibbāna* can be taken as the object of *magga* and *phala* (Path and Fruition). Therefore, it is not completely void—it is *atuccha*. Furthermore, *Nibbāna* is not a *paññatti* (concept) but is *lokuttara* (supramundane) and *paramattha* (ultimate reality).



As the *asaṅkhatadhātu* (unconditioned element), *Nibbāna* is *paramattha*--a reality, not a mere concept.

In the Theragāthā, Venerable Kulla reflects on the hollowness of the body by comparing it to a discarded corpse:

393. *“kullo sivathikaṃ gantvā,
addasa itthimujjhitaṃ.
apaviddhaṃ susānasmim,
khajjantiṃ kimihī phuṭaṃ.*

394. *“āturaṃ asuciṃ pūtiṃ,
passa kulla samussayaṃ.
uggharantaṃ paggharantaṃ,
bālānaṃ abhinanditaṃ.*

395. *“dhammādāsaṃ gahetvāna,
ñāṇadassanapattiyā.
paccavekkhiṃ imaṃ kāyaṃ,
tucchaṃ santarabāhiraṃ.*

396. *“yathā idaṃ tathā etaṃ,
yathā etaṃ tathā idaṃ.
yathā adho tathā uddhaṃ,
yathā uddhaṃ tathā adho.*

397. “*yathā divā tathā rattiṃ,
yathā rattiṃ tathā divā.
yathā pure tathā pacchā,
yathā pacchā tathā pure.*”⁹²

393. I, Kulla, went to a charnel ground
and saw a woman’s body abandoned there,
thrown away in the cemetery, being eaten, full
of worms.

394. See this body, Kulla, diseased, impure, rotten,
oozing and trickling, the delight of fools.

395. Taking the Dhamma as a mirror
for the attainment of knowledge and vision,
I considered this body, **hollow (empty)** inside
and out.

396. As this is, so is that; as that is, so is this.
As below, so above; as above, so below.⁹³

⁹² Khu.2.283 (theragāthāpāḷi, 6. chakkanipāto, 4. Kullattheragāthā verses 393-397). [English translation by K.R. Norman & Bhikkhu Sujato]

⁹³ According to the commentary, this (*idaṃ*) refers to this body of mine, while that (*etaṃ*) refers to the external dead body. Just as this impure body of mine is currently not deprived of life, body temperature, and consciousness (*āyūsmāviññāṇā*) and can show various actions caused by the mind, the dead body was in the same state in the past. Just as now the dead body is deprived of those states and can no longer show any bodily actions, in the same way, this body of mine will be deprived of all those states in the future.



397. As by day, so by night; as by night, so by day.
As before, so after; as after, so before.⁹⁴

Just as this body of mine is not currently lying dead in the cemetery and not showing rotting states, such as being bloated and so on, this dead body was in the same state in the past. Just as the dead body is now lying in the cemetery undergoing stages of decomposition such as bloating and so on, this body of mine will be the same in the future.

Alternatively, just as this body of mine is impure, foul-smelling, disgusting, repulsive, impermanent, suffering, and non-self, so is this dead body. Just as this dead body is impure, foul-smelling, disgusting, repulsive, impermanent, suffering, and non-self, so is this body of mine.

With regards to below (*adho*) and above (*uddham*), the reference point is the navel. The parts of the body that are below the navel and those that are above are similarly impure, foul-smelling, disgusting, repulsive, impermanent, suffering, and non-self.

⁹⁴ Just as this body excretes impurities, such as eye-discharge from the eyes, during the day (*divā*), so it does at night (*rattim*) as well. What it excretes at night, it excretes during the day too.

Just as in the past (*pure*) when we were young (*taruṇakāle*), this body was impure, foul-smelling, disgusting, and repulsive, so it shall be in the future (*pacchā*) when we are old (*jiṇṇakāle*). It applies the other way around as well.

Alternatively, just as in the past (*pure atītakāle*) when this body was alive with consciousness (*saviññāṇakāle*), this body was impure, etc., and impermanent, etc., so it shall be in the future (*pacchā anāgatakāle*) when it is dead and without consciousness (*aviññāṇakāle*). This meaning should also be understood.

Understanding the Stages of Vipassanā Practice

At the start of the talk, I mentioned that *Vipassanā* practice consists of four parts:

1. Discerning materiality
2. Discerning mentality
3. Discerning cause and effect
4. Contemplating *anicca* (impermanence), *dukkha* (suffering), and *anatta* (non-self) in the arising and perishing of materiality, mentality, and their causes.

Since the real practice of *Vipassanā* is focused on the contemplation of the *samañña-lakkhaṇa* (general characteristics) of *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anatta*, why is there a need for the additional steps of discerning materiality, mentality and their causes and effects? The main reason is to deepen our understanding of *anatta* before formally starting the *Vipassanā* practice.

Generally, the wrong view of self, *atta*, can be classified into two categories:

- (a) *jīva-atta* (the soul as self) – the mistaken belief that there is a self within the body, like a soul.
- (b) *Parama-atta* (the superior self) – the mistaken belief that there is a superior being outside of the body, governing and creating all our experiences.



By discerning ultimate materiality and ultimate mentality, we gain a true understanding of what actually exists in this body and, therefore, what does not exist in it. What we have are only the intrinsic characteristics (*sabhava-lakkhaṇa*) of hardness (*kakkhaḷatta*), touching (*phusana*), and so on, of ultimate materiality and ultimate mentality. There is no being, no soul, no self (*atta*) in the body. This understanding helps dispel the wrong notion of *jīva-atta* (the soul as self).

By discerning causes and effects, we understand that all phenomena arise and perish due to causes and conditions. There is no external superior creator controlling or orchestrating events. This insight helps dispel the wrong notion of *Parama-atta* (the superior self).

In this way, the purpose of discerning materiality and mentality, as well as their causes and effects, is to deepen our knowledge of non-self, *anatta*.

Furthermore, during the *udayabbaya* (arising and perishing) stage of *Vipassanā* practice, meditators acquire a deeper understanding of impermanence, *anicca*. Since what is impermanent (*anicca*) is also non-self (*anatta*), this further deepens the understanding of *anatta*.

And what is both *anicca* and *anatta*, is also *dukkha* (suffering or unsatisfactoriness). In this way, the various stages leading up to advanced *Vipassanā* practice build a profound understanding of the true nature of *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anatta* in all formations. This eventually facilitates the

maturity of *Vipassanā* insight, which liberates us from the cycle of rebirths (*saṃsāra*).

The 40-to's or the 40 ways of contemplation explained in this talk also serve this same purpose: to deepen our understanding of *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anatta*.

Conclusion

We have now completed the 40-to's, the 40 ways of contemplation.

The word *Vipassanā* is composed of two parts: *vi* and *passanā*. *Passanā* means “mentally seeing” or “mentally observing”. *Vi* means “in many special ways”—not just in a single way, but in various ways; not merely in the ordinary way that most people view the body, but in special, insightful ways. In short, *Vipassanā* means mentally seeing or mentally observing the object in many special ways.

Through this teaching, we have now learned multiple ways to reflect and contemplate as part of *Vipassanā* practice. You can reflect on the body, on *nāma* and *rūpa* (mentality and materiality), or on the five *khandhas* (aggregates). You can contemplate how the causes for these five aggregates are *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anatta*. Likewise, the effects (these five aggregates) are also *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anatta*. Since there are 40 contemplations for each aggregate, there are a total of 200 *Vipassanā* methods for all five aggregates (40 x 5 = 200).

You may also apply these 40 contemplations to the twelve bases (*āyatana*) or the eighteen elements (*dhātu*). Sometimes, you may choose to contemplate only on mentality (*nāma*), sometimes only on materiality (*rūpa*), and at other times on both mentality and materiality together. You can also contemplate the eleven categories of past, future, present, internal, external, gross and subtle, inferior

and superior, far and near. At times, your focus may be on the characteristic of *anicca*, at other times on *dukkha*, and at other times on *anatta*.

May you be able to reflect and contemplate in accordance with the way of *Vipassanā*, following the Buddha's teaching.

May you be free from all these sufferings mentioned above through the practice of *Vipassanā*.

*Aniccā vata saṅkhārā uppāda vaya dhammino,
Uppajjitvā nirujjhanti, tesam vūpasamo sukho.*⁹⁵

Impermanent are formations,
They arise and cease, that is their nature:
They come into being and pass away,
Release from them is bliss supreme.

*“sabbe saṅkhārā aniccā”ti, yadā paññāya passati.
atha nibbindati dukkhe, esa maggo visuddhiyā.*⁹⁶

“All conditioned things are impermanent” –
When one sees this with wisdom,
one is disenchanted with suffering.
This is the path to purification.

⁹⁵ Dī.2.129 (DN 16 Mahaparinibbāna Sutta).

⁹⁶ The last three verses: Khu.1.53 Dhammapade (Dhammapa verses 277-279)



*“sabbe saṅkhārā dukkhā”ti, yadā paññāya passati.
atha nibbindati dukkhe, esa maggo visuddhiyā.*

“All conditioned things are unsatisfactory” –
When one sees this with wisdom,
one is disenchanted with suffering.
This is the path to purification.

*“sabbe dhammā anattā”ti, yadā paññāya passati.
atha nibbindati dukkhe, esa maggo visuddhiyā.*

“All phenomena are non-self” –
When one sees this with wisdom,
one is disenchanted with suffering.
This is the path to purification.

Sādhu Sādhu Sādhu!

Appendix: Additional Contemplations at the Paṭisaṅkhañāṇa and Saṅkhārupekkhāñāṇa Stages

Introduction

In the Visuddhimagga, the 40 contemplations (known as the 40-to practice) are first introduced under the stage of Comprehension Knowledge (*sammasana-ñāṇa*). They appear again, with slight variations and additional contemplations, under the stages of Reflection Knowledge (*paṭisaṅkha-ñāṇa*) and Knowledge of Equanimity towards Formations (*saṅkhārupekkhā-ñāṇa*) in the progress of insight meditation.

The method proceeds as follows: first, one discerns materiality, then mentality (*nāma-rūpa-pariccheda-ñāṇa*); next, one discerns cause and effect (*paccaya-pariggaha-ñāṇa*); and finally, one contemplates the arising and perishing of materiality, mentality, and their causes. At the stage of Comprehension Knowledge (*sammasana-ñāṇa*), one practices the 40-to contemplations, and from there, progresses to the Knowledge of Arising and Perishing (*udayabbaya-ñāṇa*).

Subsequently, the meditator observes perishing alone, developing successive insights: Knowledge of Dissolution (*bhaṅga-ñāṇa*), Knowledge of Fear (*bhaya-ñāṇa*), Knowledge of Danger (*ādīnava-ñāṇa*), Knowledge of Disenchantment (*nibbida-ñāṇa*), and Knowledge of Desire for Deliverance (*muñcitu-kamyata-ñāṇa*). Throughout these stages, one



continues to observe the perishing of phenomena, each time with a deepened understanding—seeing them as fearful, dangerous, unsatisfactory, and generating the aspiration for release.

This process may be illustrated by the analogy of a married couple. In the beginning, husband and wife cherish one another deeply. Over time, as they live together, they begin to notice each other's faults, leading to *nibbida* (disenchantment) and *muñcitu-kamyata* (the desire to be free). In the same way, we initially love and cling to this body, but through the Buddha's teaching, we come to see its faults, its impermanent and suffering nature, and we naturally develop the wish to be liberated from it.

However, just as one should reflect carefully before deciding on divorce to avoid future regret, the next stage of insight is Reflection Knowledge (*paṭisaṅkha-ñāṇa*)—a stage of renewed contemplation and verification to ensure certainty. Here, the Visuddhimagga recommends practicing the 40-to contemplations once again, now with additional reflections, which will be briefly explained below.

**Contemplations under Paṭisaṅkhañña stage in
Visuddhimagga⁹⁷**

*so sabbasaṅkhāre anaccantikato, tāvakālikato, uppāda-
vayaparicchinno, palokato, calato, pabhaṅgato,
addhuvato, vipariṇāmadhammato, assārakato,
vibhavato, saṅkhatato, maraṇadhammatotiādīhi
kāraṇehi **aniccā**ti passati.*

*abhiṇhapatipīlanato, dukkhamato, dukkhavatthuto,
rogato, gaṇḍato, sallato, aghato, ābādhato, ītito,
upaddavato, bhayato, upasaggato, atāṇato, aleṇato,
asaraṇato, ādīnavato, aghamūlato, vadhakato,
sāsavato, mārāmisato, jātidhammato, jarādhammato,
byādhidhammato, sokadhammato, paridevadhammato,
upāyāsadhammato, saṃkilesikadhammatotiādīhi
kāraṇehi **dukkhā**ti passati.*

*ajaññato, duggandhato, jegucchato, paṭikkūlato,
amaṇḍanārahato, virūpato, bībhacchatotiādīhi kāraṇehi
dukkhalakkhaṇassa parivārabhūto **asubhato** passati.*

*parato, rittato, tucchato, suññato, assāmikato,
anissarato, avasavattitotiādīhi kāraṇehi **anattato**
passati.*

One sees [all formations] as impermanent (*anicca*) for
reasons such as: all formations are non-eternal,
temporary, bounded by arising and passing away,

⁹⁷ Visuddhi.2.289 (paṭipadāññadassanavisuddhiniddeso,
paṭisaṅkhānupassanāññakathā)



disintegrating, fickle, perishable, not constant, subject to change, having no core, due to be annihilated, formed, and subject to death.

[One] sees [them] as suffering (*dukkha*) for reasons such as: constant oppression, difficult to endure, being a basis for suffering, being like a disease, boil, dart, calamity, affliction, plague, disaster, terror, menace, no protection, no shelter, no refuge, being dangerous, being the root of calamity, being murderous, subject to cankers, being Māra's bait, and being subject to birth, aging, illness, sorrow, lamentation, despair, and defilements.

[One] sees [them] as repulsive (*asubha*) - being a constituent of the characteristic of suffering - for reasons such as: not delightful/not beautiful, foul-smelling, disgusting, repulsive, unworthy of adornment, ugly, and revolting.

[One] sees [them] as not-self (*anatta*) for reasons such as: alien/belonging to others, lacking, vain, voidness, without owner, without controller/creator, and not being under one's control.

Only some of those contemplations that have not been covered in the original 40-to are explained here.

Anicca

***Tāvakālikato* (temporary)**

Tāvakālika means temporary or short-term use. This body is like a borrowed property, without permanent ownership. We have this body for a limited time—perhaps 100 years—not as a freehold property. Even phones and houses are temporary; we should recognize that our body, possessions, relationships, and even monasteries are all for short-term use, not permanent.

Recent earthquakes in Mandalay, Myanmar, demonstrate this truth. People invested everything in their houses, thinking they would own them permanently, but earthquakes destroyed everything. When we reflect on the temporary nature of all things—body, possessions, children, friends—right view arises, and the mind becomes strong because our understanding aligns with reality.

***Uppāda-vaya-paricchinna* (bounded by arising and passing away)**

Everything is bound by arising and perishing. All living beings have clear boundaries of birth and death. Those with sharp *vipassanā* knowledge will see the arising and perishing of formations in every moment. Even great ancient monasteries like Jetavana and Pubbārāma no longer exist. Our lives, too, have birth and death as boundaries—we have birthdays and will have death-days.



Dukkha

***Abhiṇha-paṭipīlanato* (constant oppression)**

All formations have the nature of constantly oppressing or torturing. In deep *vipassanā*, we see everything being oppressed by constant arising and perishing. Even in daily life, we're constantly forced to change our postures, drink, eat, sleep, and attend to bodily needs. This constant maintenance is a form of torture. These endless requirements to keep the body comfortable are inherently oppressive.

The Buddha's teaching reminds us that even eating is suffering—we must seek food by going on alms-round, depend on others' generosity, and endure various difficulties. Life requires constant effort for survival, disposed to conflicts, wars, and competition. This body and mind are always subject to oppression and torture. If we cultivate the perception of suffering, everything we do appears as suffering.

***Dukkhamato* (difficult to endure)**

Dukkhamā means difficult to endure or difficult to maintain patience. If we truly understood this body's suffering, we would find it difficult to bear. We only tolerate it due to attachment. Try caring for someone you don't love as you care for yourself—washing their face, cleaning their waste—and you'll understand how burdensome these tasks truly are.

We perform these duties for ourselves and loved ones only because of attachment.

If we reflect correctly that everything related to this body is difficult to endure, it is the right knowledge that will lead to Nibbāna.

Asubha (as an ancillary characteristic of Dukkha)

***Ajañña*to (not delightful/not beautiful)**

Ajañña has two definitions here -- not delightful (*amanuñña*) or not beautiful (*asobhana*). Noble people don't delight in the body. They understand its suffering nature and do not develop a liking for the body. Due to the absence of this delight, they are not affected by worries and anxiety when harm comes to the body, be it in the form of adverse weather, unsuitable food, unfriendly foes, illnesses, or physical pains.

Additionally, this body is not aesthetically pleasing. Most people regard the body as beautiful or try to make it beautiful. This is a wrong view and improper attention. The Buddha did not allow monks to use mirrors except to examine wounds or observe aging—grey hair and physical deterioration—not to admire their appearance.



Duggandhato (foul-smelling)

This is quite obvious. If you notice a pleasant fragrance coming from someone, you should understand that it does not normally arise from the body itself. No part of the body naturally produces a good smell. Whatever comes into contact with the body—be it food, clothing, or medicine—will eventually give off an unpleasant odor.

Jegucchato (disgusting)

This body is disgusting. It is made up of 32 parts, none of which is beautiful. For example, saliva is acceptable in the mouth but disgusting once spat out. Hair and nails seem beautiful on the body, but become refuse once cut. The Buddha compared this to an old fox mistaking red flowers for meat due to hunger—we similarly mistake body parts as beautiful when attached to the body.

The body is called "*kāya*" (*ku* + *āya* = place of disgusting things). It has nine major openings plus countless pores constantly expelling impurities. Bacteria inhabit the body, using it as their toilet, hospital, and cemetery.

We should reflect on the body as "*jeguccha, jeguccha, disgusting, disgusting*". Such reflections will increase our knowledge, make our craving and defilements thinner, and approach nearer to Nibbāna.

Paṭikkūlato (repulsive)

The body is repulsive. It is the opposite of beautiful. It is synonymous with *jeguccha*, disgusting.

Amaṇḍanārahato (unworthy of adornment)

Amaṇḍanāraha means not worthy of adornment. This body is not worthy of decoration. We put on beautiful clothes to adorn the body. However, beautiful clothes become dirty when worn on the body. Perfume smells pleasant alone but develops a bad odor when applied to the body. The body is inherently unworthy of beautification.

Understanding this, practitioners will not try to adorn the body, but just to keep it clean and comfortable. No need to make it beautiful. Similarly, it is important to keep the monastery clean and tidy, but not necessary to make it grand and beautiful. From the donors' perspective, they may wish to offer the best, and this would be very beneficial for them. However, practitioners' mind should be content with that which is just sufficient to support the progress in practice.

The Visuddhimagga ṭīkā offers another interpretation: *amaṇḍanāhatā* (*amaṇḍanā* + *hatā*) - killed by lack of decoration. It is possible to destroy the body's beautiful nature by non-adornment. Without bathing, brushing teeth, and wearing clean clothes, the body's beauty dies. We are ashamed to show our bodies' natural state to others. We need to cover up with adornments. Its unpleasantness



becomes manifest through non-adornment. This constant need for maintenance reveals the body's naturally repulsive state.

Another interpretation for *amaṇḍanāhatā* is *maṇḍanā* + *ahata* – not killing if there is decoration. It conveys essentially the same meaning, but from a different perspective. If we put in effort to decorate the body, beauty will not die. It is similar to the earlier interpretation of the death of our beauty if we do not decorate ourselves. All these are showing the *asubha* nature of the body.

***Virūpato* (ugly)**

The definition of *virūpa* is *asundara* – generally not good. This body is not good. It is ugly.

***Bībhacchato* (revolting)**

Bībhaccha means extremely ugly. This ugliness can become an object of the fetter of hatred (*paṭighasaṃyojana*). The body becomes a cause for the arising of displeasure merely upon being seen. Our enemies see our bodies as extremely ugly and wish to harm them.

Another definition of *bībhaccha* is that it should be abandoned due to being unappetizing and disgusting, just like feces. The Buddha compared all forms of existence to feces—even small amounts are disgusting. He declared he

would never praise rebirth in any realm of existence, even for a short time, as all existence involves suffering.⁹⁸

In connection with this, the Buddha also taught the perception of non-delight in all the world (*sabbaloke anabhiratasaññā*). All realms of existence—whether humans, devas or brahmas—are inherently unsatisfactory and should not be delighted in. If there is life, there will be problems.

Therefore, we should reflect this body as “*bībhaccha, bībhaccha*, exceedingly ugly and disgusting”.

⁹⁸ Añ.1.36 (AN 1.320 - ekaṇipātapāḷi, 16. Ekadhammapāḷi, 3, tatiyavaggo) “*seyyathāpi, bhikkhave, appamattakopi gūtho duggandho hoti; evamevaṃ kho ahaṃ, bhikkhave, appamattakampi bhavaṃ na vaṇṇemi, antamaso accharāsaṅghātamattampi*”.

“Bhikkhus, just as even a trifling amount of feces is foul smelling, so too I do not praise even a trifling amount of existence, even for a mere finger snap.”



Anatta

***Apariṇāyakato* (lacking a leader)⁹⁹**

We should discern this body as lacking a leader. No Self or God is controlling this body. Everything depends on conditions—the physical body depends on food, weather, kamma, and mind, while the mind depends on the physical body, association with teachers, and many other factors. No permanent leader or controller exists; everything arises through interdependence on causes and conditions.

⁹⁹ This does not appear directly in Visuddhimagga, but in the Visuddhimagga Ṭīkā as an elaboration of the word “*ādi*” in the original Visuddhimagga text.

Additional Contemplations under the Saṅkhārupekkhāñāṇa stage¹⁰⁰

Following the *Paṭisaṅkha-ñāṇa* stage, the Visuddhimagga describes various modes of discerning voidness (*suññatā*) at the *Saṅkhārupekkhā-ñāṇa* (knowledge of equanimity towards formations) stage. Among these are contemplations similar to those previously discussed under the 40-to methods, as well as several additional reflections, which are briefly explained below.

***Anissariyato* (having no sovereignty)**

One contemplates the body as lacking sovereignty or authority because of the absence of any authority within the body, and no one can possibly exercise sovereignty or authority over the body.

***Akāmākāriyato* (incapable of being made as one wishes)**

Just as a person wishing to shape a lump of foam into a vessel would fail, so too one wishing to make the body permanent fails to do so. The body cannot act according to one's desires, for there is no inherent power of one's own desire that can make it so.

¹⁰⁰ Visuddhi.2.293 (paṭipadāñāṇadassanavisuddhiniddeso, saṅkhārupekkhāñāṇakathā, paragraphs 763 and 765)



***Alabbhanīyato* (incapable of being obtained as one desires)**

It is unattainable to have the body conform to one's wishes. Desires such as "Let the body be thus" or "Let it not be thus" can never be fulfilled.

***Avasavattanato* (insusceptible to the exercise of mastery)**

One contemplates that the body is not subject to one's control. It does not act according to one's wishes, nor can it be made to obey the wishes of another. Likewise, one cannot make another being's body conform to one's own desire. Each body follows its own natural course, governed by causes and conditions, and not by the command of any self or being.

***Vivittato* (secluded)**

One contemplates that the body is secluded from both its causes and its effects. The effect is not contained within the cause, nor is the cause contained within the effect. This differs from the case of a foetus in the mother's womb, where the effect (the foetus) exists within the cause (the mother). Here, however, cause and effect do not coexist; they are temporally distinct and not contained within each other.

In commenting on the body's seclusion from causes, the Visuddhimagga sub-commentary gives the example of "like doer and so on" (*kāraṇakādi viya kāraṇehi, phalena ca*

vivittato)¹⁰¹. This may be understood in the same way that one discerns there is no doer (*kāraṇa*), but only the doing—no agent, only the process of action. As the verse expresses:

*“dukkhameva hi, na koci dukkhito.
kāraṇa na, kiriyāva vijjati.
atthi nibbuti, na nibbuto pumā.
maggamatthi, gamako na vijjati”*ti.¹⁰²

For there is suffering, but none who suffers;
Doing exists although there is no doer.
Extinction is, but no extinguished person;
Although there is a path, there is no goer.

***Asaranibhutato* (unfit to be a refuge)**

One understands the body to be unfit to serve as a refuge, for it is unreliable and incapable of providing true protection or support. It is not able to dispel danger.

¹⁰¹ Visuddhi.Ṭīkā.2.457

*kāraṇādi viya kāraṇehi, phalena ca vivittato. na hi kāraṇena phalaṃ,
phalena vā kāraṇaṃ sagabbhaṃ tiṭṭhati.*

¹⁰² Visuddhi.2.144 (Vism.2.16.indriyasaccaniddeso.magganiddesakathā).

[English translation by Bhikkhu Ñāṇamoli]



Anassādato (without satisfaction)

One perceives the body as devoid of delight and gratification—there is nothing truly pleasing or satisfying in it.

Samudayato, atthangamato, anassādato, ādīnavato, and nissaraṇato

In the Visuddhimagga section on the forty-two modes of contemplations under the stage of Knowledge of Equanimity towards Formations (*saṅkhārupekkhāñāṇa*), the final five contemplations concern discerning the five aggregates as follows: *samudayato*, *atthaṅgamato*, *anassādato*, *ādīnavato*, and *nissaraṇato*—that is as arising, perishing, without gratification, as danger, and as escape.

These five ways of contemplation—where *assāda* (gratification) appears instead of *anassāda*—occur frequently in the canonical texts.¹⁰³ The Buddha consistently presents them as a unified set of contemplations essential for the realization of Nibbāna. Here, we follow the explanations provided in the commentary on the Brahmajāla Sutta.¹⁰⁴

¹⁰³ Dī.1.16 (DN 1 Brahmajāla Sutta paragraph 36), Ma.3.333 (MN 148 Chachakka Sutta paragraph 425), Saṃ.2.68 (SN 22.74 Samudaya Sutta), and many others.

¹⁰⁴ Dī.Ṭṭha.1.100 (Brahmajālasuttavaṇṇanā, pubbantakappikasassatavāda-vaṇṇanā)

***Samudayato* (arising)**

*avijjāsamudayā vedanāsamudayoti — paccaya-
samudayaṭṭhena vedanākkhandhassa udayaṃ passati.
taṇhāsamudayā vedanāsamudayoti — paccaya-
samudayaṭṭhena vedanākkhandhassa udayaṃ passati.
kammāsamudayā vedanāsamudayoti — paccaya-
samudayaṭṭhena vedanākkhandhassa udayaṃ passati.
phassasamudayā vedanāsamudayoti — paccaya-
samudayaṭṭhena vedanākkhandhassa udayaṃ passati.
nibbattilakkhaṇaṃ passantopi vedanākkhandhassa
udayaṃ passati.¹⁰⁵*

“With the arising of ignorance, there is the arising of feeling”—thus one sees the arising of the feeling aggregate in the sense of the arising of its conditions. “With the arising of craving, there is the arising of feeling”—thus one sees the arising of the feeling aggregate in the sense of the arising of its conditions. “With the arising of kamma, there is the arising of feeling”—thus one sees the arising of the feeling aggregate in the sense of the arising of its conditions. “With the arising of contact, there is the arising of feeling”—thus one sees the arising of the feeling aggregate in the sense of the arising of its conditions.

¹⁰⁵ Paṭisaṃ.54 (mahāvaggo, ñāṇakathā, udayabbayaññaniddeso).



Seeing as well the characteristic of production, one sees the arising of the feeling aggregate.¹⁰⁶

***Atthaṅgamato* (perishing)**

*avijjānirodhā vedanānirodhoti — paccaya-nirodhaṭṭhena vedanākkhandhassa vayaṃ passati. taṇhānirodhā vedanānirodhoti — paccaya-nirodhaṭṭhena vedanākkhandhassa vayaṃ passati. kammanirodhā vedanānirodhoti — paccaya-nirodhaṭṭhena vedanākkhandhassa vayaṃ passati. phassanirodhā vedanānirodhoti — paccaya-nirodhaṭṭhena vedanākkhandhassa vayaṃ passati. vipariṇāmalakkhaṇaṃ passantopi vedanākkhandhassa vayaṃ passati. vedanākkhandhassa vayaṃ passanto imāni pañca lakkhaṇāni passati.*¹⁰⁷

“With the cessation of ignorance, there is the cessation of feeling”—thus one sees the perishing of the feeling aggregate in the sense of the cessation of its conditions. “With the cessation of craving, there is the cessation of feeling”—thus one sees the perishing of the feeling aggregate in the sense of the cessation of its conditions. “With the cessation of kamma, there is the cessation of

¹⁰⁶ Although only the feeling aggregate is mentioned here, all the other aggregates are included in the Paṭisambhidāmagga texts, with the condition of *phassa*(contact) being replaced respectively by *āhāra*(nutriment) in the case of the materiality aggregate, and *nāmarūpa*(mentality-materiality) in the case of the consciousness aggregate.

¹⁰⁷ Paṭisaṃ.54 (mahāvaggo, nāṇakathā, udayabbayañāṇaniddeso)

feeling”—thus one sees the perishing of the feeling aggregate in the sense of the cessation of its conditions. “With the cessation of contact, there is the cessation of feeling”—thus one sees the perishing of the feeling aggregate in the sense of the cessation of its conditions. Seeing as well the characteristic of change, one sees the perishing of the feeling aggregate.

Combining *samudayato* and *atthaṅgamato*, one contemplates the body in two ways:

1. **According to conditions (*paccayato*)**—as illustrated above: with the arising of conditions, the five aggregates arise; with the cessation of conditions, the five aggregates cease. This is in accordance with the general formula of dependent origination:

*imasmim sati idaṃ hoti, imassuppādā idaṃ uppajjati.
imasmim asati idaṃ na hoti, imassa nirodhā idaṃ
nirujjhati.*¹⁰⁸

When this exists, that comes to be; with the arising of this, that arises. When this does not exist, that does not come to be; with the cessation of this, that ceases.

¹⁰⁸ Ma.1.329,331 (MN 38 Mahātaṇhāsāṅkhaya Sutta), Saṃ.1.266 (SN 12.21 Dasabala Sutta), and others.



Thus, one contemplates not only the arising and perishing of the aggregates themselves, but also the arising and perishing of their causes and conditions.¹⁰⁹

2. **Moment by moment (khaṇato)** —as continuously arising and perishing in every moment.

Through these two modes of contemplation—by conditions and by moments—the voidness (*suññatā*) of the body is revealed: voidness is seen both through conditional dependence (the connections of cause and effect) and through the absence of any permanent essence.

These two ways of contemplation correspond to the contemplations *paccayato* (by condition) and *khaṇato* (moment-to-moment) within the stage of Knowledge of Arising and Passing Away (*udayabbayañāṇa*).

***Assādato* (gratification)**

In the Visuddhimagga, the term appears as *anassādato*—“without gratification”, perceiving the body as devoid of delight and satisfaction. However, the Visuddhimagga-mahāṭīkā notes that *anassāda* does not occur in the pāli texts; rather, *assāda* consistently appears in this group of five

¹⁰⁹ Dī.Ṭīkā.2.301 (DN 22 Mahāsatipaṭṭhānasutta-ṭīkā, anāpānapabbavaṇṇanā)

“*samudeti etasmāti samudayo*” – it originates from that; therefore, it is called the origin. According to this definition, *samudaya* refers not only to arising but also to the cause of arising.

contemplations. The Mahāṭṭikā further explains that the next contemplation, *ādīnavato* (as danger), is repeated in order to highlight its opposition to *assāda* (gratification). Thus, *assādato* is the more appropriate term here.

The triad of *assāda* (gratification), *ādīnava* (danger), and *nissaraṇa* (escape) is found in many suttas. The Brahmajāla Sutta commentary quotes the Assāda Sutta of the Saṃyutta Nikāya:

*yaṃ vedanaṃ paṭicca uppajjati sukhaṃ somanassaṃ,
ayaṃ vedanāya assādo.*¹¹⁰

“The pleasure and joy that arise dependent on feeling—
this is the gratification in feeling.”

Although feeling alone is mentioned, all five aggregates are included as objects of contemplation in the Assāda Sutta.

***Ādīnavato* (danger)**

*yaṃ vedanā aniccā dukkhā vipariṇāmadhammā, ayaṃ
vedanāya ādīnavo.*¹¹¹

“That feeling is impermanent, suffering, and subject to
change—this is the danger in feeling.”

According to the Brahmajāla Sutta sub-commentary, the term *anicca* (impermanent) refers to equanimous feeling (*upekkhā vedanā*) or all three types of feeling, showing the

¹¹⁰ Saṃ.2.23-24 (SN 22.26 Assāda Sutta)

¹¹¹ Saṃ.2.24 (SN 22.26 Assāda Sutta)



suffering inherent in formations (*saṅkhāradukkha*). The terms *dukkha* (suffering) and *vipariṇāmadhamma* (subject to change) refer respectively to painful feeling (as *dukkhadukkha*) and pleasant feeling (as *vipariṇāmadukkha*). Alternatively, all three terms can be applied to all feelings without distinction.

Thus, the danger in feelings lies in:

- their impermanence, in the sense of their non-existence after having been (*hurvā abhavaṭṭhena aniccabhāvo*);
- their nature as suffering, in being oppressed by rise and fall (*udayabbayaapaṭipīlanaṭṭhena dukkhabhāvo*); and
- their changeableness, in being subject to both aging and death (*jarāya maraṇena cāti dvedhā vipariṇāmetabbabhāvo*).

These discernments similarly apply to all the other aggregates.

***Nissaraṇato* (having an escape)**

Nissaraṇa refers to Nibbāna, the escape from all defilements and from all aggregates.

*yo vedanāya chandarāgavinayo chandarāgappahānaṃ,
idaṃ vedanāya nissaraṇaṃ.*¹¹²

“The removal and abandonment of desire and lust for feeling—this is the escape from feeling.”

As long as desire and lust bound up with feeling remain, one is attached to feeling; when they are abandoned, one becomes released and detached. Here, “feeling” includes the materiality and mentality that are its co-nascent (*sahajāta*), dependent (*nissaya*), and object (*ārammaṇa*) conditions. Thus, all five clinging aggregates are included.

The five clinging aggregates constitutes the truth of suffering (*dukkhasacca*); ignorance, craving, and related factors that give rise to feeling constitute the truth of origin (*samudaya-sacca*). *atthaṅgama* (perishing) and *nissaraṇa* (escape) imply the truth of cessation (*nirodhasacca*); and understanding feelings as they truly are (*yathābhūtaṃ viditvā*) represents the truth of the path (*maggasacca*).

Hence, all Four Noble Truths are comprehended within this discernment.

¹¹² Saṃ.2.24 (SN 22.26 Assāda Sutta)



Conclusion

These contemplations weaken defilements and craving when applied correctly. They develop the right view that aligns with reality, creating mental strength and clarity. Whether practiced during *saṅkhārupekkhā-ñāṇa* or earlier stages, they guide practitioners toward liberation by revealing the true nature of conditioned existence.

The path requires seeing through pleasant appearances to the underlying reality and overcoming the fear of that reality. This isn't pessimism but wisdom—understanding what truly brings peace and what perpetuates suffering. Through such contemplation, the mind naturally becomes balanced and equanimous toward all phenomena and thus turns toward the unconditioned peace of Nibbāna.

Sādhū Sādhū Sādhū!